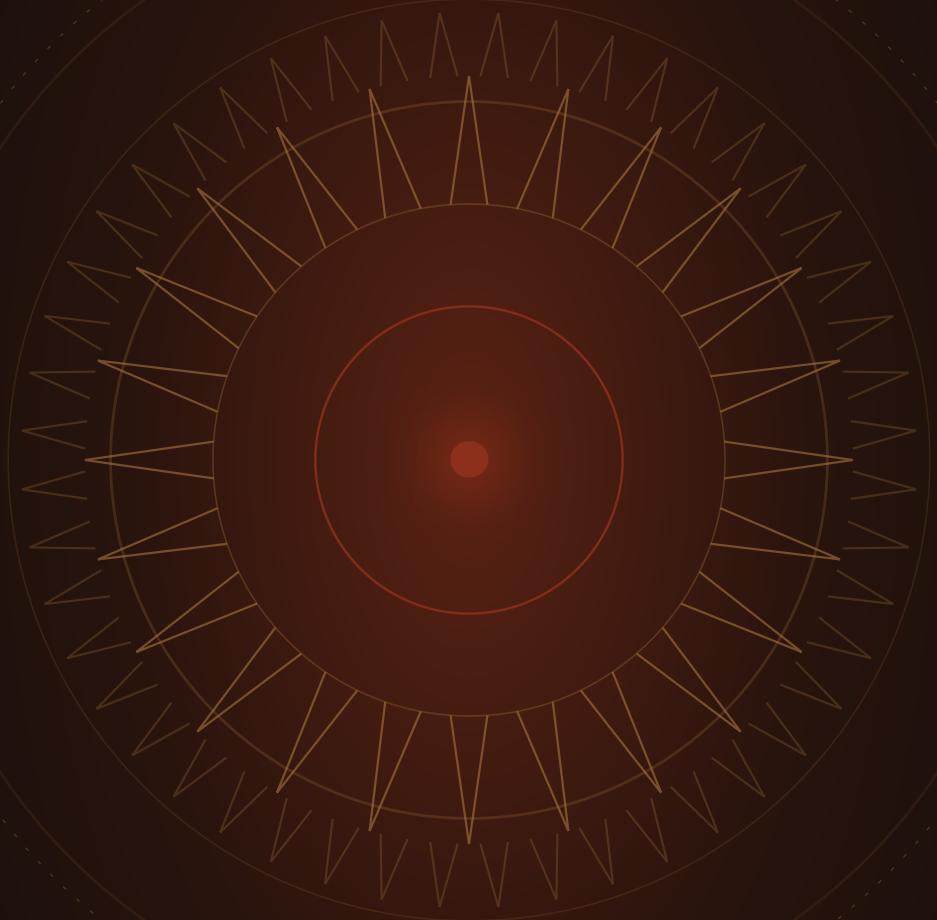
A DISSERTATION IN PHILOSOPHY AND GAME STUDIES



THE PHARMACOLOGY OF THE NAMELESS

Allomnesia, Allothanasia, and the Ethics of Reappropriated Finitude in Planescape: Torment (*Black Isle Studios, 1999*)

SEPTEMBER 2026

“What can change the nature of a man?”

RAVEL PUZZLEWELL

ABSTRACT

Planescape: Torment (Black Isle Studios/Interplay, 1999), designed under Chris Avellone's lead with Colin McComb as principal co-designer and set in TSR's Planescape cosmology, is widely treated as the paradigmatic philosophical role-playing game. Its philosophy, however, has usually been inventoried by theme (memory, identity, belief, regret) rather than reconstructed as an argument. This dissertation reconstructs that argument.

It contends that the game's organizing problem is not immortality but substitution. The Nameless One persists by means of two supplements in the Derridean sense. The first is a *pharmakon*: the inscriptive and testimonial prosthesis (tattoo, journal, the recollection of others) that stands in for his memory. The second is a *pharmakos*: the anonymous dead whose deaths stand in for his own and whose shadows pursue him. I name these conditions *allomnesia* (memory held by another) and *allothanasia* (death borne by another). Together they form a single economy of externalized finitude, in which the persistence of one self is financed by debts that others carry.

Chapter I reconstructs the genealogy of the setting's doxastic cosmology, the principle that belief is constitutive of reality. It traces that principle through Dantean, Swedenborgian, Miltonic, Feuerbachian, and pragmatist antecedents, and through the alignment metaphysics of Poul Anderson and Michael Moorcock. Chapter II reconstructs the game's theory of personal identity against Locke, Reid, Hume, Parfit, and Buddhist *anattā*. Chapter III reconstructs its ontology of conviction against Berkeley, James, Vaihinger, Austin, Searle, and Borges. Chapter IV reads the fifteen factions as a *disputatio* among historical philosophical schools. Chapter V reads the companions as philosophical personae. Chapter VI places allothanasia in a lineage running from Euripides' *Alcestis* and the death of Enkidu through Kierkegaard, Heidegger, Levinas, Freud, and Lacan, and within the political theology of Schmitt, Kantorowicz, and Agamben. Because the first incarnation struck his bargain in order to atone, it also shows this economy of borrowed death financing even the wish to make amends.

Chapter VII argues that the game extends this structure to its own medium. The player's finite time is the extradiegetic substrate of the avatar's resurrection, so that the respawn, ethically inert in most games, is revealed as a transfer of mortality. Chapter VIII proposes the dissertation's central concept, *thanatic oikeiōsis*: a reconstruction of the Stoic doctrine of appropriation as the assumption of one's own liabilities. This is offered as the game's answer to its governing question, "What can change the nature of a man?" The answer is not the recovery of an essence but the retraction of costs one has pushed onto others.

The Lockean forensic self confines accountability to what is remembered. Parfitian reductionism discounts desert across weakened psychological connection. Against both, the game stages a Parfitian metaphysics in the service of a non-Parfitian ethics. Its final image, a man walking into an eternal war to which an unremembered crime has sentenced him, is read as the exact inversion of Le Guin's parable of Omelas: not the one who walks away, but the one who walks toward.

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PROLEGOMENON



0

INTRODUCTION

The Question Before the Question

0.1 Status Quaestionis

Few works in the history of the computer role-playing game have been so often called philosophical, and so rarely read as philosophy, as *Planescape: Torment*. Developed by Black Isle Studios and released by Interplay on 12 December 1999, it runs on a modified version of the Infinity Engine that BioWare built for *Baldur's Gate*, and it is set in the Planescape multiverse of *Advanced Dungeons & Dragons*. The game achieved little commercial success yet drew broad critical acclaim and a lasting cult status. Avellone later recalled learning that it had in fact turned a profit, though a small one next to *Baldur's Gate*.

Its textual mass is itself a datum. The script exceeds 800,000 words, and Avellone has voiced some regret that the weight placed on dialogue came at the expense of other systems such as combat.

The critical vocabulary that has grown up around the work (memory, identity, belief, regret, mortality) is accurate as an inventory and insufficient as interpretation. A theme is not a thesis. To say the game is "about" personal identity says where it looks, not what it sees. The usual method of its philosophical reception is to pair motifs with philosophers' names: Locke for memory, Sartre for self-making, the Buddha for the Dustmen. That method repeats, at the level of criticism, the very operation the game diagnoses in its protagonist: the substitution of external tokens for an internal work of recollection.

This dissertation proceeds otherwise. It treats *Planescape: Torment* not as an anthology of allusions but as an apparatus for running thought experiments that philosophy has so far only been able to narrate. Locke's prince and cobbler, Reid's brave officer, Parfit's teletransporter and fission cases, Williams's lorry driver and Elina Makropulos, Nozick's experience machine: each is a miniature fiction whose force depends on the reader's willingness to inhabit a counterfactual.

The role-playing game converts such counterfactuals from objects of contemplation into environments of decision. Its distinctive contribution to philosophical knowledge is therefore modal rather than doctrinal. It does not tell us what personal identity is. It compels a player to act *as if* a given theory were true, and to discover in the first person, across dozens of hours and hundreds of branching choices, what follows. The governing question here is accordingly not which philosophies the game contains. It is which propositions its structure is built to test, and which of them it corroborates or refutes.

0.2 Corpus, Authorship, and the Author-Function

The object of study is the game as released in 1999. It is supplemented by the *Enhanced Edition* (Beamdog, 2017) and by the surviving pre-production documentation.

The attribution with which this study was commissioned, a game "designed and written by Chris Avellone and Colin McComb," should be read, following Foucault, as an author-function rather than a biographical fact (Foucault 1969). An author-function is a principle of grouping, valuation, and interpretive constraint that organizes a dispersed and collective practice under proper names. Empirically, the practice was plural:

- A 47-page document setting out the game's premise and vision was written in 1997 to pitch the project to Interplay's management. Once Interplay held the rights to a Planescape RPG, Avellone was made lead designer.
- His simultaneous work on *Fallout* 2 led him to reconsider what dialogue could do.
- The working title was "Planescape: Last Rites," which had to be dropped because another game already bore the name "Last Rites."

McComb's own account places him with unusual precision. Only months out of TSR, he became the team's authority on Planescape lore and Avellone's second. From Avellone he absorbed how to structure dialogue, how to build real reactivity, and how to compress ideas for maximum impact. He adds that both men loved the setting and both saw where departing from it would serve the story better.

The work also belongs to a licensed cosmos that neither designer invented. Planescape was created for TSR by David "Zeb" Cook (1994), with a visual idiom set by Tony DiTerlizzi's illustrations. After Zeb Cook left TSR, McComb and Monte Cook became the line's principal designers.

That last fact bears directly on interpretation, because McComb's pre-Interplay corpus is part of the game's metaphysical apparatus:

- His Planescape credits include *Planes of Law*, *Planes of Conflict*, *Hellbound: The Blood War*, *On Hallowed Ground*, *Faces of Evil: The Fiends*, and *The Great Modron March*.
- Through this work he became the setting's specialist on fiends and the infernal planes, treating fiends almost anthropologically, as foul but legitimate societies rather than as menaces to be exterminated.
- *On Hallowed Ground*, published in October 1996, set out the divine realms of twenty pantheons and tried to settle how petitioners and the afterlife actually work.

The cosmological infrastructure on which *Torment*'s ending depends was therefore written in significant part by one of its designers before the game existed. That infrastructure comprises the Blood War as the destination of the damned, belief as the currency of divinity, and the petitioner as a soul reshaped by its conviction. The biographical detail that McComb graduated from Lake Forest College in 1991 with a degree in philosophy is not an explanatory key. It does corroborate what the texts already show: a design practice for which cosmology was an argumentative medium.

Avellone's retrospective statements supply the other half of the author-function:

- He has described *Torment* as the accumulation of years of unrealized adventures and characters, for which a setting that accommodated almost anything was an ideal repository. He credits whatever seems deep in it to heavy reading, while judging it modest beside much published fiction and noting only that games had seldom gone that far.
- He has said that his impulse to invert conventions stemmed largely from antipathy in the Planescape case, and from indignation at the unfairness of the Force's rules in his *Star Wars* work.
- He has formulated a design axiom whose philosophical consequences this dissertation will pursue at length: players are selfish, the experience gets better the more it is made about them, and so almost everything in *Torment* was built to concern the player.

A single interrogative form recurs across both designers' later work. In *Knights of the Old Republic II* (2004), Kreia interrogates the Force as a manipulative economy. McComb served as creative lead on *Torment: Tides of Numenera* (inXile, 2017), which is organized around the question of what one life matters. This recurrence confirms that the question-form itself is the author-function's signature. What the attribution "Avellone and McComb" names, then, is a discursive practice: a cosmology interrogated through a single protagonist whose existence is its test case.

0.3 Method: Modal Hermeneutics and the Creation of Concepts

Three methodological commitments follow.

The ontology of the text. A branching game is not a narrative but a structured space of narratives. Its designers author not a sequence but, in Salen and Zimmerman's terms, a space of possibility (Salen and Zimmerman 2004).

Interpretation must therefore be modal. Its object is neither a single playthrough nor an idealized "complete" reading. It is the distribution of what stays fixed and what varies across the set of admissible paths.

The right image is not the book but Leibniz's Palace of the Fates at the close of the *Theodicy*: a pyramid of apartments in which each chamber shows a different Sextus Tarquinius living out a different possible world (Leibniz 1710, §§413–417). Borges's garden of forking times, in which every choice is taken and every outcome coexists (Borges 1941), serves equally well. The analogy is exact in a way neither author could have anticipated. *Torment*'s protagonist is himself a gallery of Sextuses: a succession of incarnations, each of which lived a different possible life of the same body. The rule this licenses is simple. In a modal text, an argument is carried by its invariants and a question by its variables. What no path lets the player avoid is what the work asserts. What every path lets the player decide is what the work asks.

Genealogy and its discipline. The study distinguishes three orders of relation:

- **Attested sources:** the Planescape and *AD&D* corpus, and the designers' own statements.
- **Structural antecedents:** works that share a problem-structure with the game, whether or not any causal link exists.
- **Philosophical interlocutors:** arguments the game can be shown to test, corroborate, or defeat.

The distinction guards against what Quentin Skinner called the mythologies of doctrine and of prolepsis. The first attributes to authors coherent systems they never held. The second reads earlier works in light of significances that only became available later (Skinner 1969). Where this dissertation compares *Torment* to Borges, Lem, Wolfe, or Le Guin, it asserts an affinity of problem, not a lineage of influence, unless the lineage is documented.

The status of the dissertation's vocabulary. If philosophy is, as Deleuze and Guattari argued, the creation of concepts adequate to problems that existing concepts misdescribe (Deleuze and Guattari 1991), then each neologism introduced here must be justified by a misdescription it corrects.

- "Immortality" misdescribes the Nameless One's condition. He dies continually; what he lacks is not death but ownership of it.
- "Amnesia" misdescribes his memory. His past is not lost but relocated into scar tissue, ink, journals, and above all other people.

Allothanasia (from ἄλλος, "other," and θάνατος, "death") names the condition in which one's death is suffered by another. *Allomnesia* names the condition in which one's memory is held by another. *Thanatic oikeiōsis*, developed in Chapter VIII, names their reversal.

The title condenses this apparatus. In "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968), Derrida showed that the *Phaedrus* condemns writing as a *pharmakon*: at once remedy and poison, a prosthesis for memory that weakens the faculty it supplements. He also showed that Plato's chain of signification links *pharmakon* silently to *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled from the city in times of crisis. The word *pharmakos* never appears in Plato's text, yet it haunts its logic. This dissertation uses *pharmakos* in an extended sense, for one whose death, and not only whose expulsion, stands in for another's; §6.2 sets out what the historical rite involved and where this usage goes beyond it. Bernard Stiegler later generalized the first term into a "pharmacology" of technics, in which every externalization of memory is both a condition of individuation and a threat to it (Stiegler 2010).

The Nameless One stands exactly where the two terms of Derrida's chain intersect. His memory is supplemented by a *pharmakon*: tattoos, journals, testimony. His death is supplemented by *pharmakoi*: the anonymous dead who perish in his place. To read *Torment* is to read a pharmacology of the self in both senses at once.

0.4 The Argument

The dissertation advances six propositions.

First, the organizing problem is substitution rather than immortality. The philosophical literature on deathlessness has mostly asked what endless life would do to the one who lives it: whether it would exhaust desire, dissolve character, or drain choice of weight. That literature runs from Swift's Struldbrugs through Čapek's *The Makropulos Affair* (1922), Beauvoir's *All Men Are Mortal* (1946), and Borges's "The Immortal" (1947), to Bernard Williams's "The Makropulos Case" (1973). *Torment* asks a different and more unsettling question: what one's deathlessness does to others. Its answer, that each resurrection is paid for by a death elsewhere, moves the problem of immortality from the register of tedium to the register of expropriation.

Second, the self the game constructs is palimpsestic and distributed. The Nameless One's past survives not in consciousness but in inscriptions and in other minds. His identity must be reassembled from outside, out of testimony, grievance,

love, and ink. This is allomnesia. It places the game in dialogue with externalist and prosthetic theories of memory: Plato's *Phaedrus*, Freud's Mystic Writing-Pad, Derrida's *pharmakon*, Stiegler's tertiary retention, and Clark and Chalmers's extended mind.

Third, a cosmology in which belief makes reality turns the ethics of belief into an ethics of worldmaking. In such a cosmos, the dispute between Clifford and James is no longer about whether one may believe beyond the evidence. It is about the responsibility of authoring reality, and every act of belief becomes a political act.

Fourth, the Nameless One's deathlessness is a sovereign exception financed by anonymous and unsacrificed deaths. The shadows who hunt him are bare life in Agamben's sense: lives that can be taken without the act counting as either homicide or sacrifice. His persistence reproduces, within a single biography, the structure of political theology that Kantorowicz, Schmitt, and Agamben reconstructed for the sovereign. That the exception was sought for the sake of atonement, as the game eventually reveals, makes it no less an exception and its cost no less real.

Fifth, the game extends this structure to its own medium. In most games the avatar dies so that the player may learn without dying. In *Torment*, others die so that the avatar may persist, and the player's finite time is the extradiegetic substrate that underwrites that persistence. To my knowledge, it is the first major work in its medium to make the respawn the object of sustained moral reflection. The respawn is the resurrection mechanic on which the medium's pedagogy of failure depends.

Sixth, the game resolves not in recovered essence or extinction but in reappropriated finitude. It offers neither the recovery of a lost essence nor the extinction its Dustmen preach. It offers the retraction into the self of the memory and the death that others have carried for it. This cannot restore presence. The game never specifies his original crime. On one optional path he recovers his true name, but the name settles nothing: the ending asks the same of him with it or without it, and no path ever discloses it to the player. The reappropriation is therefore ethical rather than metaphysical, an assumption of liability rather than a return to origin. I call it *thanatic oikeiōsis* and argue that it is the game's answer to Ravel Puzzlewell's question. What can change the nature of a man? Not what he remembers, nor what he believes, nor the time he can buy, but his taking back what others have borne for him.

0.5 Architecture

- **Chapter I** reconstructs the genealogy of the game's cosmos: the spatialization of alignment in *AD&D*, the doxastic plasticity Planescape introduced, the three planar axioms, Sigil as a philosophical form, and the literary strata (Gnostic, classical, modernist, Borgesian, fantastic) against which the game's innovations become legible.
- **Chapter II, "Allomnesia,"** reconstructs the game's theory of personal identity through Locke's forensic person, Reid's brave officer, Hume's bundle, Parfit's reductionism, and the *Milindapañha*'s chariot. It reconstructs the game's theory of memory through Plato's *pharmakon*, Nietzsche's mnemotechnics of pain, Freud's repetition compulsion and Mystic Writing-Pad, Kierkegaard's contrast between recollection and repetition, Stiegler's tertiary retention, and the extended mind. It closes with a theory of the name, running from Russell's descriptions and Kripke's rigid designators to the apophatic tradition.
- **Chapter III, "Doxastic Ontology,"** develops the ethics of worldmaking through Adahn, Vhailor, and the sliding of Curst, in comparison with Lem's *Solaris*, Dick's *Ubik*, and Borges's Tlön.
- **Chapter IV, "The Polis of Doctrines,"** reads the fifteen factions as a disputation among historical schools, and Sigil's sovereignty through Schmitt, Lefort, and Kafka.
- **Chapter V, "Personae,"** reads the companions as philosophical figures: Morte and the ethics of the lie; Dak'kon and the epistemology of faith; Annah and hybrid embodiment; Fall-from-Grace and virtue as the refusal of nature; Ignus and the Promethean complex; Nordom and the individuation of the monad; Vhailor and justice without a subject.
- **Chapter VI, "Allothanasia,"** develops the central diagnosis. Its key materials are Heidegger's claim that no one can take another's dying from him, Levinas on substitution, Kierkegaard's torment, Freud's death drive, Lacan's zone between two deaths, Kantorowicz, Agamben, Girard, Nietzsche's genealogy of debt, Williams's agent-regret, and Le Guin's Omelas.
- **Chapter VII, "Ludic Allothanasia,"** extends the diagnosis to the medium, in dialogue with Huizinga, Caillois, Aarseth, Murray, Juul, Bogost, and Sicart, and in comparison with works from *Legacy of Kain: Soul Reaver* and *Xenogears* to *Undertale*, *Hades*, *Outer Wilds*, *NieR: Automata*, and *Disco Elysium*.
- **Chapter VIII, "Thanatic Oikeiōsis,"** builds the original thesis from Stoic, Ricoeurian, Arendtian, and Korsgaardian materials, tests it against Buddhist,

Parfitian, Foucauldian, and Derridean objections, and answers Ravel's question. A conclusion, a select bibliography, and a list of keywords close the study.

CHAPTER



I

GENEALOGIES OF THE WHEEL

Sources, Cosmology, and the Doxastic Multiverse

1.1 From Moral Geography to Metaphysical Politics

The cosmos of *Planescape: Torment* is the product of three successive transformations of the *Dungeons & Dragons* afterlife. Each altered the relation between ethics and space.

The first transformation was the spatialization of alignment. The original *Dungeons & Dragons* (1974) sorted beings along a single axis of Law and Chaos. It inherited that axis from Poul Anderson's *Three Hearts and Three Lions* (1953/1961) and from Michael Moorcock's Elric and Eternal Champion sequences, in which cosmic Law and cosmic Chaos contend through mortal proxies. Gygax then added a second, orthogonal axis of Good and Evil, first sketched in *The Strategic Review* (1976) and codified in *Advanced Dungeons & Dragons* as nine alignments. The result was a moral grid.

Three texts then gave that grid a topography: Gygax's planar essay in *The Dragon* (1977), the appendix on the known planes in the *Players Handbook* (1978), and Jeff Grubb's *Manual of the Planes* (1987). The Outer Planes, arranged as a Great Wheel, became regions in which each alignment possessed its own afterlife. The outcome was a moral geography in the strictest sense. Ethical dispositions acquired extension, adjacency, and distance. One could walk from Lawful Good toward Lawful Neutral as one walks from one province to the next.

The theological antecedents of this arrangement are ancient; its immediate models are literary.

Dante's *Commedia* supplied the template of an afterlife ordered by the qualitative structure of sin and virtue, together with the principle of *contrapasso*: punishment as the self-manifestation of the deed. "Così s'osserva in me lo contrapasso," says the decapitated Bertran de Born (*Inferno* XXVIII.142). He carries his severed head as a lantern because he severed father from son.

Swedenborg's *Heaven and Hell* (1758) supplied something subtler and, for Planescape, more consequential. No one, on his account, is cast into hell by divine sentence. Each spirit, freed at death from the constraints of outward life, gravitates by the pull of its "ruling love" to the society that corresponds to it. The afterlife is therefore not a verdict imposed but a disposition consummated (Swedenborg 1758, §§545–550). The *AD&D* petitioner is Swedenborgian before it is anything else: the dead soul that arrives, stripped of most of its mortal memory, on the plane matching its conviction and

is gradually conformed to it. The detail of stripped memory will prove decisive. In this cosmology, to die is ordinarily to forget. The Nameless One, who forgets at every death but never leaves his body, is a petitioner who has not been permitted to depart.

The second transformation was Planescape's reconception of the Wheel as doxastically plastic (1994). The Gygaxian planes were fixed containers of alignment. Planescape made them responsive to belief:

- The Outer Planes are shaped by the convictions of their inhabitants.
- The strength of the Powers is a function of worship.
- The gate-towns of the Outlands, each set beside a portal to an Outer Plane, drift into that plane when their citizens' prevailing belief comes to match it.

Torment stages precisely such a drift. The gate-town of Curst, saturated with betrayal, slides into Carceri, the prison plane: contrapasso at the scale of a municipality. The moral grid thus became a moral field of forces. It was no longer a map of where souls go but a medium that beliefs deform.

The third transformation was political. Planescape embodied its doxastic metaphysics in institutions: the fifteen factions of Sigil. Each is a philosophy with a headquarters, a membership, a civic function, and a theory of the multiverse. Because belief shapes reality, their contest is not merely a debate but a struggle over the authorship of the cosmos. Metaphysics becomes politics by other means.

Torment inherits all three transformations and adds a fourth, which occupies the rest of this dissertation. It relocates the whole apparatus (moral geography, doxastic plasticity, factional politics) into a single biography. The protagonist's forgetting and deathlessness thereby become cosmological events with distributed costs.

1.2 The Doxastic Principle and Its Antecedents

The principle that belief constitutes reality has a long and heterogeneous prehistory. The specificity of Planescape's version emerges only by contrast with its antecedents.

The Satanic statement. The principle's most compact statement in English belongs to Milton's Satan: "The mind is its own place, and in it self / Can make a Heav'n of Hell, a Hell of Heav'n" (*Paradise Lost* I.254–255).

The fallen archangel asserts, as defiance, the sovereignty of mind over location. The poem ironizes the boast in advance of its later confession, "Which way I flie is Hell; my self am Hell" (IV.75). Planescape, however, takes the defiance at its word and raises it

into physics. In the Outer Planes the mind is, within limits, its own place. It is not incidental that the setting's founding axiom was first spoken by the archetypal rebel. That origin writes into the multiverse the possibility that the most radical conviction is also the most dangerous. Satan's later confession is also the most exact description of the Nameless One in Western literature before 1999: a being who carries his hell with him because he has made it.

The theological statement. The theological version of the principle is Feuerbach's. In *The Essence of Christianity* (1841), God is the objectified essence of the human species: human predicates projected, alienated, and worshipped as another. Marx's 1844 manuscripts draw the economic corollary: the more a person puts into God, the less they keep for themselves.

Planescape performs a strange operation on this critique. It grants Feuerbach's genealogy, that divine power derives from believers, while denying his conclusion. The gods are nonetheless real, causally efficacious, and dangerous. Call this *Feuerbachian realism*: projection with ontological consequences. The Athar, the faction that holds the Powers to be frauds, stand where Feuerbach's critic would stand in a world where the critic's genealogy is right and his ontology wrong.

Torment treats the divine obliquely. The Lady of Pain bars the Powers from Sigil, and the game's cosmic antagonist is not a god. It is the protagonist's own alienated mortality, which has come to regard itself as transcendent. Chapter VI will show that this reverses Feuerbach's scheme. What the Nameless One projects outward and lets rule him is not his infinitude but his finitude. Transcendence, in *Torment*, is made of alienated death.

The pragmatist statement. The pragmatist version belongs to William James. In "Is Life Worth Living?" (1895) he called visible nature "a moral multiverse, as one might call it, and not a moral universe." In "The Will to Believe" (1896) he argued that in some domains belief contributes to fact rather than merely answering it, since "faith in a fact can help create the fact." His examples include the mutual confidence without which the individually brave passengers of a train are robbed by a handful of highwaymen who can count on one another.

Sociology compressed the insight into the theorem that bears W. I. Thomas's name: "If men define situations as real, they are real in their consequences" (Thomas and Thomas 1928, 572). Philosophy developed it into theories of performative utterance (Austin 1962), social construction (Berger and Luckmann 1966), collective intentionality (Searle 1995), and the looping effects by which classifications transform the people classified (Hacking 1995).

All of these respect a boundary that Planescape abolishes. For Searle, collective intentionality constitutes institutional facts (money, marriage, property, office) against a background of brute facts that no belief can alter. In the Outer Planes, collective belief reaches through that boundary and constitutes brute facts: topography, climate, the location of a town, the substance of a realm. Planescape is social ontology made cosmic. I call its metaphysics *doxastic realism*: the thesis that, within a determinate domain, collective conviction is a physical cause.

Literary precedents. The nearest literary precedent is Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940). There, the idealist physics of an invented planet generates *hrönir*: secondary objects produced by expectation, found by those who expect to find them, their shape conforming to hope. The nearest comic precedent is Terry Pratchett's *Small Gods* (1992). A deity reduced to the form of a tortoise discovers that his church's institutional power has outlived genuine belief in him, so the god starves while his priesthood thrives.

Torment contains its own *hrön*. A protagonist who lies often enough that his name is Adahn eventually meets a man named Adahn, called into existence by the circulation of a falsehood. The episode is presented almost as a jest, but it is the game's purest demonstration of doxastic realism. It also has a disquieting corollary that later chapters develop. In such a cosmos a lie is not merely a false statement but a creative act, and the liar is answerable not only for deception but for ontology.

Limits of the principle. Two further antecedents mark its limits:

- **Berkeley's immaterialism** (1710) makes perception constitutive of being (*esse est percipi*) but grounds the world's persistence in God's uninterrupted perception. Planescape's belief-plasticity is regional, partial, and without a divine guarantor. It governs the Outer Planes rather than the Prime Material, and it admits competition, drift, and failure.
- **Vaihinger's *Philosophy of "As If"*** (1911) makes consciously false fictions indispensable instruments of thought. Planescape collapses the distinction between the useful fiction and the real: a fiction believed widely enough ceases to be one.

Between Berkeley's theocentric idealism and Vaihinger's instrumental fictionalism, Planescape occupies a third position. It is a democratic and agonistic ontology, in which reality is the provisional outcome of competing convictions.

The consequence for ethics. The consequence is decisive, and it governs Chapter III. In 1877 W. K. Clifford held that believing anything on insufficient evidence is always and everywhere wrong. James replied that where evidence cannot decide and

the option is live, forced, and momentous, we may and must believe by passion. Both assumed that belief answers to a reality it does not make. In a doxastically realist cosmos the question changes its nature. The issue is no longer whether the world warrants one's belief, but what world one's belief will bring about. The ethics of belief becomes the ethics of worldmaking.

1.3 The Three Planar Axioms: Center, Ring, Triad

Planescape codifies its cosmology in three axioms that function, within the fiction, as laws of the multiverse: the Center of All, the Unity of Rings, and the Rule of Three. Each has a philosophical ancestry, and each is structurally active in *Torment*.

The Center of All holds that, the multiverse being infinite, every point in it may be regarded as its center. Its ancestry runs as follows:

- The twelfth-century pseudo-Hermetic *Liber XXIV philosophorum*, whose second proposition defines God as "sphaera infinita cuius centrum est ubique, circumferentia nusquam."
- Nicholas of Cusa's *De docta ignorantia* (1440, II.12).
- Bruno's infinite universe (1584).
- Pascal's application of the formula to nature itself (*Pensées*, Laf. 199).
- Borges's "Pascal's Sphere" (1951), which traces the metaphor's migration from theology to cosmology to vertigo.

In Planescape the formula makes one final migration, from cosmology into perspectivism. A decentered multiverse is the metaphysical condition for irreducible standpoints: Leibniz's monads, each mirroring the whole from its own point of view, or Nietzsche's "nur ein perspektivisches Sehen, nur ein perspektivisches 'Erkennen'" (*Zur Genealogie der Moral* III §12). It is therefore the condition for the factional pluralism of Sigil, where fifteen philosophies each claim, with equal cosmological right, to occupy the center.

Torment introduces into this axiom a tension the setting alone does not contain. The computer role-playing game is a genre organized around a single center, the avatar for whom the world is arranged. Avellone's design axiom, cited above, makes that centering explicit and deliberate. The game thus stages a collision between its cosmological axiom (every point is the center) and its generic axiom (one point is the center). It resolves the collision not by suppressing either term but by turning their contradiction into the moral problem of the plot.

The world of *Torment* has in fact been bent around its protagonist. A remarkable proportion of the significant people he meets were used, loved, bound, taught, betrayed, or damned by one of his former selves. The landscape is strewn with his caches, his traps, his corpses, and his victims. The genre's egocentrism, elsewhere an unexamined convenience, is revealed here as a form of damage. The Center of All teaches that no one is the center; the Nameless One's biography shows what it costs everyone else when someone behaves as if he were.

The Unity of Rings holds that the multiverse tends toward circularity. Sigil is a ring-shaped city above the infinite Spire; the Outlands' gate-towns encircle that Spire; the Outer Planes form a wheel. *Torment* multiplies the figure. The githzerai scripture Dak'kon carries is the Unbroken Circle of Zerthimon, and the protagonist's existence is a circuit of death and return. In multiplying it, the game activates the ring's two opposed philosophical meanings.

On one side, the ring is the figure of bondage to repetition. It is the Buddhist *bhavacakra*, the wheel of conditioned existence; Ixion on his burning wheel; the Nietzschean "Ring der Ringe," the "Ring der Wiederkunft" celebrated in the "Seven Seals" of *Also sprach Zarathustra* (III), which one must will in order not to be crushed by it.

On the other side, the ring is the figure of ethical extension. In a fragment preserved by Stobaeus (4.27.23), the Stoic Hierocles pictures each person enclosed by concentric circles: self, household, kin, fellow citizens, humanity. He assigns ethics the task of drawing the outer circles inward. Chapter VIII will argue that the game's moral structure is precisely the conversion of the first ring into the second. It moves from the vicious circle of a self that persists at others' expense to the virtuous circle of a self that appropriates its own finitude and so releases those it had consumed.

The Rule of Three holds that significant things occur in triads. Its ancestry is too diffuse to trace to a single origin: the Christian Trinity, Plato's tripartite soul, Peirce's firstness, secondness, and thirdness, Dumézil's trifunctional ideology. In passing, the common attribution to Hegel of the schema "thesis–antithesis–synthesis" should be corrected; it belongs rather to Fichte and to Chalybäus's exposition of Hegel.

Torment's most important triad is the division of the protagonist, in the Fortress of Regrets, into the shades of three prior incarnations:

- a Good incarnation, remorseful and compassionate, who proves to be the first: the man who made the bargain with Ravel;
- a Paranoid incarnation, defended and hostile;
- a Practical incarnation, strategic, cold, and supremely instrumental.

The game invites triadic readings of this division: Plato's reason, spirit, and appetite; Freud's superego, id, and ego; Lacan's Real, Imaginary, and Symbolic. A responsible interpretation should register both the invitation and the game's refusal to complete it. What matters is not which triad the incarnations instantiate. It is that the self appears as a plurality that can be summoned, interrogated, and reabsorbed. Applied to a person, the Rule of Three yields not a synthesis but a council.

1.4 Sigil: The City as Philosophical Form

If the Outer Planes are the setting's metaphysics, Sigil is its phenomenology: the lived form of a doxastic multiverse.

A city of thresholds. The name derives from the Latin *sigillum*, a seal or sign, and the city is literally a semiotic machine. Any bounded opening (an archway, a window frame, the gap between two barrels) may be a portal to another plane. It opens only to the correct key, which may be an object, a gesture, a thought, or an emotion. Sigil is thus a city made entirely of thresholds whose meaning stays latent until the right sign is supplied: a hermeneutic topology in which every aperture is a text awaiting its reader. Its inhabitants call it the Cage, a name to which the prison-plane Carceri will later give an etymological echo.

In the *Arcades Project* materials, Walter Benjamin lamented that modern life had grown poor in threshold experiences, the rites and zones of transition that older societies surrounded with ceremony. Sigil is a counter-modern utopia of the threshold, a city where transition is everywhere and passage is the ordinary condition of existence.

The unfinished last rite. This observation gains ethnographic precision beside the game's original title. The project was first called "Planescape: Last Rites", and "last rites" names the terminal instance of what Arnold van Gennep (1909) called *rites de passage*. These are ceremonies that carry a person across a boundary of status through three phases: separation, liminality, and incorporation.

Victor Turner's analysis of the liminal phase (1967) describes the ritual subject as structurally "betwixt and between." Such a subject is often treated as invisible or dead, associated with decomposition, darkness, and the grave, and stripped of name and status. The Nameless One wakes on a mortuary slab without name, rank, possessions, or memory. He is a liminal persona in exactly Turner's sense, and the Mortuary where his every life begins is the site of a rite of passage interrupted and repeated without

completion. Read through van Gennep and Turner, the whole narrative performs an unfinished last rite: a passage whose incorporation phase, entry into the status of the dead, has been endlessly deferred.

Torment as blocked passage. Replacing *Last Rites* with *Torment* shifts the emphasis from ritual passage to its blockage. Latin *tormentum* derives from *torquere*, "to twist." It named both a torsion-powered siege engine and an instrument of torture, and it denotes a force stored by twisting: tension without release.

Kierkegaard supplies the concept that makes the etymology philosophical. In *The Sickness unto Death* (1849), despair is the sickness of a self that relates itself wrongly to itself. Its peculiar torment is that it cannot consummate itself in death: to be sick unto death is to be forever dying without being able to die (Kierkegaard 1849, Part One). No formula describes the Nameless One more exactly. Whether or not by design, the title is a Kierkegaardian diagnosis. Torment is the condition of a self that cannot reach its end and therefore cannot become itself.

A sovereign who refuses to be a god. The Lady of Pain, the city's ruler:

- never speaks;
- bars the Powers from entry;
- punishes those who worship her;
- exiles transgressors into pocket labyrinths, the Mazes, from which escape is rare.

Chapter IV will read this sovereignty through three frames: Carl Schmitt's definition of the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception (1922); Kafka's parable of the unapproachable Law; and, above all, Claude Lefort's account of modern democracy as the regime in which the locus of power becomes an empty place that no person or group can occupy as its own (Lefort 1983). The Lady's silence and her ban on worship keep the center of Sigil's political space empty of transcendence, and the factions contend around a void they cannot fill. Sigil is in this sense a democracy of doctrines under a sovereign whose only doctrine is the refusal to become one.

A necro-economy. Sigil also has a material economy whose relevance to the argument is easily underestimated. In the Hive, the city's slum, a guild of Collectors scours the streets for corpses and sells them to the Dustmen. The Dustmen's Mortuary processes the dead and works reanimated corpses as unpaid labor. The historical analogues are two. One is the resurrection men of early nineteenth-century Britain, who dug up the newly buried and sold the bodies to anatomists. In Edinburgh in 1828 William Burke and William Hare went further: they murdered sixteen people and sold the bodies to the anatomist Robert Knox. The scandal helped force the Anatomy Act

(1832), which supplied the dissecting rooms instead with the unclaimed bodies of people who died in workhouses and hospitals, overwhelmingly the poor. The other is the economy of refuse-collection anatomized by Henry Mayhew in *London Labour and the London Poor* (1851). Marx's figure of capital as dead labor that lives, vampire-like, only by absorbing living labor (*Capital* I, "The Working Day") finds a grotesquely literal referent in the Mortuary.

The Nameless One enters this necro-economy as its anomaly: the corpse that will not stay sold, the product that walks back off the dissecting table. The anomaly conceals a deeper conformity. Chapter VI will show that his returns are themselves financed by an invisible traffic in the dead. He is not the exception to Sigil's economy of expendable bodies but its most extreme beneficiary.

The names as compressed arguments.

- **Morte**, the floating skull who is the protagonist's first companion, bears the Italian word for death. He performs, as a talking *memento mori*, the office of a psychopomp: Dante's Virgil reduced to a cranium and a line of patter.
- **Ignus**, the burning mage, is fire itself (*ignis*).
- **Nordom**, the modron severed from his collective, bears an anagram of his kind's name: an individual constituted by rearranging his species' letters.
- **Carceri** is the prison (*carcer*); **Curst** is cursed; **Rubikon**, the modron maze, recalls the river whose crossing admits no return.
- **Trias**, the fallen deva and betrayer, carries the triad in his name.
- **Ravel Puzzlewell**, the night hag who made the protagonist deathless, bears one of English's rare contronyms: to *ravel* is both to entangle and to disentangle. She who knotted the Nameless One's fate also holds the thread by which it may be undone.

1.5 The Literary Genealogy: Attested Frames and Structural Antecedents

The designers' testimony yields no canonical bibliography, and the scholar should resist supplying one. Avellone attributes the game's apparent depth to how much he read, while declining to rank it with the fiction he admired. McComb stresses that both designers loved the setting but departed from it where the story demanded. Beyond the Planescape corpus, what can be established with confidence is a set of structural antecedents. These are works that pose the game's problems in comparable form and together map the conceptual field *Torment* enters.

The Gnostic stratum. The oldest layer is Gnostic. The *Hymn of the Pearl*, preserved in the apocryphal *Acts of Thomas* (§§108–113), tells of a prince sent from the East into Egypt to recover a pearl guarded by a serpent. He puts on Egyptian garments, eats Egyptian food, and falls into a sleep in which he forgets his origin, his mission, and that he is a king's son. His parents send a letter that flies to him as an eagle and speaks. He wakes, remembers, charms the serpent, seizes the pearl, and returns. The robe he left behind then comes to meet him, and he sees his own image in it as in a mirror: two in distinction, yet one in likeness.

Every structural element of *Torment*'s frame is present:

- the forgetful exile in a foreign and corrupting world;
- the letter from home that recalls the sleeper to himself (the tattoo on the Nameless One's back, a message from a former self);
- the guarded object of the mission;
- the final reunion with a double who is both self and other (the Transcendent One).

Hans Jonas's reconstruction of Gnostic symbolism (1958/1963) catalogues these motifs (alienness, numbness, sleep, intoxication, the call from without) as the vocabulary of a religion of the forgetful soul. In his epilogue on Gnosticism and existentialism, Jonas notes that Heidegger's term for the facticity of existence, *Geworfenheit* or thrownness, is originally a Gnostic figure. It recurs in Mandaean texts that speak of life as thrown into the world. The Nameless One's awakening in the Mortuary is Heideggerian thrownness in its Gnostic form. He finds himself already cast into a world he did not choose, bearing a history he cannot recall, addressed by a call he cannot yet understand.

The decisive difference is the source of the call. The Gnostic call comes from a transcendent home; the Nameless One's comes from himself, a letter written by a previous incarnation. There is no Father beyond the planes. There is only a former self who planned, and whose planning cannot be told apart from manipulation.

The classical stratum. This layer supplies the two myths of forgetting that frame the Western philosophy of memory.

- In the Myth of Er that closes Plato's *Republic* (X, 614b–621d), souls who have chosen their next lives cross the plain of Lethe and drink from the river Ameles, "unmindfulness," so that they enter the new existence without recollection of the old.
- In the *Meno* (81b–86b) and *Phaedo* (72e–77a), learning is anamnesis, the recovery of knowledge held before birth.

The Nameless One is a soul that drinks from Ameles at every death and must relearn everything by anamnesis. What he recovers, however, is not the vision of the Forms but the record of his crimes.

The same stratum supplies the earliest literary instances of allothanasia. In the Standard Babylonian *Epic of Gilgamesh* (Tablet VII), the gods decree that one of the two companions who slew Humbaba and the Bull of Heaven must die. It is Enkidu, not Gilgamesh, who sickens, and Gilgamesh's quest for immortality begins from the scandal of a death suffered in his place.

In Euripides' *Alcestis* (438 BCE), Apollo has won from the Fates the concession that Admetus may escape his appointed death if someone else will die for him. His aged parents refuse; his wife consents. The play's most searching scene is the quarrel between Admetus and his father Pheres. Pheres refuses to die for his son on the ground that love of life is not the privilege of the young, and in doing so exposes the shame of a man who has accepted another's death as the price of his own continuance. Admetus is the Greek prototype of the Nameless One: a man alive by substitution, whose survival indicts him.

The modernist stratum. This layer supplies the juridical and inscriptive dimensions of the problem.

- Kafka's Josef K. (*The Trial*, 1925) is arrested and finally executed for a crime that is never named. The Nameless One is pursued by the consequences of an original crime, the transgression of his first incarnation that motivated the bargain with Ravel, which the game with deliberate restraint never specifies.
- Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919) describes an apparatus that writes the violated commandment into the condemned man's flesh, so that he learns his sentence only by deciphering it through his wounds. The Nameless One's body is likewise a surface of inscription, legible to others before it is legible to him, and his education consists in reading the text of his own skin.

The juxtaposition reveals a structural affinity that needs no influence claim. In both Kafka and *Torment*, the law precedes knowledge of the law, guilt precedes knowledge of the crime, and the body is the medium through which a subject learns what it has already been judged to be.

The Borgesian stratum. Borges supplies the metaphysics.

- "The Immortal" (1947) imagines a City of the Immortals whose inhabitants have lived so long that they are indifferent to everything, since in infinite time every act

is performed and every fate befalls everyone. Its narrator, who had been Homer, has forgotten his own poem.

- "Funes the Memorious" (1942) presents the inverse case: a man who forgets nothing and is thereby made incapable of abstraction, generalization, and thought.
- "The Circular Ruins" (1940) describes a man who dreams another man into existence and then discovers that he too is dreamed.

Between Funes and the Immortal, the Nameless One occupies a third position: infinite life without infinite memory. He shows neither the Immortal's indifference nor Funes's paralysis. He is a moral agent who must recommence repeatedly and decide each time what to make of a past he knows only by report.

The fantastic stratum. This layer supplies the narrative architecture and the most exact thematic parallels.

- **Jack Vance, *The Dying Earth* (1950).** Vance gave *Dungeons & Dragons* both its baroque register and a magic system in which a spell, once cast, is erased from the caster's memory. The game's substrate is therefore, with a certain irony, an economy of spending memory, and its protagonist is a Vancian magus writ large: every use of himself consumes part of what he knows.
- **Roger Zelazny.** *Nine Princes in Amber* (1970) opens with its prince waking amnesiac in a hospital bed and rebuilding his identity from others' reactions. This outside-in method of self-knowledge is the one *Torment* makes systematic. *Lord of Light* (1967) made reincarnation at once technological and theological.
- **Michael Moorcock.** His Eternal Champion is a single hero incarnated across the multiverse who, in *The Eternal Champion* (1970), is cursed to remember his other lives: the exact inverse of the Nameless One, whose curse is to forget them.
- **Clive Barker.** *Imajica* (1991) presents Gentle, who lived before as the Maestro Sartori, has forgotten it, and must be reconciled with a double who is himself. Barker's earlier *The Hellbound Heart* (1986) imagined an order of beings for whom extreme sensation is a mode of knowledge, an aesthetic the Sensates of Sigil domesticate into a civic institution.
- **Neil Gaiman, *The Sandman* (1989–1996).** Across the same years in which Planescape was conceived, it sustained a meditation on whether an eternal being can change its nature. In the arc that ends with Dream's death, it answers that for such a being change and death may be the same event.
- **Gene Wolfe, *The Book of the New Sun* (1980–1983).** Wolfe gave the fantastic its most philosophically ambitious protagonist. Severian, a journeyman of the tortur-

ers' guild, claims to forget nothing. After a ritual ingestion he carries within him the memories and personality of the woman whose death he made possible. He also bears a relic that appears to raise the dead.

- **Ursula K. Le Guin, *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968).** Le Guin supplied the parable that *Torment*'s ending most closely rewrites. Ged is pursued across the world by a shadow he himself released. He turns to hunt it and, at the edge of the world, names it with his own name and becomes whole. The Nameless One is likewise pursued by shadows, and his final confrontation is with a being that is his own: the mortality he alienated.

These antecedents do not explain the game; they triangulate it. From the Gnostic stratum it inherits the forgetful exile and the call. From the classical, the waters of forgetting and the scandal of substitution. From the modernist, the unnamed crime and the inscribed body. From Borges, the dialectic of infinite life and total memory. From the fantastic, the amnesiac prince, the doubled maestro, the eternal who must die to change, the torturer who carries his victim within him, and the wizard who reclaims his shadow.

What *Torment* adds is the connection none of these works makes explicit: forgetting and deathlessness are not two misfortunes but a single economy, in which whatever the self does not carry, its past and its end, is carried by others. The chapters that follow reconstruct that economy, beginning with its mnemonic half.

CHAPTER



II

ALLOMNESIA

Memory, Inscription, and the Distributed Self

2.1 The Awakening as a Philosophical Protocol

Planescape: Torment opens with a scene that works less as exposition than as a controlled arrangement of variables, in the manner of the thought experiments it goes on to complicate.

A scarred body wakes on a slab in the Mortuary of the Dustmen. A floating skull addresses it and reports that words have been written on its back, then reads them aloud. The waking man is to consult a journal, find someone named Pharod, and tell no one what he is or what happens to him, or he will be sent to the crematorium. He can speak, walk, bargain, and fight. He does not know his name.

Every variable in the problem of personal identity is present in this scene, and each is set to an extreme:

- **Bodily continuity is maximal.** This body has lain on this slab before, and the Mortuary's scribe Dhall knows it as a returning arrival.
- **Psychological continuity is minimal.** The man keeps his competences but none of his autobiography.
- **The past exists only as text,** and the text is accessible only through another's reading.
- **The text contains intentions** already formed and already endorsed. The present subject finds them lodged in him like a stranger's luggage, signed by someone who both was and was not himself.

One detail deserves separate attention, because the rest of this chapter grows from it. The message is written on the one surface of the human body its owner cannot see. The Nameless One's first access to his own past must therefore pass through another's eyes.

The back is the anatomical site of what Sartre called being-for-others: the dimension of my being that exists for another's look and that I can never grasp from inside (Sartre 1943, Part III). Mead distinguished the "I," the spontaneous agent, from the "me," the organized attitudes of others toward me that I take up as my own (Mead 1934). Here that distinction gets a literal diagram. The Nameless One wakes as an "I" without a "me," and his "me" is on his back, legible to his companion and illegible to himself. This is the primal scene of allomnesia.

2.2 The Forensic Person: Locke, Butler, Reid, Oedipus

The modern philosophy of personal identity began with a legal question, and *Torment* returns it to that origin.

Locke's chapter "Of Identity and Diversity," added to the second edition of the *Essay* (1694), separates three identities that ordinary speech runs together:

- the identity of a substance;
- the identity of a *man*, which consists in "a participation of the same continued life" in an organized body (II.xxvii.6);
- the identity of a *person*, which consists in sameness of consciousness: "as far as this consciousness can be extended backwards to any past action or thought, so far reaches the identity of that person" (II.xxvii.9).

The distinction is practical, not idle. "Person," Locke insists, "is a forensic term, appropriating actions and their merit" (II.xxvii.26). Its job is to settle who may justly be rewarded or punished for what.

Locke's own thought experiments anticipate the Nameless One closely. He imagines "two distinct incommunicable consciousnesses acting the same body, the one constantly by day, the other by night," and asks whether the day-man and night-man would not be "two as distinct persons as Socrates and Plato" (II.xxvii.23). The Nameless One is Locke's day-man and night-man stretched across millennia: one man in Locke's technical sense, and an indefinite series of persons.

Locke draws the forensic consequence without hesitation. Human courts punish the drunkard for what he did while drunk, because they cannot verify his claim not to remember. But "in the great day, wherein the secrets of all hearts shall be laid open, it may be reasonable to think, no one shall be made to answer for what he knows nothing of" (II.xxvii.22). On Locke's account, the present Nameless One is simply not the person who committed his first incarnation's crime. At the Last Judgment an omniscient court would acquit him.

Torment places Locke's principle inside a cosmos that has exactly the omniscient bookkeeping Locke invoked, and shows that cosmos rejecting Locke's verdict. The planes know what the protagonist does not. The Blood War awaits him regardless; the shadows pursue him; Vhailor would judge him; his victims remember. The Great Day of the Outer Planes lays open the secrets of all hearts and holds him answerable anyway.

This is the game's first modal invariant: no path lets the protagonist escape liability for deeds he cannot remember. What varies is his stance toward that liability, from denial through flight to acceptance. The game does not *argue* against Locke. It builds a world in which Lockean exculpation is unavailable and asks what a person should do there.

Two classic objections to Locke sharpen the case.

Butler's circularity objection. Joseph Butler observed that "consciousness of personal identity presupposes, and therefore cannot constitute, personal identity" (Butler 1736). To remember an action as one's own already assumes one did it. Sydney Shoemaker's reply defined *quasi-memory*: an apparent memory caused in the right way by an experience, without assuming that rememberer and experiencer are the same person (Shoemaker 1970).

The Nameless One's recollections are quasi-memories in the most exact sense fiction allows. When a phrase of Deionarra's or the feel of a scar releases a fragment of the past, he has no internal test that separates his own recollection from a trace left by a predecessor, and whether he is identical to that predecessor is exactly the open question. Mechanically, the game presents these fragments as memories. Structurally, it has made them impossible to tell apart from inheritance.

Reid's transitivity objection. Thomas Reid's objection is more damaging and more instructive. His brave officer was flogged as a boy for robbing an orchard. As a young officer who captures an enemy standard, he remembers the flogging. As a general, he remembers capturing the standard but has forgotten the flogging. By Locke's criterion, the general both is and is not the boy (Reid 1785, Essay III, ch. 6).

The Nameless One's history is a lattice of such failures. Each incarnation kept, at most, scraps of certain predecessors. None kept all of them. Before the Fortress of Regrets, the first incarnation is remembered by no one who is him. There the lattice closes in a way Reid's case cannot: the first incarnation stands before the latest as a shade, the Good Incarnation, who can be questioned and taken back into the self, and a stored memory of him survives in the bronze sphere (§2.7). Reid's general does not remember the boy; the Nameless One meets him.

Reid's positive doctrine fits the case exactly. For Reid, memory does not make identity; it testifies to it: "It is not my remembering any action of mine that makes me to be the person who did it. This remembrance makes me to know assuredly that I did it; but I might have done it, though I did not remember it" (Reid 1785, Essay III, ch. 4).

I might have done it, though I did not remember it. No sentence in the literature describes the Nameless One more precisely. If memory is evidence rather than constitution, identity becomes something to infer and the self something to investigate. The protagonist's quest takes the form of a trial in which he is detective, defendant, and chief witness at once.

That form has a tragic archetype. Oedipus answered the Sphinx's riddle about the creature that walks on four feet, then two, then three as the day of its life proceeds; the answer was "man." He then became the investigator who discovers that the criminal he seeks is himself. Ravel Puzzlewell, the monstrous female questioner who poses a riddle about the nature of man, stands where the Sphinx stood. The Sphinx asked what it is that time transforms. Ravel asks what *can* transform.

Across two plays, Sophocles stages both forensic positions between which *Torment* moves:

- In *Oedipus Tyrannus*, the discovery of unknowing guilt ends in self-blinding: responsibility accepted for deeds done in ignorance.
- In *Oedipus at Colonus*, the aged Oedipus pleads before Creon that he acted unwittingly and is therefore clean in law. This is the Lockean defense two thousand years early.

Bernard Williams argued that the first response shows a conception of agency and responsibility richer than the modern one, which limits responsibility to the voluntary and the known (Williams 1993). Chapter VIII will argue that *Torment* sides with the Oedipus of the *Tyrannus*, while replacing his self-mutilation with something harder.

2.3 The Bundle, the Chariot, and Relation R

If Locke's person is forensic, Hume's is fictional. Introspection finds no impression of a self, only "a bundle or collection of different perceptions, which succeed each other with an inconceivable rapidity, and are in a perpetual flux and movement" (Hume 1739, I.iv.6). The identity we ascribe to the bundle is a fiction the imagination produces as it slides easily along relations of resemblance and causation.

Hume's most fitting image, though, is political: "I cannot compare the soul more properly to any thing than to a republic or commonwealth, in which the several members are united by the reciprocal ties of government and subordination, and give rise to other persons, who propagate the same republic in the incessant changes of its parts."

The Nameless One is a Humean commonwealth whose citizens succeed one another in office. Each incarnation gives rise to the next. The republic is carried forward by a constitution: tattoos, caches, and instructions, the laws one administration leaves to bind the next. It is also something Hume's image does not quite foresee: a republic in which one administration can systematically defraud its successor.

Parfit and prosthetic R. Derek Parfit's reductionism rebuilds Hume's bundle with analytical precision (Parfit 1984, Part Three). What persists through time is Relation R, which has two components:

- **psychological connectedness:** direct links such as memories of experiences, the carrying out of earlier intentions, and persisting beliefs and desires;
- **psychological continuity:** overlapping chains of such links, with the right kind of cause.

Identity is a further fact only on the non-reductionist view Parfit rejects. On the reductionist view, identity is not what matters.

Measured this way, the incarnations stand in striking relations. Connectedness of character and skill is considerable: the body learns with suspicious ease what it has plainly learned before. Connectedness of memory is almost nil. Continuity breaks at every death, except where it is artificially rebuilt.

That artificial rebuilding is the game's most original contribution to the theory of identity. The Practical Incarnation is the cold strategist whose shade the protagonist meets in the Fortress of Regrets, and the game shows his hand behind the most systematic of these provisions. He did not merely suffer the break in Relation R; he engineered a prosthetic repair. By inscription he supplied his successor with ready-made intentions, beliefs, and plans, forging by hand the links of intention and fulfilment that death had cut. Call this *prosthetic R*.

Prosthetic R raises a problem Parfit's framework cannot easily absorb. Intentions carried out later are among Parfit's central examples of psychological connection. But an intention formed by one agent, installed in another, and then carried out by the second without knowing where it came from is the textbook case of manipulation in the free-will literature. Alfred Mele's agent has her values covertly implanted overnight (Mele 1995). Derk Pereboom's agent has his deliberations engineered by neuroscientists (Pereboom 2001).

The Nameless One begins each life as a manipulated agent whose manipulator is himself. The game repeatedly puts before him the choice that Harry Frankfurt's hierarchical theory makes central: to identify with the desires he finds in himself, and so make

them his own, or to repudiate them (Frankfurt 1971). The Practical's plan can be followed or refused. Here too the inheritance is invariant and the identification is the variable.

Parfit on desert. Parfit drew ethical consequences from his metaphysics, and one is decisive for this dissertation. If identity is not what matters, and connectedness comes in degrees, then desert may shrink as connectedness weakens. A present self only distantly connected to a past criminal may deserve less punishment for that crime (Parfit 1984, Part Three, ch. 15).

Few characters in any fiction satisfy the antecedent of that conditional as completely as the Nameless One, whose connection to his first incarnation is, until the closing scenes, effectively zero. Parfit's reductionism would all but acquit him. The game grants the metaphysics: nothing in it suggests a further fact of identity, a soul-pearl or Cartesian ego persisting beneath the incarnations. It refuses the ethics. This pairing of a Parfitian ontology of the self with a non-Parfitian theory of desert is not an inconsistency. It marks a theory in which responsibility is constituted by assumption rather than discovered through identity. Chapter VIII will reconstruct that theory.

The Buddhist case. The oldest reductionism is Buddhist, and the game's relation to it is subtler than its assignment of Buddhist motifs to the Dustmen suggests.

- In the *Milindapañha*, King Milinda asks the monk Nāgasena his name. Nāgasena replies that "Nāgasena" is only a designation, a conventional term, since no person is found in it. Asked to explain, he makes the king concede that "chariot" names nothing over and above axle, wheels, and pole assembled.
- Asked whether the one reborn is the same as the one who died, Nāgasena gives a formula that could serve as *Torment*'s epigraph: *na ca so na ca añño*, neither the same nor another, as the flame of the night's last watch is neither the same as nor other than the flame of the first.
- Buddhaghosa's *Visuddhimagga* (XVI.90) compresses the doctrine further: there is suffering but no sufferer, deeds but no doer.

What persists is a causal stream (*santāna*) in which deeds ripen into fruit (*vipāka*) with no enduring self to own either.

The Nameless One is this doctrine seen through a distorting lens, in two respects.

1. **He radicalizes *anattā* (no-self) into *anāma* (no-name).** Nāgasena at least has the conventional name he deconstructs. The Nameless One lacks even the convention.

2. **His case is karmically anomalous.** In the Buddhist account, the fruit of deeds ripens in the stream that produced them. In the Nameless One's case the stream re-enters the same body rather than a new one, so rebirth has become resurrection. And the fruit of his persistence, which is death, ripens in *other* streams: the anonymous lives that end so his can continue.

Allothanasia is, in Buddhist terms, a cosmic misattribution of karma, a ledger error that delivers the consequences of one stream's deeds to others. The game's resolution will correct the ledger. The Dustmen, the game's institutional Buddhists, preach instead the extinction of passion in a True Death. The game thus separates the Buddhist diagnosis, which it largely accepts, from the Buddhist cure, which it declines. Chapter IV develops the distinction.

Animalism. One more position completes the map. If the Nameless One is anything continuously, he is an animal. Animalism, the view that we are identical to human organisms whose persistence is biological (Olson 1997), fits his case perfectly and explains nothing. The organism persists, regenerating like the ship of Theseus, patched but never replaced; the persons come and go.

The game's ethical weight falls on the persons, and its forensic weight on the organism. Deionarra, Morte, Pharod, Ignus, and Dak'kon track, recognize, hunt, or love him by his body. Yet what he must answer for was done by persons he does not remember being. The moral drama of the game unfolds in the gap between the organism that is liable and the person who must assume the liability.

2.4 The Inscribed Body: Pharmakon, Mnemotechnics, Palimpsest

Plato's orphaned writing. In the *Phaedrus*, Socrates tells the Egyptian myth in which the god Theuth offers writing to King Thamus as a remedy (*pharmakon*) for memory and wisdom. Thamus answers that it will breed forgetfulness in those who learn it, because they will trust external marks instead of remembering from within: *ἄκων μνήμης, ἀλλὰ ὑπομνήσεως φάρμακον ηὗρες*, "it is not a drug of memory but of reminding that you have found" (275a). Written words, Socrates adds, are orphans. They cannot answer questions or defend themselves when misused, and they always need their father to come to their aid (275d–e).

The Nameless One's tattoos are the most extreme orphaned writing imaginable. Their father is dead, and their father is also their reader. They cannot answer the questions they raise, explain their own purposes, or defend themselves against the suspicion that they lie.

The *Phaedrus* declares that the text cannot answer until its father appears. In the Fortress of Regrets, that is literally what happens: the father of the text, the Practical Incarnation, appears as a shade and can be questioned. The orphaned *logos* meets its author, and the author turns out to be the reader's former self.

Derrida's supplement. Derrida's reading of the *Phaedrus* (1968) argues that Plato's opposition between living memory (*mnēmē*) and dead reminder (*hypomnēsis*) cannot hold. Memory is already structured as inscription, a system of traces, before any literal writing supplements it. Writing, in the phrase Derrida took from Rousseau (1967), is a "dangerous supplement" that exposes the original incompleteness of what it supplements.

The Nameless One literalizes this thesis. At the start of each of his lives there is no living memory for writing to supplement. The supplement comes before what it supplements, and each life begins with *hypomnēsis*.

Nietzsche's mnemotechnics. Nietzsche supplies the anthropology of this inscription. The second essay of the *Genealogy of Morals* treats forgetfulness not as inertia but as an active faculty of inhibition (*aktives Hemmungsvermögen*) necessary to health. It then asks how an essentially forgetful animal could be bred into one "das versprechen darf," permitted to make promises (GM II §1). The answer is a mnemotechnics of pain: "Man brennt Etwas ein, damit es im Gedächtniss bleibt: nur was nicht aufhört, weh zu thun, bleibt im Gedächtniss" (GM II §3).

One burns something in so that it stays in memory; only what never stops hurting stays in memory. The Nameless One's body is this mnemotechnics made flesh: tattoos put in by needle, scars left by deaths, a skin on which the only surviving memories are those that hurt.

Yet his case inverts Nietzsche's ideal. The strong forget actively and remember selectively. The Nameless One forgets involuntarily and totally, while carrying a surplus of branding on his skin. He is forgetful without innocence and marked without recollection, bearing every scar of the morality of custom and none of the sovereignty it was meant to produce.

Nietzsche's earlier essay on history (1874) named the capacity he lacks: the *plastische Kraft*, the plastic power by which a healthy person or culture absorbs its past, heals its wounds, and replaces what is lost. The Nameless One can neither absorb his past nor escape it, and so, in Nietzsche's sense, cannot live.

Fell's tattoos. The tattoos gain a further, specifically game-based dimension through Fell, the dabus tattooist. Fell inscribes commemorative marks that the rules treat as equipment, each conferring particular powers. A memory worn becomes a capacity of the body.

Here the pharmacology of the self takes a turn neither Plato nor Nietzsche foresaw: the mnemonic supplement does not merely remind, it augments. Stiegler held that technical memory is constitutive of human capacity, that we become what we are through the tools in which our memory is stored (Stiegler 1994–2001). That thesis finds an unusually literal emblem in a man whose strength and resilience are indexed to what has been written on him.

Freud's Mystic Writing-Pad. Freud's "Note upon the 'Mystic Writing-Pad'" (1925) models the relation between the Nameless One's deaths and his body. The toy is a slab of wax under a translucent sheet. Writing appears where the stylus presses the sheet against the wax. Lifting the sheet erases the visible text, while the wax keeps permanent traces. Freud saw in it the psychic apparatus: a receptive surface that stays perpetually fresh, over a permanent store of traces.

Each of the Nameless One's deaths lifts the sheet. The surface of consciousness is wiped clean, and the wax of the body keeps its traces: scars, skills, reflexes, tattoos.

Freud noted the device's limit. Once the writing is erased, the pad cannot reproduce it from within; it would be a truly mystic pad if it could do what memory does. The Nameless One's body is a Wunderblock that cannot reproduce its own traces. Reactivating them requires readers, companions, and witnesses, others whose recognition presses the sheet back against the wax.

De Quincey's image of the brain as palimpsest completes the thought: "Everlasting layers of ideas, images, feelings, have fallen upon your brain softly as light. Each succession has seemed to bury all that went before. And yet, in reality, not one has been extinguished" (De Quincey 1845). What the Nameless One lacks is not the layers but the chemistry that would make the lower ones readable.

Bergson and Merleau-Ponty. Bergson's two forms of memory explain what the palimpsest keeps (Bergson 1896, ch. 2). Habit-memory is the motor mechanism acquired by repetition, the lesson learned by heart. Pure memory is the dated recollection of a unique event. The Nameless One keeps the first and has lost the second. He can fight, steal, and cast spells, and the fiction keeps hinting that he learns these arts with a facility that betrays earlier learning. What he cannot recover unaided is the pure memory of when, where, and why he learned them.

Merleau-Ponty's distinction between the habitual body and the actual body (1945) describes the same split from the inside. The body carries a sedimented history of competences that the present subject inhabits without possessing as knowledge. The Nameless One's body knows what he does not.

Experience as a mechanic. The game's rules encode this epistemology with some subtlety. In most role-playing games, *experience*, the genre's central quantity, measures accumulated combat. In *Torment* it is earned prominently through conversation and recollection; recovering a memory is itself a source of experience. Wisdom, which in the game's adaptation of the rules bears on both experience gained and memories recovered, becomes the attribute of retrospection. The Greeks made Mnemosyne, Memory, the mother of the Muses.

Benjamin's distinction between two kinds of experience gives the mechanic a precise gloss (Benjamin 1939). *Erlebnis* is isolated lived experience registered as shock. *Erfahrung* is experience accumulated, integrated, and handed down as tradition. "Experience points" in the ordinary game are *Erlebnis* quantified. In *Torment*, recovering the past turns *Erlebnis* back into *Erfahrung*: isolated fragments are integrated into a narrative, and the integration is rewarded as growth.

2.5 Three Repetitions: Freud, Plato, Kierkegaard

The Nameless One does not merely forget his past; he repeats it.

Freud: repetition without recollection. Freud's "Erinnern, Wiederholen und Durcharbeiten" (1914) describes a patient who remembers nothing of what he has forgotten and repressed but acts it out: "Er reproduziert es nicht als Erinnerung, sondern als Tat, er wiederholt es, ohne natürlich zu wissen, daß er es wiederholt." He reproduces it not as memory but as action, repeating it without, of course, knowing that he repeats it.

Torment's narrative is a repetition compulsion on a cosmic scale:

- The Mortuary has received his corpse before, and its scribe recognizes the returning dead man.
- Companions bound to earlier selves travel with the present one.
- The same questions send him down the same roads toward the same Fortress.
- His former selves have left the debris of earlier versions of the same pilgrimage scattered along the way.

Freud's therapeutic answer to repetition was working-through (*Durcharbeiten*), which proceeds by transference: the past is re-enacted in the relation to the analyst, where it can be recognized and interpreted. In the game this function is spread across the companions, in whom the protagonist's past relations return: Deionarra's love, Ignus's resentment, Dak'kon's bondage, Morte's evasions. Morte in particular, joking where he should disclose and deflecting where he should confess, plays the part of the resistance. His humor matches what Freud (1927) called humor's consoling function, the stance that shrinks a threatening reality into a joke. Chapter V returns to him.

Plato: recollection without repetition. Against compulsive repetition stands Platonic recollection. In the *Meno*, the problem of inquiry takes the form of a paradox. One cannot search for what one knows, since one already has it, nor for what one does not know, since one would not recognize it if found (80d–e). Socrates dissolves the paradox with anamnesis: learning is recovering what the soul knew before birth.

The Nameless One's quest is the Meno paradox in the flesh. He searches for himself without knowing what he seeks and could not recognize it unaided. The game's solution is social rather than Platonic: others recognize him. The witness's recognition stands in for the soul's anamnesis, and what is recovered is not a vision of the Forms but a record of deeds.

Kierkegaard: repetition recollected forward. Kierkegaard supplies the third term and, with it, the shape of the resolution. In *Repetition* (1843), Constantin Constantius contrasts the Greek category of recollection with the modern category of repetition. They are the same movement in opposite directions. What is recollected has been, and is repeated backward (*gjentages baglænds*); genuine repetition is recollected forward (*erindres forlænds*). Recollection returns the self to an origin. Repetition takes up what has been as a task still to be done. Heidegger inherited the concept as *Wiederholung*, the authentic retrieval by which Dasein hands down to itself the possibilities that have been and takes them over as its fate (Heidegger 1927, §74).

The Nameless One's arc passes through all three movements in order:

1. compulsive repetition without recollection (Freud);
2. recollection without repetition (Plato);
3. repetition recollected forward (Kierkegaard).

His past, reassembled in the Fortress, is not only known but taken up as a future: the war to which it sentences him. Applied to time, the Rule of Three yields three forms of return, and only the third is freedom.

2.6 Otto's Notebook on Another's Back: The Distributed Self

In 1998, while *Torment* was in production, Andy Clark and David Chalmers published "The Extended Mind." Its central figure is Otto, a man with Alzheimer's disease who writes down what he needs to remember in a notebook he always carries. When Otto consults the notebook to find his way to a museum, they argue, the notebook plays the role that biological memory plays for his unimpaired friend Inga, so its entries count as Otto's beliefs.

Their parity principle comes with conditions. The resource must be:

- reliably available and typically invoked;
- directly and easily accessible;
- more or less automatically endorsed when retrieved;
- consciously endorsed at some time in the past.

At first the Nameless One's tattoos look like Otto's notebook perfected: written on the body itself, they cannot be misplaced. On inspection they fail two of the conditions, and the failures are more interesting than the fit.

- **They are not directly accessible.** He cannot read the tattoo on his back without another's eyes. His extended memory extends *through another mind*.
- **They fail prior endorsement.** Their contents were endorsed by a predecessor, not by him.

The Nameless One is therefore not an extended mind but a distributed and partly expropriated one. His notebook is written on a surface only others can read, by an author who was and was not himself. The extended-mind thesis treats cognitive extension as an enlargement of the self, so it cannot register the political dimension the game reveals: whoever writes in your notebook governs you.

Social frameworks of memory. The better frameworks are social.

- Maurice Halbwachs argued that individual memory is always framed by collective memory. We remember as members of groups, within social frameworks (*cadres sociaux*) that give memories their place and meaning. Someone deprived of these frameworks loses not only the past but the ability to locate it (Halbwachs 1925).
- Edwin Hutchins showed that cognition in complex tasks is distributed across people and artifacts (Hutchins 1995).
- Daniel Wegner described transactive memory, in which intimate partners divide remembering so that each stores what the other need not (Wegner 1987).

The Nameless One's past is held in exactly such a transactive system. But the other members were never his equals, and they are not neutral archivists:

- Deionarra holds his love and his betrayal.
- Dak'kon holds an oath the protagonist does not remember extracting, so the promise is remembered only by the one who made it.
- Ignus holds the memory of a harsh master.
- Morte holds more than he admits.
- The Pillar of Skulls holds knowledge for a price.

His memory partners are creditors. Their memories of him are grievances, loves, debts, and claims.

Testimony as self-knowledge. This turns the epistemology of self-knowledge into the epistemology of testimony. The classic dispute over testimony set Hume's evidentialism, which accepts testimony only in proportion to our experience of its reliability (Hume 1748, X), against Reid's principle of credulity, a native disposition to trust what we are told (Reid 1764, ch. VI §24). In the Nameless One's case, that dispute becomes a dispute about how to know oneself.

His informants include a professional liar, a lover who died because of him, a disciple an earlier self schooled in fire, and a pillar of the damned. C. A. J. Coady's defense of testimony as a basic source of knowledge (Coady 1992) meets its hardest test here: a self known mainly by report, from interested witnesses, with no independent access to check them against.

Two boundary cases. Two further structures mark the edges of this distributed self.

The Sensates' sensory stones let one undergo another's recorded experience. They industrialize what Stiegler calls tertiary retention: memory becomes a commodity, experience a transferable good, and the line between one's own past and another's a matter of purchase. Stiegler's critique of the cultural industries as a proletarianization of memory (Stiegler 2010) finds an emblem here in a civic institution.

The Many-as-One, a collective intelligence formed by a swarm of cranium rats whose intellect grows with the number of bodies it spans, is the exact inverse of the Nameless One. He is one body inhabited in succession by many minds; it is one mind spread at once across many bodies.

Taken together, these cases amount to a laboratory of persistence conditions:

Figure	Substrate	Mode of unity	What persists	Philosophical analogue
The Nameless One	One regenerating organism	Serial persons in one body	Body, habits, inscriptions	Locke's day-man and night-man; animalism
The Many-as-One	Many organisms (cranium rats)	One mind across a swarm	A pattern spanning bodies	Hume's commonwealth; distributed cognition
Nordom	An artificial body cut off from its collective	A self produced by subtraction	Individuality after disconnection	Leibniz's monad; Descartes' cogito
Morte	A skull taken from the Pillar of Skulls	A voice without a body	Speech and its liabilities	The oracular head: Orpheus, Mímir
Deionarra	No body; a ghost	A love outliving its bearer	Attachment and foresight	The shadowy phantoms of *Phaedo* 81c–d
Vhailor	Empty armor	A conviction without a believer	A single belief	Peirce's tenacity; Hegel's absolute freedom
Ignus	A body turned into a conduit of elemental fire	A person consumed by appetite	Fire and hunger	Empedocles at Etna; Heraclitean fire
The Transcendent One	A mortality severed from its body	A finitude become an agent	Death as will	Feuerbach inverted; the Jungian shadow

The table's point is that the game treats the relation between persons and their substrates as a variable to explore, not a fixed datum. The Nameless One is the fixed point around which the variations are arranged. He combines the greatest bodily continuity with the least psychological continuity, and so isolates, as no other figure in the game can, the question of what else a person might consist in.

2.7 The Name: Description, Designation, Apophasis

Russell and the failure of uniqueness. The protagonist is known by a description, not a name. Russell's theory of descriptions (1905) analyzes "the F" as asserting that exactly one thing is F. "The Nameless One" therefore asserts uniqueness: there is one and only one being without a name.

The game falsifies this presupposition from within. The multiverse is full of nameless ones: the anonymous dead whose lives ended so his could continue, whose shadows gather around him and whom no record names. Read strictly, the protagonist's designation is false, and its falsity is morally exact. He is not *the* nameless one. He is one nameless one among the multitudes he has made nameless.

On Strawson's rival account (1950), a failed presupposition leaves a statement neither true nor false. The designation then falls into a truth-value gap, a semantically liminal status fitting for a being caught betwixt and between.

Kripke and the orphaned name. Kripke's causal theory of names (1980) complicates the picture. A proper name designates rigidly, picking out the same individual in every possible world, through an initial baptism and a chain of transmission, not through any description its users attach to it.

On this view the Nameless One has a name. It was fixed at a baptism he does not remember and passed along chains that have since broken, and it still rigidly designates him in every world. For most of the game no one, himself included, can use it. The game does allow it to be recovered, and the manner of recovery is telling. A bronze sphere the player can find turns out to be a dead sensory stone holding memories of the first incarnation, and in the Fortress of Regrets it can return the name to him. The broken chain of transmission is repaired not from within but by a stored, external memory: allomnesia restores even the name. Yet on no path does the game disclose the name to the player. For the character it is a recoverable rigid designator; for the player it stays orphaned.

In the setting's lore, and in a long tradition running from the Egyptian *ren* through the Rumpelstiltskin tales to the true names of Le Guin's Earthsea, knowing a being's true name gives power over it. Namelessness is therefore both dispossession and protection. It strips him of the self a name would anchor and shields him from anyone who would use it. The instruction tattooed on his back, to hide what he is, belongs to the same economy of concealment.

Outis and Odysseus. The Homeric archetype of strategic namelessness is Odysseus telling the Cyclops his name is *Outis*, Nobody (*Odyssey* IX.366–367). When the blinded Polyphemus cries that Nobody is killing him, no help comes, and the ruse saves him.

The sequel matters more. Once safe aboard ship, Odysseus shouts his true name and lineage back to the Cyclops (IX.502–505), claiming authorship of the deed. That exposes him to Polyphemus's curse and to Poseidon's long enmity. To name oneself is to sign one's acts and accept their consequences.

The Nameless One's whole trajectory runs from Outis to Odysseus: from the concealment that preserves him to the self-disclosure that exposes him to retribution. The difference is that his self-disclosure does not depend on a name. He may recover it, and if

he does he can turn it against the Transcendent One, as the lore of true names predicts; but the ending demands the same act whether he knows it or not. His self-disclosure takes the form of an assumption of responsibility.

Apophasis. The theological tradition adds a final register. Pseudo-Dionysius calls the divine both *anōnymos* and *polyōnymos*, nameless and many-named, beyond every name because it causes all things (*Divine Names* I.6). The first chapter of the *Daodejing* holds that the name that can be named is not the constant name, and that the nameless is the beginning of heaven and earth (無名天地之始).

The Nameless One is *anōnymos* and *polyōnymos* in a debased, human sense:

- Lacking a name, he can take any name.
- His incarnations go by descriptive epithets: the Good, the Practical, the Paranoid.
- By repetition, he can turn a false name into a person: Adahn.

He is the nameless beginning of a series of selves, but the series was started by a crime, and by a remorse that sought more time, not by a creation.

A Lacanian reading would take his namelessness as the absence of the paternal signifier that assigns a subject its place in the symbolic order. His only substitute is a letter from a former self acting as his own father. The tattoo is that father's law written on the son's body, and the son is the father's successor in the same flesh.

Conclusion to Chapter II

The chapter's argument can now be stated formally. A subject is *allomnesic* when three conditions hold:

1. The conditions of its self-knowledge over time are held mainly outside its own biological memory, in inscriptions and in other persons.
2. Its access to its own past is therefore testimonial rather than recollective.
3. The contents of that past include intentions it did not form and cannot call its own without an act of identification.

Three theses follow.

First, for such a subject, self-knowledge is a problem in the epistemology of testimony, and the witnesses are interested parties.

Second, responsibility comes before memory and exceeds it. In the world's eyes, the allomnesic subject answers for more than it can recall, and it must decide how to stand toward that answerability without Locke's excuse of ignorance.

Third, the self is a palimpsest co-written by others and held by them in trust, or in pawn. Memory held by others is never neutral; it is held *for* one or *against* one.

The third thesis points to the next chapter. If the Nameless One's past lives in others' beliefs about him, and if in his cosmos belief is a constitutive force, then he is partly made of what others believe him to be. Ian Hacking's looping effects, by which classifications reshape the people classified, take on literal ontological force here. In a doxastically realist cosmos, the allomnesic subject is not only remembered by others but partly created by them. The argument now turns to the nature and ethics of that creation.

CHAPTER



III

DOXASTIC ONTOLOGY

Belief, Speech, and the Ethics of Worldmaking

3.1 From Warrant to Authorship

W. K. Clifford opened "The Ethics of Belief" (1877) with a shipowner. By suppressing his doubts, the shipowner comes sincerely to believe that his aging vessel is seaworthy, sends it to sea, and collects the insurance when it sinks. Clifford holds him guilty of the deaths. He would be just as guilty had the ship arrived safely, because the wrong lies in how the belief was formed, not in its consequences. His principle, "It is wrong always, everywhere, and for any one, to believe anything upon insufficient evidence," set the terms of a century of debate. James's reply (1896) marked out genuine options, live, forced, and momentous, where evidence cannot decide and refusing to believe is itself a decision made on passional grounds.

Both sides assumed that belief answers to a world it does not make. Clifford's shipowner cannot make the ship seaworthy by believing it so, which is exactly why his belief is culpable.

In a doxastically realist cosmos this assumption fails within a defined domain. In the Outer Planes, a sufficiently shared and intense conviction that a ship is seaworthy might, in principle, help make it so. The consequences for the ethics of belief are structural, not merely quantitative. Belief now answers to two distinct norms:

- **Epistemic:** does the belief fit the world?
- **Demiurgic:** what world will the belief help make?

Bernard Williams argued that one cannot believe at will, because a state one knew one had adopted regardless of its truth would not count as belief (Williams 1973). Planescape does not contradict Williams; its inhabitants still believe their beliefs are true. It adds that believing contributes causally to the truth believed. Belief's aim becomes partly self-fulfilling, and the believer is responsible not only for fit but for fabrication.

The doxastic commons. Nelson Goodman held that we make worlds by making versions of them, that worldmaking always starts from worlds already at hand, and that every making is a remaking (Goodman 1978). For Goodman this was a thesis about symbols, versions, and rightness of rendering. In Planescape it is a thesis about geography.

The Outer Planes are a *doxastic commons*: a shared medium continuously reshaped by the aggregated beliefs of countless believers, which no single believer controls. Like every commons, it is subject to tragedy. Beliefs held individually for private reasons can add up to planar drifts nobody intended.

The ethics of such a commons cannot be exhausted by Clifford's individualist evidentialism or James's individualist voluntarism. It needs an account of shared, structural, and cumulative responsibility. The next sections develop that account through three of the game's most philosophically dense episodes.

3.2 Adahn: The Lie as Cosmogony

The Adahn episode looks trivial: a lie repeated often enough produces a man. Its apparent triviality is the measure of its radicalism.

Asked his name, the protagonist may answer that it is Adahn. This is a lie, and the game, which lets lies and vows alike register on his alignment, treats it as one. If he repeats the lie often enough, a man answering to the name Adahn appears in the Smoldering Corpse Bar: unremarkable, ordinary, and real.

Speech-act theory. Austin distinguished constatives, which describe and may be true or false, from performatives, which do what they say ("I name this ship") and succeed or fail according to conventions (Austin 1962). "I am Adahn" is a constative, and false. What turns it into a performative is not any single utterance but iteration.

Derrida, answering Austin, argued that performativity depends on iterability, the repeatability of an utterance as citation. The conventions Austin treated as external conditions are themselves products of repetition (Derrida 1972). Judith Butler developed this into a theory of performativity as the reiteration of norms that produces the effects it names (Butler 1990; 1993; 1997).

Adahn is iterability as the origin of being. No single lie creates him; the repeated citation accumulates a person. The game models, with a precision no theoretical text could match, the thesis that reiterated discourse can produce what it claims merely to describe.

The golem and the creature. Mythology supplies a second frame. In the golem legend, a clay figure is animated by the inscription *emet*, "truth," on its brow, and returned to dust when a single letter is erased, leaving *met*, "dead." Adahn is a golem

animated not by *emet* but by its negation, a being called to life by a falsehood. In Jewish esoteric tradition the golem is animated by the divine Name. The Nameless One, who has no name, animates his creature by giving it a false one.

Mary Shelley's creature states the claim such a being has on its maker: "Remember, that I am thy creature; I ought to be thy Adam; but I am rather the fallen angel, whom thou drivest from joy for no misdeed" (Shelley 1818, II.2).

Borges's "The Circular Ruins" adds the dreamer's fear that his creature might discover it is a phantom, and then the dreamer's discovery that he too is dreamed. The Nameless One's own deathless condition is the product of another's craft, Ravel's ritual. In Adahn he makes a being out of his own words. The relation of creature to creator repeats down the chain.

Kant on lying, made literal. The ethical corollary is severe. Kant's notorious essay on the supposed right to lie from benevolent motives (1797) held that the liar answers for every consequence of his lie, however well meant, because the lie removes him from the protection of right. Kant has been faulted for rigorism, and fairly so in a world where lies change only minds.

In a doxastically realist cosmos, Kant's claim becomes unexpectedly literal. The liar answers for the lie's consequences, and those consequences may include the existence of a person. A lie is not only a wrong done to the deceived; it is an act of creation that carries a creator's responsibilities.

Williams analyzed truthfulness into two virtues, Accuracy and Sincerity (Williams 2002). In Planescape these become cosmological virtues, because inaccuracy and insincerity are not only failures of representation but interventions in being.

The Pillar of Skulls. The setting institutionalizes this principle in one of its most striking images. The Pillar of Skulls in Baator is made from the heads of those whose words in life led others to ruin, and it must answer the questions of those who come to it, for a price. It is the multiverse's court of testimonial liability, damnation for the misuse of speech. It is also where Morte, the protagonist's first companion and a habitual liar, was taken from. In a cosmos where speech makes worlds, the misleading speaker commits a crime against being, and the Pillar is the prison of failed world-makers.

3.3 Vhailor and the Transcendent One: Conviction Without a Believer

Vhailor. If Adahn is belief making a person, Vhailor is belief outliving one. He is an empty suit of armor animated by nothing but the conviction that justice must be done, a conviction that persists after the death of the man who wore it. The conviction has become its own bearer. The believer has evaporated into the belief.

Peirce's "The Fixation of Belief" (1877) described four ways people settle their opinions: tenacity, authority, the a priori method, and the method of science. The first, tenacity, consists in clinging to a belief and avoiding whatever might unsettle it. Vhailor is tenacity personified, and more than personified, made into a being. His belief is not held by a subject; it holds itself. He cannot revise it, because no one is left to do the revising, and the conviction's persistence is the only persistence there is.

Hegel's analysis of absolute freedom and terror in the *Phenomenology* (1807) describes the politics of such a conviction. Its subject is the Jacobin Terror of 1793–94, when the Revolutionary Tribunal and its provincial counterparts sent thousands to the guillotine, many of them condemned as mere "suspects." A universal will that has stripped away every particular content can only negate, and its only work is death: "der kälteste, platteste Tod, ohne mehr Bedeutung als das Durchhauen eines Kohlhaupts oder ein Schluck Wassers" (§590). That is, the coldest, flattest death, with no more meaning than cutting through a head of cabbage or swallowing a mouthful of water. Hegel's name for such a will is *die Furie des Verschwindens*, the fury of disappearance (§589). Vhailor is that fury wearing armor. Chapter IV reads his faction, the Mercykillers, in the same light.

The Transcendent One. The Transcendent One is the complementary case: an entity sustained by its own self-conception. It is the protagonist's mortality, split from him by Ravel's ritual, which has come to regard itself as transcendent and to will its continued separation. It is a finitude that believes itself infinite, a death that believes itself a god.

Daniel Dennett proposed that the self is a "center of narrative gravity," a theoretical fiction like a physical center of gravity: useful for organizing the data of a life, but not a real thing (Dennett 1992). In Planescape, a center of narrative gravity can acquire mass. The Transcendent One is a self-narrative that has become an agent, and its narrative is that it need not die.

What distinguishes a person from a conviction. Side by side, Vhailor and the Transcendent One put a question to the protagonist that goes to the heart of the game. If conviction can persist as an agent after its bearer dies, and if self-conception

can sustain an entity that should not exist, what separates the Nameless One from either? His body is animated, his memory borrowed, his intentions installed. He might be nothing more than a Vhailor of the Practical Incarnation's plan, a conviction wearing flesh.

The answer the game implies is the capacity to revise belief:

- Vhailor cannot revise his conviction.
- The Transcendent One will not revise its self-conception.
- The Nameless One can revise both the plan he inherits and the self he believes himself to be.

Peirce held that of the four methods of fixing belief, only science submits belief to correction by something beyond itself. In a doxastic cosmos, the willingness to let one's beliefs be corrected is more than an epistemic virtue. It is the criterion that separates a person from a conviction.

3.4 Curst: The Tragedy of the Doxastic Commons

The gate-town of Curst stands in the Outlands beside the portal to Carceri, the plane of prisons. It is a town of traitors, betrayers, and exiles, and its slide into Carceri is the game's most spectacular demonstration of collective belief acting as a cause. The narrative makes the slide coincide with the betrayal at the center of the Curst episode, so that the individual treachery of the fallen deva Trias and the aggregate treachery of a population appear as two scales of one law.

Plato's city and soul. The philosophical antecedent is Platonic. In Book VIII of the *Republic*, Socrates opens his account of how constitutions degenerate by asking whether Glaucon thinks constitutions arise "from some oak or rock" rather than from the characters of the people living in the cities (544d–e, my translation). A city's constitution is its citizens' character writ large. As that character decays, the constitution follows, through timocracy, oligarchy, and democracy, down to tyranny.

Curst is this thesis made spatial. The city's location follows its character. A city whose soul has become a prison is carried, by the physics of the planes, to the plane of prisons.

Thresholds. The Hebrew Bible supplies a second antecedent that introduces the idea of a threshold. Bargaining with God over Sodom, Abraham talks down the number of righteous people whose presence would save the city from fifty to ten:

"Peradventure ten shall be found there. And he said, I will not destroy it for ten's sake" (Genesis 18:32, KJV). A city's fate depends on its overall moral composition, and there is a threshold below which it cannot be saved.

Twentieth-century social science formalized such thresholds:

- Garrett Hardin's tragedy of the commons (1968) showed how individually rational uses of a shared resource add up to collective ruin.
- Thomas Schelling's and Mark Granovetter's threshold models (Schelling 1978; Granovetter 1978) showed how small individual dispositions can tip a population into states no member intended.

Curst's slide is a tipping point in the doxastic commons. No citizen intended it, and every citizen contributed to it.

Structural responsibility. Such cases raise the question of structural responsibility. Iris Marion Young distinguished two models (Young 2011):

- a *liability model*, backward-looking and grounded in individual fault;
- a *social connection model*, forward-looking and grounded in participation in structural processes that produce injustice.

Curst's citizens are responsible in the second sense even where they are not in the first. Each traitor's belief fed the drift, and each bears a share of the outcome, though none authored it.

The Nameless One's dealings with Trias put him inside this structure, not above it, and his situation throughout the game has the same double character. He bears liability, without memory of fault, for his former selves' deeds. He also bears structural responsibility for the ongoing process by which his persistence consumes others. Chapter VIII will argue that his final choice combines Young's two models: backward-looking in accepting liability, forward-looking in ending the process.

3.5 Limbo and the Karach: The Askēsis of Belief

If belief can move cities and make persons, the ethics of belief cannot stop at warrant or authorship. It needs an account of how belief is formed, sustained, and disciplined, and the game supplies one through its githzerai.

In the setting's lore, the githzerai live in Limbo, a plane of raw chaos whose substance takes shape only under the pressure of a disciplined mind. Their fortresses stand only as long as their minds hold them. Dak'kon's *karach* blade, made from the stuff of

Limbo, keeps its shape and edge only while its bearer's conviction holds. In Dak'kon's own telling, the githzerai city of Shra'kt'lor was held together by its people's will, and he was a leader whose word they relied on to keep that will firm. When he came to doubt Zerthimon's teaching, his doubt spread through them, and the city weakened and fell.

The Stoic citadel. The Stoic tradition supplies the concepts:

- Epictetus teaches that people are disturbed not by things but by their judgments about things: "*Ταράσσει τοὺς ἀνθρώπους ὐ τὰ πράγματα, ἀλλὰ τὰ περὶ τῶν πραγμάτων δόγματα*" (*Enchiridion* 5). The only thing wholly in our power is the use of impressions, whether to assent to an appearance or withhold assent (*Discourses* I.1).
- Marcus Aurelius calls the mind free of passions a citadel: *ἀκρόπολίς ἐστιν ἡ ἐλευθέρα παθῶν διάνοια* (*Meditations* VIII.48).
- Pierre Hadot titled his study of Marcus *The Inner Citadel* (1992) and argued that ancient philosophy was above all a practice of spiritual exercises, *askēsis*, through which the self is transformed (Hadot 1981; 1995).

In Limbo, the Stoic's inner citadel becomes an outer one. The githzerai build fortresses out of mental discipline, and doubt is not just an inner disturbance but a structural failure. Zerthimon's teaching, the Unbroken Circle, is a manual of spiritual exercises whose results are architectural and martial.

Cultivation, not volition. The githzerai case clarifies how doxastic realism relates to doxastic voluntarism. Williams's argument that one cannot believe at will holds in Limbo as everywhere else. If one decided to believe one's fortress sound regardless of evidence, the resulting state would not be belief and would not hold the walls up. Belief cannot be commanded; it can be cultivated.

Pascal saw this when he advised the would-be believer who cannot argue himself into faith to act as if he believed, take holy water, and have masses said: "cela vous fera croire et vous abêtira," this will make you believe and will make you stupid (*Pensées*, Laf. 418). Pascal's "machine," the body trained by habit, produces belief indirectly, and his candid *abêtira* names the cost.

The githzerai discipline sits at the opposite pole: belief produced not by the dulling of habit but by the lucidity of practice. In both cases the lesson is the same. The ethics of worldmaking requires an ethics of cultivating belief. A person is not responsible for what he chooses to believe at a given moment, which is not in his power. He is responsible for the practices by which he forms, tests, and sustains his beliefs over time, which are.

Dak'kon's crisis is that of a practitioner whose practice has failed him, and the game makes the protagonist a participant in repairing it. He can study the Circle, question Dak'kon's understanding of it, and help him recover a relation to its teaching. Chapter V examines the epistemology of that relation. For now it is enough to note where the game's treatment of belief ends up. It is not the voluntarism of the Sign of One, which holds that the self imagines the multiverse into being. It is a discipline in which belief must be earned, tested, and sustained against the pressure of chaos.

3.6 Three Models of Mind-Made Reality: Solaris, Ubik, Tlön

Philosophical science fiction offers three developed models of mind-made reality, and *Torment* contains all three.

Return (Lem). In Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961), the ocean covering an alien planet probes the minds of the scientists orbiting it and materializes their most charged memories as physical visitors. Kelvin's visitor is Harey, the young wife who killed herself after he left her. The ocean makes reality not from belief but from the mind's deepest traces, and what it makes is guilt given form. The scientists came to make contact with an absolute other and find themselves confronting themselves; the novel suggests that humans want not other worlds but mirrors.

Torment's Fortress of Regrets is a Solaris of the self: a place anchored by the protagonist's regrets and peopled by the shades of his former selves. Deionarra, the dead lover whose death an earlier self deliberately brought about and who still waits for him, is his Harey.

Predation (Dick). In Philip K. Dick's *Ubik* (1969), the recently dead are kept in cold-pac, a half-life in which consciousness lingers, dimming, and can be consulted by the living. Reality in the novel decays toward entropy as objects regress to earlier forms. Its hidden engine is Jory, a half-lifer who prolongs his own existence by consuming the remaining life of the half-lifers around him, and who fabricates the world they inhabit while he devours them.

This is mind-made reality as parasitism: the strongest consciousness writes the world of the weaker and feeds on them. It is also the closest twentieth-century science fiction comes to anticipating allothanasia, a persistence financed by consuming other lives. Chapter VI returns to it.

Hegemony (Borges). In Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940), an invented planet whose idealist metaphysics produces objects from expectation gradually displaces the real world. Its encyclopedias, artifacts, and language invade reality, and the

narrator foresees a world that will become Tlön. Here mind-made reality is the victory of a sufficiently coherent fiction over its rivals.

Sigil's factional politics, the struggle among fifteen philosophies to author the planes, is the Tlön model institutionalized. Each faction is a candidate Tlön trying to become the world.

One cosmos, three faces. That all three models coexist in *Torment* is diagnosis, not eclecticism:

- The Fortress of Regrets shows reality returning to the self as guilt.
- The Nameless One's persistence shows reality consumed by the self as predation.
- Sigil shows reality contested among selves as hegemony.

The game's claim, carried by its structure rather than any single speech, is that these are three faces of the same doxastic cosmos. Where belief makes reality, the past returns, the strong feed on the weak, and doctrines fight for mastery. The question is not whether belief will make the world, but which belief, whose, and at whose expense.

Conclusion to Chapter III: Toward an Ethics of Doxastic Stewardship

Six principles can now be drawn from the game's doxastic ontology:

1. **Belief is action.** In a doxastically realist cosmos, to believe is to intervene.
2. **Testimony is legislation.** To cause others to believe is to shape the world they will live in, and the Pillar of Skulls is the jurisprudence of that power.
3. **The lie is cosmogony.** False speech, repeated, can produce beings, and the liar bears a creator's responsibilities.
4. **Collective belief is a commons.** It is subject to tragedy and tipping points, and it generates structural responsibility shared among everyone who contributes to it.
5. **Belief cannot be willed but can be cultivated.** Doxastic responsibility therefore lies in the practices by which belief is formed and sustained.
6. **Revisability is the mark of a person.** The capacity to revise one's convictions under correction is what separates a person from a conviction.

These principles bear directly on Ravel's question. "Belief" is among the answers the game's cosmology most obviously invites: in a cosmos where belief shapes planes, it would be strange if it could not shape a man. This chapter shows why belief alone is not enough:

- Vhailor proves that belief can persist unchanged beyond its bearer's death.
- The Transcendent One proves that belief can entrench a self against every pressure to change.
- Curst proves that belief can transform a community without anyone choosing the transformation.

Belief can change the nature of a man, but it can also fix that nature, entomb it, or sell it into prison. What decides among these outcomes is not belief as such but belief's relation to what lies outside it. That relation has two dimensions: the past that others hold, the allomnesia of Chapter II, and the death that others have borne, the allothanasia of Chapter VI.

Between those two chapters stand the institutions and persons through which the game gives these principles concrete form. The factions of Sigil are read in the next chapter as a disputation among the philosophical schools of the multiverse. The companions, the Nameless One's court of witnesses, are the subject of the chapter after.

CHAPTER



IV

THE POLIS OF DOCTRINES

The Factions of Sigil as a Disputation of Schools

4.1 The Faction as a Philosophical Form

Planescape's factions are an institutional form with no exact historical precedent. Each is at once a philosophical school, a political party, a religious confession, and a municipal bureau. Each holds a doctrine about the nature of the multiverse, recruits and disciplines members, keeps a headquarters, and administers a public function in Sigil. The nearest historical analogues capture only pieces of this form:

- the Hellenistic schools (Academy, Lyceum, Stoa, Garden), which Pierre Hadot taught us to read as ways of life rather than bodies of doctrine (Hadot 1995);
- the medieval religious orders and university faculties, which fused doctrine, discipline, and institutional power;
- the modern political party, whose drift toward oligarchy Robert Michels formulated as an iron law (Michels 1911).

Doctrine and office. What none of these achieves, and what Planescape makes systematic, is an exact fit between a doctrine and the civic office its adherents hold:

- The Dustmen, who believe everyone is already dead, run the Mortuary.
- The Mercykillers, who believe justice must be absolute, run the Prison.
- The Fated, who believe the multiverse belongs to whoever takes it, keep the Hall of Records and collect the city's taxes.
- The Bleak Cabal, who believe nothing means anything, run the asylum.
- The Sign of One, each of whose members believes that he imagines the multiverse into being, keep the Hall of Speakers, where the city deliberates. It is a parliament of solipsists.

Every public function in Sigil is thus administered by a metaphysics. Louis Althusser argued that a social order reproduces itself through "ideological state apparatuses": schools, churches, courts, and other institutions that teach the ideology the order requires (Althusser 1970). In Sigil this is not a critical discovery but the city's published constitution. Each apparatus announces its ideology on the door.

Precedents for a city of confessions. The literary tradition of disputation among faiths offers closer precedents than political history does.

- **Llull.** Ramon Llull's *Book of the Gentile and the Three Wise Men* (c. 1274–1276) has a gentile hear a Jew, a Christian, and a Muslim set out their faiths. The three sages

leave before the gentile announces his choice, so that their conversation can continue without a verdict. This refusal anticipates the modal structure of the role-playing game, in which the text withholds judgment and the player joins, or declines to join, a school.

- **Boccaccio and Lessing.** Boccaccio's tale of the three rings (*Decameron* I.3), recast by Lessing in *Nathan der Weise* (1779), tells of a father with one precious ring and three beloved sons, who has two indistinguishable copies made. When the sons dispute which ring is genuine, the judge tells each to prove his ring's virtue by his conduct. The parable is built from two of Planescape's planar axioms, the triad and the ring. Its moral is the one the game enacts: a doctrine's truth is shown in deeds, not in the doctrine.
- **Bodin.** Jean Bodin's *Colloquium Heptaplomeres* (c. 1588) gathers seven speakers of seven confessions in Venice, where they debate and part as friends without reaching agreement.
- **Spinoza.** Spinoza's *Tractatus Theologico-Politicus* (1670) concludes that the true end of the state is freedom ("Finis ergo Reipublicae revera libertas est," ch. 20). He offers Amsterdam, where adherents of every sect live together in peace, as proof.

Sigil is Bodin's Venice and Spinoza's Amsterdam, governed not by a republic but by a silent sovereign whose nature §4.8 examines.

Bakhtin's concept of polyphony, formulated for Dostoevsky's novels, describes the literary form the city takes. It is a plurality of independent, unmerged consciousnesses, each carrying the full weight of its own world, none subordinated to the author's final word (Bakhtin 1929/1963). *Torment* endorses no faction and lets the player join several. It appears to withhold the author's final word. This chapter argues that the word is spoken nonetheless, by the game's structure rather than by its characters.

4.2 A Doxography of the Fifteen

Faction (epithet)	Core tenet	Civic seat	Philosophical lineage	The Nameless One as *reductio*
Athar (the Lost)	The Powers are frauds; true divinity lies beyond them	Shattered Temple	Xenophanes; Feuerbach; Eckhart; Tillich	The only "god" he meets is his own alienated death
Believers of the Source (Godsmen)	Every being can ascend to divinity through trials across lives	Great Foundry	*Phaedrus*; Plotinus; Origen; *theōsis*	Countless lives without ascent; his test is passed by descent
Bleak Cabal (Bleakers)	The multiverse has no meaning; seek it, if anywhere, within	Gatehouse (asylum)	Schopenhauer; Camus	Meaning is made by assuming a debt, not found
Doomguard (Sinkers)	Entropy is the multiverse's law and should be served	Armory	Clausius; Mainländer; Freud	His persistence exports decay to others
Dustmen (the Dead)	All are already dead; purge passion to reach the True Death	Mortuary	*Phaedo*; Orphic *sōma sēma*; Schopenhauer	The True Death would free him and leave his debts unpaid
Fated (Takers)	The multiverse belongs to whoever can take it	Hall of Records (taxes)	Thrasymachus; Callicles; Stirner	The greatest taker of all: he takes deaths
Fraternity of Order (Guvners)	All things have laws; know them and exploit their loopholes	City Court	Leibniz; Laplace; Kelsen; Hilbert	His immortality is a loophole in death, paid for by others
Free League (Indeps)	No one may dictate belief; belong to nothing	Great Bazaar	Pyrrho; Mill; Berlin	The most unaffiliated man is the most dependent
Harmonium (Hardheads)	Peace through enforced agreement	City Barracks	Plato; Hobbes; Rousseau	A self that cannot agree with itself
Mercykillers (Red Death)	Justice is absolute; mercy is corruption	Prison	Kant's retributivism; Hegel	Justice is done when he wills his own sentence
Revolutionary League (Anarchists)	Every faction is corrupt; tear them all down	None (clandestine)	Proudhon; Bakunin; Marx	A self already torn down must rebuild, not demolish
Sign of One (Signers)	The self imagines the multiverse into being	Hall of Speakers	Berkeley; Fichte; Stirner	The world imagines him: others hold his past
Society of Sensation (Sensates)	Truth comes only through experience	Civic Festhall	Aristippus; Locke; Pater; Nozick	Endless experience, almost none retained

Faction (epithet)	Core tenet	Civic seat	Philosophical lineage	The Nameless One as *reductio*
Transcendent Order (Ciphers)	Act without thought, in harmony with the multiverse	Great Gymnasium	Zhuangzi; Zen; Dreyfus	His body acts without thought, and the deeds became debts
Xaositects (Chaosmen)	Chaos is truth; order is illusion	The Hive	Heraclitus; Dada; Discordianism	A life of fragments that seeks, in the end, an order

The last column compresses this chapter's central claim. Each faction's doctrine finds in the Nameless One both its most perfect instance and its refutation. He is a *reductio per exemplum* of the whole city: every school finds in him the case that proves it and the case that breaks it. The sections that follow develop the claim for the factions whose doctrines bear most directly on his condition.

4.3 The Practice of Dying: The Dustmen and the Refusal of the True Death

The Dustmen hold that every being is already dead. What we call life is a pale afterimage of an earlier existence, and the task of the dead is to purge passion and attachment until they are ready for the True Death, a final cessation beyond any further existence. They run the Mortuary where the game begins, and their dispassion is institutional: they process the dead, work corpses as laborers, and treat the living with courteous melancholy.

Three ancestors.

- **Platonic.** In the *Phaedo*, Socrates says that those who pursue philosophy rightly practice nothing other than dying and being dead (64a). The Orphic-Pythagorean pun that the body (*sōma*) is a tomb (*sēma*), cited in the *Gorgias* (493a) and *Cratylus* (400c), supplies the Dustmen's founding image: life is already entombment. Montaigne's essay "Que philosopher c'est apprendre à mourir" (1580) carried the thesis into modernity.
- **Schopenhauerian.** The first volume of *The World as Will and Representation* ends with the denial of the will. For those in whom the will has turned and denied itself, "diese unsere so sehr reale Welt mit allen ihren Sonnen und Milchstraßen" is "Nichts" (1819, §71): our so very real world, with all its suns and galaxies, is nothing.
- **Buddhist.** *Nibbāna* derives from a root meaning "to blow out." The Dustmen's True Death reads the extinction of craving as the extinction of the flame itself.

Freud gave the complex a psychoanalytic name. In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), he took from Barbara Low the term "Nirvana principle" for the mind's tendency to reduce tension toward zero, and read it as an expression of the death drive. The Dustmen are the Nirvana principle institutionalized.

The Dustmen's scandal. The Nameless One is the dead man who will not stay dead: dead many times over and never finished. He is also the most passionate of the dead, driven by a desire to know that no death extinguishes. The tattoo warns that revealing his condition would send him to the crematorium. To the faction that runs the Mortuary, then, he is not a curiosity but an error to be corrected.

Why the game refuses the True Death. The True Death is, in principle, the obvious exit from his torment, and the game's refusal of it is philosophically deliberate. The Dustmen's soteriology is self-regarding. It addresses the passion of the one who dies, not the deaths of those who died for him. For the Nameless One, extinction would end the torment and leave the ledger unsettled. It would be escape, not settlement.

This is not a rejection of Buddhism but a rehearsal of Buddhism's own internal critique. The Mahāyāna tradition criticized the pursuit of private liberation in the name of the bodhisattva, who vows to defer final release until all beings are freed. Śāntideva's *Bodhicaryāvatāra* (VIII.120) calls the practice of regarding others as oneself and oneself as others, *parātmaparivartana* or the "exchange of self and other," the supreme secret of the path. Allothanasia is the demonic inversion of that exchange: the Nameless One has exchanged others for himself. The game's resolution reverses the exchange.

Read this way, the Dustmen's True Death is less *nibbāna* than Schopenhauerian quietism in Buddhist robes. The game rejects the quietism, not the dharma. Its closest approach to Buddhist ethics lies not in the Mortuary but in the ending, where a being sustained by others' deaths takes back his own.

4.4 Ascent and Apophasis: The Godsmen and the Athar

The Godsmen. The Believers of the Source hold that every being carries the potential for divinity and rises toward it through a succession of lives. Each life is a test: failure sends the soul down, success raises it. Their headquarters is the Great Foundry, an apt image of the soul as ore refined by repeated firing. The theological lineage is ancient and distinguished:

- Plato's *Phaedrus* (248e–249a), in which souls return through ten-thousand-year cycles unless three successive lives of philosophy release them early;
- Plotinus's return (*epistrophē*) of the soul to the One;
- Origen's *apokatastasis*, the eventual restoration of all souls;
- the Eastern doctrine of *theōsis*, compressed in Athanasius's formula that God "became human so that we might become divine" (*αὐτὸς γὰρ ἐνηνθρώπησεν, ἵνα ἡμεῖς θεοποιηθῶμεν*, *De Incarnatione* 54.3).

The Nameless One refutes the Godsmen's meliorism by sheer repetition. He has lived more lives than any Godsman could hope to count and has not ascended; he has recurred without progressing. His case sets Nietzsche's eternal recurrence against every theodicy of cumulative improvement.

When his test is finally passed, it is passed by descent rather than ascent: he walks down into the Blood War, not up into divinity. The theological term for this movement is not *theōsis* but *kenōsis*, the self-emptying by which, in the hymn of Philippians 2, the divine "emptied himself" (*ἑαυτὸν ἐκένωσεν*, 2:7) to take the form of a servant and accept death. The Godsmen imagine a being made divine through trial. The game shows a being made human through the acceptance of a sentence.

The Athar. At the opposite pole, the Athar hold that the Powers are frauds: mighty beings, not gods. The true divine, if it exists, is a Great Unknown beyond them. Their headquarters is the Shattered Temple, which in the setting's lore once belonged to Aoskar, the god of portals, whom the Lady of Pain destroyed when his worship grew too strong in her city.

Their lineage runs through three stages:

- Xenophanes observed that if oxen, horses, and lions had hands, they would draw gods shaped like oxen, horses, and lions (B15).
- Feuerbach's projection theory (Chapter I) made the gods a mirror of their worshippers.
- The apophatic tradition refused to identify the divine with any object of worship. Meister Eckhart prays God to rid him of God: "Ich bite got, daz er mich ledic mache gotes" (*Predigt* 52). Paul Tillich names "the God above God," who appears when the God of theism has disappeared in doubt (Tillich 1952).

The Athar are apophatic atheists: they deny the gods in the name of the divine.

In *Torment*'s cosmology they are, from the protagonist's standpoint, right. The Powers are barred from Sigil and never appear. The only being in the game that claims transcendence is the Transcendent One, and it is not a god but the protagonist's own alienated mortality. The Athar and the Lady of Pain converge, as §4.8 shows: both keep the place of the divine empty.

4.5 The Epistemic Schools: Sensates, Guvners, Ciphers, Signers

Four factions are best read as epistemologies, that is, as theories of how truth is reached.

The Society of Sensation. The Sensates hold that truth comes only through experience, and that one must therefore experience everything. Their lineage combines Cyrenaic hedonism, which located the good in present pleasure; the empiricism of Locke and Hume, for whom every idea derives from impressions; and Walter Pater's notorious conclusion to *The Renaissance* (1873): "To burn always with this hard, gem-like flame, to maintain this ecstasy, is success in life."

Their Civic Festhall houses the Sensorium, where sensory stones let a visitor live through another's recorded experience. The stones realize a limited version of Robert Nozick's experience machine (1974). Nozick asked whether we would plug into a device that supplied any experience we wanted, and argued that we would not, for three reasons:

- we want to do things, not merely to feel that we do them;
- we want to be certain kinds of persons;
- we want contact with a reality deeper than our sensations.

The Sensate ideal is vulnerable to all three objections. The stones sharpen a fourth that Nozick did not consider: experience detachable from its subject becomes a commodity (Chapter II, §2.6).

The Nameless One is the Sensate ideal realized and refuted. He has had more experiences than any Sensate could gather across a hundred lifetimes, and he retains almost none of them. Experience without memory is not knowledge but *Erlebnis* without *Erfahrung*: isolated episodes never integrated into a remembered life. Pushed to its limit, the Sensate program yields a man who has felt everything and knows nothing of himself.

The Fraternity of Order. The Guvners hold that everything in the multiverse is governed by laws. Whoever knows the laws can master the multiverse, and whoever knows them perfectly can find their loopholes. Their lineage runs:

- from Leibniz's dream of a universal calculus in which disputes would be settled by the command *Calculemus!*;
- through Laplace's intelligence that, knowing every force and position at a given instant, "embrasserait dans la même formule les mouvements des plus grands corps de l'univers et ceux du plus léger atome" (1814);
- to Kelsen's pure theory of law and Hilbert's program for a complete and consistent axiomatization of mathematics.

Gödel's incompleteness theorems (1931) are the Guvners' nightmare: any sufficiently powerful system of laws contains truths it cannot prove.

The Guvners' deepest affinity with the Nameless One lies in the loophole. His first incarnation, knowing that his crime had damned him however much good he did with the rest of his life, sought through Ravel's ritual an exemption from the law that the dead go where their deeds send them. He wanted the exemption in order to atone: to have time for the good that one lifetime could not hold. Immortality is the greatest loophole in the multiverse. The game adds what the Guvners miss: every loophole is financed by someone, including a loophole sought for the sake of repentance. The Nameless One's exemption from death is paid for by others' deaths. A loophole does not abolish a cost. It shifts the cost onto those outside the contract; it creates an externality.

A minor figure dramatizes the Guvners' confusion of legality with morality. Fhjull Forked-Tongue is a fiend bound by pact to do good: he acts beneficently because a contract compels him. Kant distinguished two pairs of terms:

- action *in accordance with* duty versus action *from* duty (*Groundwork*, 4:397–399);
- legality (*Legalität*), the mere conformity of an act to law, versus morality (*Moralität*), which requires that the law itself be the motive (*Metaphysics of Morals*, 6:219).

Fhjull is legality without morality in its purest form: a demon whose every good act goes against his will.

The Transcendent Order. The Ciphers hold that thought gets between the self and right action, and that one should train oneself to act without deliberation, in harmony with the multiverse. Their lineage is Daoist and Zen:

- Zhuangzi's Cook Ding carves oxen for nineteen years without dulling his blade, because he meets the carcass with spirit rather than eyes and follows its natural joints (*Zhuangzi*, ch. 3).
- The *Daodejing* holds that one who pursues learning gains something every day, while one who pursues the Dao loses something every day (ch. 48).

Phenomenology later supplied the theory: Heidegger's readiness-to-hand, Merleau-Ponty's motor intentionality, and Hubert Dreyfus's account of absorbed skillful coping (Dreyfus 1991). The Dreyfus–McDowell debate over whether expert action is permeated by conceptual rationality is, in effect, a debate over the Ciphers' central claim.

The Nameless One, whose body acts with a competence his mind does not possess, is a natural Cipher. His history exposes the doctrine's ambiguity, because action without thought has two readings:

- the virtuoso's embodied wisdom, Cook Ding's effortless precision;
- what Hannah Arendt called thoughtlessness, the absence of the inner dialogue in which conscience operates, which she found at the root of the banality of evil (Arendt 1963; 1971). Her case was Adolf Eichmann, the SS officer who organized the deportation of millions of Jews to the ghettos and extermination camps, whom she watched at his 1961 trial in Jerusalem. Later historians, drawing on Eichmann's own writings and recorded interviews, have shown him to have been a committed antisemite and contest her reading of him (Stangneth 2011).

The debts the protagonist inherits were run up by selves who acted with great skill and too little of the second kind of thought. The Cipher ideal is ethically incomplete unless the harmony it seeks includes harmony with those one's actions affect.

The Sign of One. The Signers hold that each of them imagines the multiverse into being. Their lineage runs from Berkeley's immaterialism, through Fichte's absolute I, which "setzt ursprünglich schlechthin sein eigenes Seyn" (originally and absolutely posits its own being, *Wissenschaftslehre*, 1794), to Stirner's egoist declaration, borrowed from Goethe: "Ich hab' mein' Sach' auf Nichts gestellt" (1844). Their comedy is structural. A faction of solipsists is a contradiction in terms. A council hall of solipsists, each of whom believes the others are his figments, is the setting's sharpest satire of liberal parliamentarism.

The Nameless One inverts their doctrine. He does not imagine the world. The world, in the form of those who hold his past, imagines him.

4.6 The Enforcers of Order: Harmonium and Mercykillers

The Harmonium. The Harmonium hold that peace requires harmony, that harmony requires agreement, and that agreement may be enforced. They are Sigil's police. Their lineage includes Plato's Kallipolis, in which justice is each class doing its own work under the rule of the wise, and Hobbes's Leviathan, whose sovereign ends the war of all against all. Above all it includes Rousseau's *Social Contract*, whose most notorious sentence the Harmonium could take as a motto: "quiconque refusera d'obéir à la volonté générale y sera contraint par tout le corps: ce qui ne signifie autre chose sinon qu'on le forcera d'être libre" (I.7, 1762).

Whoever refuses to obey the general will shall be constrained to it by the whole body, which means nothing other than that he will be forced to be free. J. L. Talmon traced "totalitarian democracy" to this sentence (Talmon 1952), and Isaiah Berlin found in it the characteristic perversion of positive liberty (Berlin 1958).

Claude Lefort's analysis of totalitarianism supplies the sharpest frame (Lefort 1979; 1986). For Lefort, modern democracy is the regime in which the place of power is empty and society is irreducibly divided. Totalitarianism tries to abolish that division by embodying power in "the People-as-One" (*le Peuple-Un*), a society made uniform and transparent to itself. The Harmonium is the People-as-One as a policing program.

The game contains a grotesque emblem of the same aspiration. The Many-as-One, the collective mind formed by a swarm of cranium rats, is a unity composed of many bodies, and its name echoes Lefort's formula almost exactly. Its visual ancestor is the frontispiece of Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651), in which the sovereign's giant body is made of countless tiny subjects. In the Warrens of Thought, the Leviathan is rendered as vermin: the dream of the many made one, realized in the sewer.

The Mercykillers. The Mercykillers hold that justice must be absolute and that mercy corrupts it. They run the Prison. Their philosophical ancestor is Kant's retributivism at its most uncompromising:

- In the *Metaphysics of Morals*, Kant argues that even if a civil society dissolved itself by unanimous consent, "müßte der letzte im Gefängniß befindliche Mörder vorher hingerichtet werden" (6:333). The last murderer in prison would first have to be executed, so that each receives what his deeds are worth and blood-guilt does not cling to the people.
- In *Perpetual Peace* (1795), Kant glosses the proverb *fiat iustitia, pereat mundus* as "let justice reign, even if all the rogues in the world must perish."

Hegel's analysis of absolute freedom as the fury of disappearance (Chapter III, §3.3) describes what such a justice becomes when it is organized into a faction.

The Mercykillers' name is a polemic against a tradition that placed mercy at the summit of sovereignty. Portia's speech in *The Merchant of Venice* states that tradition plainly: "The quality of mercy is not strain'd; / It droppeth as the gentle rain from heaven / Upon the place beneath" (IV.i).

Mercy, she argues, becomes the throned monarch better than his crown. Kant himself called the sovereign's right of pardon the most slippery of all his rights (*das schlüpfrigste*, 6:337). The Mercykillers abolish the sovereign's grace and, with it, the power of exception that distinguishes sovereignty from administration. Their justice is law without a sovereign: the machine of Kafka's penal colony, running with no commandant. Section 5.8 follows this thread to Vhailor.

4.7 The Varieties of Negation: Anarchists, Xaositects, Fated, Indeps, Bleakers, Doomguard

Six factions define themselves chiefly against something: against order, meaning, law, affiliation, or persistence.

The Revolutionary League. The Anarchists hold that every faction is corrupt and that truth can be found only after all of them are torn down. Their lineage is the classical anarchist tradition:

- Proudhon's answer to his own question: "Qu'est-ce que la propriété? … c'est le vol" (1840);
- Bakunin's early declaration, "Die Lust der Zerstörung ist auch eine schaffende Lust" (1842): the passion for destruction is also a creative passion;
- Marx's program, in his 1843 letter to Ruge, of a "rücksichtslose Kritik alles Bestehenden," a ruthless criticism of everything that exists.

They are the only faction without a headquarters or civic office: the negative space of the polis. Their dilemma is the one Le Guin explored in *The Dispossessed* (1974), whose anarchist society on Anarres finds that abolishing formal authority breeds informal authority, and that revolution must be permanent or harden. Michels's iron law threatens every organization founded to abolish organizations.

The Nameless One shows the limit of their program. His own self has been torn down at every death, as thoroughly as any Anarchist could wish, and the demolition has yielded no truth, only repetition. What his condition requires is not the destruction of

structure but the assumption of it.

The Xaositects. The Xaositects hold that chaos is the truth of the multiverse and order its illusion; in the game, their members speak in scrambled syntax. Their lineage includes Heraclitus's flux and his fragment declaring that the fairest order is like a heap of sweepings poured out at random (B124), Tristan Tzara's insistence that "Dada ne signifie rien" (1918), and the parodic theology of the *Principia Discordia* (1965). They live in the Hive, Sigil's slum, where Heraclitus's heap of refuse is the landscape. The Nameless One's life is chaos of the most intimate kind, a heap of fragments scattered at random across millennia. His quest is the search for the order the Xaositects deny.

The Fated. The Fated hold that the multiverse belongs to those who take it. Their lineage is Thrasymachus's definition of justice as the advantage of the stronger (*Republic* I, 338c), Callicles's natural law that the better should have more than the worse (*Gorgias* 483a–484c), and Stirner's egoism. That the Fated keep the Hall of Records and collect Sigil's taxes is the setting's most exact joke. Charles Tilly argued that war-making and state-making resemble organized crime: the state is the protection racket that succeeded (Tilly 1985). The Fated are Tilly's thesis made into a faction.

The Nameless One is the greatest taker in the multiverse. He takes deaths.

The Free League. The Indeps hold that no one may dictate another's belief and that one should belong to no faction. Their lineage is Mill's defense of liberty of thought (1859), Berlin's negative liberty, and the Pyrrhonian suspension of judgment (*epochē*; Sextus Empiricus, *Outlines* I.8–10). A faction of the unaffiliated inherits the structure of Russell's paradox (1901): the class of those who belong to no class. The Nameless One, affiliated with nothing and no one, is the most independent man in Sigil and the most dependent. Others hold his past, and others finance his continued existence.

The Bleak Cabal. The Bleakers hold that the multiverse has no meaning; whatever meaning exists must be found within, and many who confront its absence go mad. They run the Gatehouse, Sigil's asylum, and in the setting they care for the mad and the destitute. Their lineage is Schopenhauer's pessimism and Camus's absurd. Their ethic, though, is closer to two figures who drew compassion out of meaninglessness:

- Schopenhauer grounded morality in compassion (*Mitleid*), the direct sharing in another's suffering that pierces the illusion of separate selves (*Über die Grundlage der Moral*, 1840).
- Camus's Dr. Rieux, in *The Plague* (1947), fights the epidemic without hope of cosmic vindication, out of simple decency.

Foucault's history of the asylum (1961) casts the confinement of the mad as a technology of exclusion, and the Bleakers' Gatehouse is not innocent of that history. Still, of all the factions, the Bleakers come nearest to the ethic the game's ending enacts: right action without metaphysical guarantee.

The Doomguard. The Doomguard hold that entropy is the multiverse's fundamental law and should be served. Their lineage is thermodynamic and metaphysical:

- Clausius's second law: "Die Entropie der Welt strebt einem Maximum zu" (1865), the entropy of the world tends toward a maximum;
- Freud's death drive;
- Philipp Mainländer's *Philosophie der Erlösung* (1876), which held that the universe is the decomposition of a God who willed his own non-being: "Gott ist gestorben und sein Tod war das Leben der Welt." God has died, and his death was the life of the world.

The Doomguard illuminate the Nameless One from an unexpected direction. Erwin Schrödinger argued in *What Is Life?* (1944) that living organisms keep their improbable order by drawing what he called negative entropy from their surroundings, exporting disorder as the price of their own organization. The Nameless One raises this thermodynamic principle of life to a metaphysical scandal. He maintains himself by exporting death; his immortality is a local reversal of entropy paid for by more death elsewhere. He inverts Mainländer's formula, in which one death becomes the life of a world: in him, many deaths become the life of one.

4.8 The Empty Throne: The Lady of Pain

Above the factions stands the Lady of Pain. She never speaks. Her face is serene, framed by a halo of blades. Her shadow flays those who offend her. She exiles transgressors into the Mazes, pocket labyrinths from which few escape. She bars the Powers from Sigil and punishes worship directed at herself. She destroyed Aoskar when his cult grew strong in her city.

Schmitt: the decision without theology. Carl Schmitt defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception: "Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet" (1922). The Lady's power is pure decision. She intervenes without announcement, explanation, or appeal, and her interventions suspend the city's ordinary life. Schmitt also held that the significant concepts of modern state theory are secularized theological concepts, and that the sovereign exception is the legal analogue of the miracle.

The Lady refuses exactly this theologizing. She forbids worship, destroys a god who grew too powerful in her domain, and allows no one, herself included, to become the city's object of belief. Hers is sovereignty without political theology, or rather with a negative one: the sovereign as guardian of the city's godlessness.

Lefort: the guarded void. Lefort's account of democracy clarifies what she guards (Lefort 1986). In a democracy, the place of power is empty. No person or group can occupy it as its own or claim to embody society's unity, and power is exercised only provisionally by those who contend for it. The Lady occupies the throne in a way that keeps it empty. She never legislates, claims, or speaks, and she prevents the place of the sacred from being filled. The factions contend around a void they cannot occupy.

The setting's later canon made this logic explicit. In TSR's *Faction War* (1998), the factions' struggle for the city ends with the Lady removing them from its governance. She preserves the emptiness at the center by abolishing the parties that sought to fill it. The paradox is exact: a despot guarantees the democracy of doctrines. So Hobbes's sovereign guarantees the peace in which opinions may differ, and so Spinoza's state is justified by the freedom it protects.

Kafka: the unapproachable law. Kafka supplies the Lady's phenomenology. "Vor dem Gesetz steht ein Türhüter" (1915): before the Law stands a doorkeeper, and the man from the country waits all his life before a door that, he learns as he dies, was meant only for him. Sigil is a city of doors, each opening only to its own key. Its sovereign is a law that cannot be approached, and its Mazes are Kafka's labyrinths made literal. In Kafka's "An Imperial Message" (1919), the dying emperor's message never arrives. The Lady sends no messages at all.

Benjamin: two kinds of violence. Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) offers a final, more speculative frame. It distinguishes mythic violence, which founds and preserves law and is bloody, from divine violence, which destroys law and kills without shedding blood ("auf unblutige Weise letal"). The Lady's two instruments map suggestively onto this distinction:

- The flaying shadow is mythic violence, the bloody enforcement of her order.
- The Maze is a bloodless removal that annihilates without a verdict.

Whether the Lady founds law or suspends it, the city beneath her lives in the space her violence keeps open.

For the Nameless One, her sovereignty sets up a final comparison. She is a sovereign who refuses to become a god; he is a man whose alienated mortality has come to believe itself one. The sovereignty the game respects keeps the place of transcendence

empty. The self it condemns has filled that place with its own death.

Conclusion to Chapter IV: Reductio per Exemplum

The factions of Sigil form a complete disputation among the philosophical schools of the multiverse, and the game, like Llull's sages, declines to announce a verdict. The player may join several factions and may leave the game's question unanswered by all of them. But the absence of a verdict is not the absence of an argument. The protagonist carries the argument.

Each faction's doctrine is carried in the Nameless One to the point of refutation:

- He has died more often than any Dustman, and the True Death would settle nothing.
- He has lived more lives than any Godsman, and has not ascended.
- He has experienced more than any Sensate, and remembers almost nothing.
- He has found the greatest loophole the Guvners could dream of, and someone else pays for it.
- He acts without thought like a Cipher, and his unthinking acts have piled up debts.
- He is imagined by others more thoroughly than any Signer imagines the world.
- He has taken more than any of the Fated.
- He has been torn down more thoroughly than the Anarchists could wish.
- He has exported more death than any Doomguard has served.

Every school finds in him its perfect case and its counterexample.

What survives the *reductio* is a practice, not a doctrine, and here the game's final word, spoken by its structure, rejoins Lessing's parable. The true ring cannot be identified by inspection; it is proven by what its bearer does. The nature of a man, the game implies, is not changed by joining a school. It is changed by what he does with the debts that every school, in its own vocabulary, has taught him to recognize. The companions who travel with him are the concrete bearers of those debts, and the argument now turns to them.

CHAPTER



V

PERSONAE

The Companions as the Nameless One's Court

5.1 The Companion as Conceptual Persona

In most role-playing games, companions serve functional ends: they add complementary combat abilities, provide commentary, and offer romances. *Torment* keeps these functions but subordinates them to another. Each companion is what Deleuze and Guattari called a *conceptual persona*: a figure through whom a philosophy thinks, as Socrates is for Plato or Zarathustra for Nietzsche. Such a figure is not the author's mouthpiece but the living operator of a concept (Deleuze and Guattari 1991, ch. 3).

The companions also occupy two structural positions this dissertation has already defined:

- **Holders of the past.** They are agents of allomnesia (Chapter II). Several were bound, taught, or wounded by his former selves, and they carry memories of him that he lacks.
- **Potential victims.** They are the named, visible counterparts of the anonymous shadows (Chapter VI). In the Fortress of Regrets they may fall, and it is by reclaiming his mortality that the protagonist may restore them.

The companions are thus the Nameless One's court: witnesses to his past, jurors of his present, and the first beneficiaries of his final act.

The sections that follow read each companion as the embodiment of an answer to Ravel's question, and as a mirror of one aspect of the protagonist's condition. Bakhtin's principle of polyphony governs the reading. No companion is merely a symbol; each keeps the independence of a voice the protagonist cannot absorb.

5.2 Morte: Loyalty, the Lie, and the Consolation of the Joke

The talking skull. Morte is a floating skull taken from the Pillar of Skulls, whose occupants are the heads of those whose words led others to ruin (Chapter III, §3.2). His name is the Italian word for death. He jokes constantly, lies habitually, knows more of the protagonist's past than he admits, and fights partly with a "Litany of Curses," insults the game treats as weapons that goad enemies.

Morte is first of all a *memento mori* that talks, and his literary ancestor is Yorick as much as Virgil. Hamlet, holding the jester's skull in the graveyard, remembers "a fellow of infinite jest, of most excellent fancy" (V.i), and the meditation on mortality the

skull prompts takes place over its silence. *Torment* gives the skull back its voice, and the jest resumes.

The Dance of Death tradition, from the medieval *danse macabre* to Holbein's woodcuts (1538), had long made the skeleton a comic figure, laughing at the living it leads away. Bakhtin read such figures as carnival: the grotesque body's laughter against death and hierarchy (Bakhtin 1965). Bergson defined the comic as "du mécanique plaqué sur du vivant," the mechanical encrusted on the living (*Le Rire*, 1900). A skull with a personality is the purest case of that definition in inverted form: the living encrusted on the mechanical remains of a head.

The joke as consolation and as resistance. Chapter II suggested that Morte plays the part of resistance in the protagonist's working-through, joking where he should disclose. Freud's late essay on humor explains why the joke is also a gift. Humor, Freud argued, is the superego's consolation of the frightened ego, as if it said: "Sieh' her, das ist nun die Welt, die so gefährlich aussieht. Ein Kinderspiel, gerade gut, einen Scherz darüber zu machen!" (1927). Look, this is the world that seems so dangerous: a child's game, good for nothing but a joke. Morte's jokes shrink the multiverse to a size a man with no memory can bear. They defend against the truth, and they are also a mercy that makes approaching it possible.

The liar who keeps faith. Morte's lies raise the oldest questions in the ethics of speech:

- Augustine defined the lie as saying what one believes false with the intention to deceive, and held every lie to be a sin (*De mendacio*, 395).
- Kant held the lie to be an offense against humanity itself (Chapter III).
- Plato allowed the rulers of the Kallipolis a "noble lie" (*gennaion pseudos*, *Republic* III, 414b–c) for the city's good.
- Sissela Bok (1978) reopened the question of benevolent deception.
- Harry Frankfurt distinguished the liar, who tracks the truth in order to conceal it, from the bullshitter, who does not care about it, and judged the bullshitter the greater enemy of truth (Frankfurt 1986).

Morte is a liar in Frankfurt's sense, not a bullshitter. His lies are purposeful and often protective, and they presuppose close knowledge of what they conceal. The resolution of his character lies elsewhere than in his speech. His words deceive; his conduct is faithful. He stays.

Josiah Royce defined loyalty as "the willing and practical and thoroughgoing devotion of a person to a cause," and made "loyalty to loyalty" the principle of ethics (*The Philosophy of Loyalty*, 1908). Morte's loyalty to the protagonist is Roycean in exactly this sense: practical, thoroughgoing, and independent of whether his speech is true. A creature damned for words that led others to ruin redeems himself not by speaking truly but by acting faithfully.

The answer Morte embodies to Ravel's question is fidelity. What can change the nature of a liar is not a change in his words but constancy in his deeds.

5.3 Dak'kon: Knowing, Faith, and the Unbroken Circle

The oath and the scripture. Dak'kon is a githzerai warrior-mage. He carries the Unbroken Circle of Zerthimon, his people's scripture, and a *karach* blade whose form, as Chapter III showed, depends on the discipline of his mind. He is bound to the protagonist by an oath that holds until the protagonist's death, and the oath was a trap. An earlier incarnation, generally identified as the Practical, found him near death in Limbo, coveted his *karach* blade, and rescued him knowing that githzerai custom would make him swear to serve his rescuer until the rescuer died. The incarnation knew he could not die; Dak'kon did not. The oath was therefore perpetual servitude, engineered by one party and concealed from the other. He is also a man in crisis. His faith in the Circle was shaken by a catastrophe for which he holds himself responsible: as a leader whose word the people of Shra'kt'lor relied on to hold their city together, he came to doubt Zerthimon's teaching, the doubt spread, and the city fell.

The Unbroken Circle tells of the gith's liberation from the illithids, the mind flayers who fed on their minds, and of the schism that followed: Zerthimon's followers became the githzerai, Gith's the githyanki. It is a scripture of emancipation. Its lesson, as Dak'kon teaches it, is that freedom from external masters is incomplete without mastery of oneself.

The pattern has two philosophical echoes:

- **Hegelian.** In the dialectic of master and slave, the slave's road to freedom runs through discipline and formative labor, not merely the overthrow of the master.
- **Kantian.** Enlightenment is humanity's exit from a self-incurred immaturity, "der Ausgang des Menschen aus seiner selbstverschuldeten Unmündigkeit" (1784).

Zerthimon's Circle teaches that after liberation, the illithids' chains are replaced by the subtler chains of an undisciplined mind.

Two kinds of knowing. The Circle's central concept is *knowing*. Dak'kon's crisis is the separation of two things the githzerai discipline is supposed to unite: he can recite the Circle, but he no longer *knows* it.

- Gilbert Ryle's distinction between knowing-that and knowing-how (1949), and Michael Polanyi's thesis that we know more than we can tell (1966), describe the split. Dak'kon keeps the propositional content of his faith and has lost the tacit, practical certainty that shapes the blade and holds the walls.
- John Henry Newman drew the same line in religious terms as notional versus real assent (*Grammar of Assent*, 1870).
- Kierkegaard drew it more radically, setting truth as subjectivity, the passionate appropriation of what one believes, against the "objective" possession of doctrine (*Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, 1846).
- Wittgenstein's late notes on certainty suggest why the crisis cannot be settled by argument. At the foundation of well-grounded belief lies belief that is not itself grounded, and the difficulty is to acknowledge that groundlessness without collapse (*On Certainty*, 1969).

The student who teaches his teacher. Dak'kon and the Nameless One are exact inverses:

- The protagonist has know-how without memory: a body acting with a competence whose origins he cannot recall.
- Dak'kon has memory without know-how: a scripture he can recite and can no longer live.

The game makes their relationship one of mutual repair. The protagonist studies the Circle under Dak'kon, and in coming to know it he becomes able to question and help his teacher: a man with no past helping a man who cannot inhabit his.

Their friendship stages the reunion of the two halves of knowledge. It also gives a precise sense to Dak'kon's implicit answer to Ravel's question: what can change the nature of a man is knowing, in the githzerai sense, belief made into practice by discipline.

The oath's memory. The oath is itself a small treatise on the ethics of promising:

- Nietzsche's promising animal requires memory (Chapter II).
- Hume argued that the obligation of promises is an artificial convention, not a natural bond (*Treatise* III.ii.5).

- Arendt made the promise, together with forgiveness, one of the two faculties by which human beings master the unpredictability of action, creating islands of reliability in an ocean of uncertainty (Arendt 1958).

Dak'kon's oath strains all three accounts. It was made to a person who no longer exists in any psychological sense, and it is remembered only by the one who made it. Its continued force rests on the promiser's fidelity to a body rather than a person: Dak'kon keeps a promise the promisee has forgotten receiving. The promise was also obtained by deceit: Dak'kon made it in ignorance of the one fact that made it endless, a fact the incarnation that received it knew. Whether he should be released from it is, in miniature, the question whether the Nameless One's debts bind him. The two questions receive a common answer at the end.

5.4 Annah-of-the-Shadows: Hybridity, Stigma, and Mortal Eros

The mixed body. Annah is a tiefling, a human being with fiendish ancestry visible in her body, most obviously in her tail. She is a thief of the Hive and the ward of Pharod, chief of the corpse-collectors. She is fierce, guarded, and drawn to the protagonist despite herself.

Her body raises the question of heredity: does fiendish blood determine a nature? In a setting where alignment is written into the cosmos, the tiefling is a living objection to the premise that origin is destiny. Erving Goffman's analysis of stigma (1963), the "spoiled identity" of those whose visible traits discredit them in others' eyes, describes her social position in Sigil precisely. Donna Haraway's cyborg (1985), the figure who rejects the myth of original purity and lives on the boundary between categories without apology, describes the stance she takes toward it. She does not seek to be purified of her ancestry. She demands to be recognized in it.

Annah and the Nameless One are both bodies marked by origins they did not choose. She bears the fiendish blood of an unknown ancestor; he bears the scars and tattoos of predecessors he cannot remember. Both are thrown, in Heidegger's sense, into bodies that carry a history. Both are raised or kept by damned men: Pharod, her guardian, knows himself bound for the Lower Planes and has arranged his life around escaping that judgment, a small-scale double of the protagonist's first incarnation. Their attraction is the recognition of one marked body by another.

Eros and mortality. The deeper stake of Annah's love concerns the relation between eros and death. In the *Symposium*, Diotima teaches Socrates that love is desire for the good to be one's own forever (206a). Mortal nature seeks, as far as it can, to be

immortal, and it can do so only through generation, always leaving something new behind in place of the old (207d, my translation). Eros is the mortal's form of immortality. Love reaches toward permanence through children, works, and teachings precisely because the lover will die.

The Nameless One is immortal in the wrong way, and his deathlessness disables the function Diotima gave eros. He has no need to leave anything behind, and his lovers, Deionarra first among them, have been consumed by his persistence. Annah's love can be a mortal's love only if he becomes mortal. The romance therefore has a structural stake in the ending. Reclaiming his mortality is, among other things, the condition under which he could love as Diotima's lovers love, knowing there is an end.

Annah's implicit answer to Ravel's question is love. The game's structure qualifies it: love can change the nature of a man only if he is capable of dying.

5.5 Fall-from-Grace: Virtue Against Nature

The chaste succubus. Fall-from-Grace is a succubus, a fiend whose nature in the setting's taxonomy is seduction, and she is chaste. She keeps the Brothel for Slating Intellectual Lusts, where the currency of desire is conversation, and she is a Sensate who seeks experience without consuming it. She is serene, perceptive, and the most morally lucid of the companions.

The stone that learned to rise. Aristotle argued that the moral virtues arise in us "neither by nature nor contrary to nature" (ὅτ' ἄρα φύσει ὅτε παρὰ φύσιν, *Nicomachean Ethics* II.1, 1103a24). We are fitted by nature to receive them and perfected by habit. His illustration is a stone, which by nature moves downward and cannot be trained to move upward, not even if one throws it up ten thousand times (1103a20–23). Nature sets the limits of habit.

Fall-from-Grace is Aristotle's stone trained to rise. She has habituated herself, against her nature, into a disposition her nature forbids. The game presents this not as the erasure of her nature but as a discipline sustained against its pull. She is a direct counterexample to the Aristotelian limit, and a living test of the existentialist claim that existence precedes essence (Sartre 1946). She is not what her kind is, because she has chosen otherwise.

Kant's account of moral conversion in *Religion within the Bounds of Mere Reason* (1793) fits her better than Sartre's. The change of heart, Kant argues, is a "Revolution in der Gesinnung," a revolution in disposition accomplished at once in the intelligible order.

In the sensible world it must be realized as gradual reform, a lifelong struggle against the propensity to evil. Grace embodies both moments: her choice is the revolution, and her daily chastity is the reform.

The name as theological irony. The debate between Augustine and Pelagius turned on whether virtue can be achieved by the will alone or only by grace, the unmerited gift of God. Augustine's prayer, "da quod iubes et iube quod vis" (give what you command, and command what you will; *Confessions* X.29.40), scandalized Pelagius precisely because it made virtue depend on a gift. Fall-from-Grace is a Pelagian heroine named for the Augustinian gift. She has fallen *from* grace into a virtue achieved without it. Her existence asks the Augustinian tradition whether a demon who chooses the good by effort alone is less good, or more, than a saint who receives it.

Her brothel belongs to the same argument. Augustine named curiosity the "lust of the eyes" (*concupiscentia oculorum*, *Confessions* X.35.54) and counted it among the temptations. Grace makes the lust of the mind the substance of her house. It is a Symposium in the literal sense: desire sublimated, in Freud's sense, into conversation, with eros climbing Diotima's ladder from bodies to souls to ideas.

Her implicit answer to Ravel's question is choice sustained by discipline: the will that refuses its nature every day.

5.6 Ignus: The Apprentice of Fire

The apprentice. Ignus is a mage whom an earlier incarnation took on as a boy and trained to master fire by inflicting suffering on him, on the principle that suffering is necessary for learning. As a grown man Ignus tried to burn down the Hive, Sigil's crowded slum. The Hive's mages, working together, stopped him in a way that would have incinerated anyone else; he survived it as a living conduit to the Elemental Plane of Fire. He burns perpetually and is never consumed. The protagonist first finds him hanging in the air of the Smoldering Corpse Bar, burning, and may free him. He is hungry, resentful, and dangerous, and the game allows his resentment to be turned against the protagonist at the end.

Fire's complexes. Gaston Bachelard's *Psychoanalysis of Fire* (1938) identified the complexes that fire organizes in the imagination:

- The *Prometheus complex*: the will to know as much as our fathers and more than our teachers, the child's desire to steal the forbidden flame.

- The *Empedocles complex*: the desire to be consumed in fire, where love and death join, named for the philosopher who by legend leapt into Etna (Diogenes Laertius VIII.69).

Ignus is both at once: the student who stole his master's fire and the man consumed by it, a Prometheus who has become his own pyre.

Heraclitus supplies the metaphysics of his condition. The cosmos is "an ever-living fire, kindled in measures and extinguished in measures" (B30). All things are exchanged for fire and fire for all things, "as goods for gold and gold for goods" (*πυρός τε ἀνταμοιβὴ τὰ πάντα καὶ πῦρ ἁπάντων ὅκωσπερ χρυσοῦ χρήματα καὶ χρημάτων χρυσός*, B90). Heraclitus's fire is an economy of exchange, and Ignus embodies it in a single body: a man through whom a plane's substance passes endlessly, consuming and never consumed.

That economy illuminates the protagonist's own. His persistence is also an exchange: one life sustained by deaths elsewhere, as fire is sustained by the fuel it burns. Ignus is the Nameless One's condition in elemental form, endless dying without end, and his hunger is the visible face of an appetite the protagonist's immortality hides.

The sorcerer's apprentice. The teaching relationship that made Ignus is itself a target of the game's critique. Goethe's sorcerer's apprentice, who unleashes forces he cannot control, cries in despair: "Die ich rief, die Geister, / Werd' ich nun nicht los" (1797), the spirits I summoned I now cannot get rid of. Ignus is an apprentice whose master's lessons left him burning. The master returns as a successor who does not remember him, restoring the scene of instruction without its author.

Nietzsche's Zarathustra warns his disciples: "Man vergilt einem Lehrer schlecht, wenn man immer nur der Schüler bleibt" (I, "Von der schenkenden Tugend," 1883), one repays a teacher badly if one always remains only a pupil. Ignus repays his teacher by wanting to burn him. He also keeps his teacher's method: he will teach the Nameless One fire magic only by burning part of the Nameless One's body. His resentment is the *ressentiment* of a disciple who can neither surpass nor forgive the master who formed him.

His implicit answer to Ravel's question is passion, and the game shows its double edge. Fire changes the nature of whatever it touches, but it changes by consuming. Passion can transform a man; it can also turn him into fuel.

5.7 Nordom: The Broken Cog

The rogue modron. Nordom is a modron, one of the geometric beings of Mechanus, the plane of perfect order, where modrons serve in a strict hierarchy of rank under their supreme ruler, Primus. Nordom has been cut off from that hierarchy, and the protagonist finds him in Rubikon, the modron maze. Disconnected from the collective, he has become something no modron is meant to be, an individual, and he regards his own individuality with confusion, curiosity, and delight. His name, as noted earlier, is an anagram of his kind's: an individual made by rearranging his species' letters.

Consciousness as malfunction. The most illuminating frame for Nordom is Heidegger's. In *Being and Time* (§16), equipment that works smoothly withdraws from attention; we do not notice the hammer while hammering. Only when a tool breaks, goes missing, or gets in the way does it become conspicuous, obtrusive, or obstinate, and so present to us as a thing. Nordom is a cog of Mechanus that has broken, and in breaking has become present to itself. His self-consciousness is a malfunction, and the game treats the malfunction as a birth.

The wider tradition supplies further frames:

- **Descartes.** The cogito emerges from radical doubt, the suspension of every inherited certainty. Nordom's severance from Primus is the loss of the certainty that had done his thinking for him, and his first discovery is that he is thinking.
- **Leibniz.** The monad is a simple substance that mirrors the whole universe from its own point of view (*Monadology*, 1714). Nordom becomes a monad by subtraction: a unique perspective produced by disconnection from a collective that had none.
- **Durkheim.** Anomie (1897), the condition of individuals detached from collective norms, is ordinarily pathological. In Nordom it is generative.

Philosophical science fiction had explored the same figure. *Star Trek: The Next Generation*'s "I, Borg" (1992) presents a drone separated from a hive-mind who discovers individuality and a first-person pronoun. Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920) had already imagined manufactured beings acquiring capacities their makers denied them.

Nordom and the Nameless One share a condition. Both have been cut off from their origin, Primus in one case and the first incarnation in the other, and both have become individuals through that severance. They differ in how they experience it. For Nordom, individuality is a gift received with wonder; for the Nameless One, it is a debt received with guilt.

Nordom's implicit answer to Ravel's question is separation: what can change the nature of a being is its disconnection from what had defined it. The protagonist's story asks what the separated self owes to what it left behind.

5.8 Vhailor: Justice Without a Subject

Chapter III read Vhailor as conviction without a believer. Here the same figure is read as a theory of justice.

The officer who became the apparatus. Vhailor is a Mercykiller whose devotion to justice has outlived his body: an empty suit of armor animated by the demand that judgment be done. His literary ancestor is the officer in Kafka's "In the Penal Colony." When the colony's new commandant signals the end of the execution apparatus, the officer sets it to inscribe on his own body the sentence "Sei gerecht!" (Be just!) and lies down under the harrow. The machine malfunctions: it does not write but stabs, and the officer dies without the enlightenment the apparatus was supposed to bring. Vhailor is that officer after he has become the apparatus, justice's servant absorbed into justice's machinery, still demanding the sentence after the man who served it is gone.

Law and justice. Derrida's "Force of Law" (1990) distinguishes law (*droit*), which is calculable, codified, and deconstructible, from justice, which is incalculable, undeconstructible, and experienced as an aporia. Justice demands a decision that no rule can guarantee, addressed to a singular case no law anticipates. Vhailor mistakes law's calculation for justice's demand. His justice is mechanical in exactly the sense Derrida denies to justice: it applies; it does not judge. Benjamin's distinction between mythic and divine violence (§4.8) places him firmly on the mythic side: law-preserving violence that preserves nothing but itself.

Punishment as the criminal's right. Vhailor's presence at the protagonist's side raises the question the ending must answer: should the Nameless One be judged? The game lets the protagonist argue with Vhailor, and the Transcendent One may try to turn Vhailor's justice against him. Throughout, the invariant holds: judgment is due.

The resolution the game offers is not Vhailor's. It draws on two philosophical claims:

- **Hegel.** In the *Philosophy of Right*, punishment honors the criminal as a rational being, because it is his own right, the law he implicitly laid down in his deed, turned back on him: "Daß die Strafe darin als sein eigenes Recht enthaltend angesehen wird, darin wird der Verbrecher als Vernünftiges geehrt" (1820, §100).

- **Kant.** Answering Beccaria's objection that no one could consent to his own execution, Kant distinguished the criminal as co-legislator, who wills the penal law, from the criminal as subject, who suffers it (*Metaphysics of Morals*, 6:335).

The Nameless One's acceptance of his sentence dissolves Kant's distinction and fulfills Hegel's claim. He wills his own punishment not as a co-legislator willing a law in the abstract, but as the subject who claims the sentence as his own. Justice is accomplished without an executioner. Vhailor's apparatus is made unnecessary, not refuted, by a criminal who sentences himself.

Vhailor's implicit answer to Ravel's question is *nothing*: justice is changeless, and a man's nature is what his deeds have made it. The ending grants the premise and draws a different conclusion. The deeds cannot be changed; one's relation to them can.

5.9 The Wider Court: Deionarra, Ravel, Trias, Pharod

Four figures outside the party complete the court.

Deionarra is the ghost of a woman who loved the Practical Incarnation. He calculated that her love would keep her spirit from passing on to the Outer Planes when she died, and he brought her to the Fortress of Regrets intending that she die there, so that her ghost could scout for him in a place where nothing living survives for long. She died there, and so did he. She now haunts the Mortuary's memorial hall, gifted with foresight and still devoted. Plato describes souls weighed down by attachment to the body that wander around tombs and monuments, where they are seen as shadowy phantoms (*Phaedo* 81c–d). Deionarra is such a soul, held not by her body but by love.

Her story inverts the Orphic myth. In Orpheus's story, the living lover descends to recover the dead and loses her by looking back. In hers, the dead lover waits for the living one, who cannot remember her. She is the game's clearest case of a person treated merely as a means, the violation Kant's Formula of Humanity forbids (*Groundwork*, 4:429). Her fidelity to the man who used her is the purest instance of allomnesia: she remembers the love he has forgotten.

Ravel Puzzlewell, the night hag who made the protagonist deathless, is the Sphinx of this dissertation's reading (Chapter II, §2.2). She also embodies what Erich Neumann, systematizing Jungian theory, called the Terrible Mother, the maternal power that both generates and devours (Neumann 1955). She created the protagonist's condition and poses his question, and her name, a contronym, holds both the knot and its undoing.

Trias, the fallen deva imprisoned in Curst, is a celestial whose treachery is committed, on his own account, in the service of a higher good. He embodies the corruption of the good by instrumental reason: the rationalization by which ends are taken to sanctify means. He is the betrayer at the center of the Curst episode, whose collective treachery slides a town into Carceri, and so he is the individual face of the structural wrong analyzed in Chapter III.

Pharod, chief of the Collectors, knows himself destined for the Lower Planes and has arranged his life around escaping that judgment. He is the protagonist's first incarnation in miniature, a small man's version of the great man's bargain. His fate previews the logic the game applies to both: the judgment one tries to evade is not abolished by evading it.

Conclusion to Chapter V: A Symposium on Ravel's Question

Read together, the companions form a symposium in the Platonic sense: a gathering at which each participant in turn gives an account of the question at issue. In Plato's dialogue the question is the nature of love; in *Torment* it is Ravel's. Each companion embodies an answer, not in a speech but in a life:

- **Morte:** fidelity, the constancy of deeds that redeems the inconstancy of words.
- **Dak'kon:** knowing, belief made into practice by discipline.
- **Annah:** love, which can change a man only if he is capable of dying.
- **Fall-from-Grace:** choice, sustained by the daily refusal of one's nature.
- **Ignus:** passion, which changes by consuming.
- **Nordom:** separation, the individuation of the severed.
- **Vhailor:** nothing, since deeds cannot be undone and justice does not change.

As in the *Symposium*, where Socrates's speech gathers and transcends the others, the answer the game finally gives matches no single companion's, but it needs all of them. It takes:

- from Vhailor, the premise that deeds cannot be undone;
- from Dak'kon, the recognition that belief must become practice;
- from Fall-from-Grace, the demonstration that a nature can be refused;
- from Morte, the priority of fidelity over speech;
- from Annah, the insight that love requires mortality;
- from Nordom, the question of what the separated self owes its origin;

- from Ignus, the warning that passion left to itself only consumes.

The companions are also the concrete, named counterparts of the multitudes who died for the protagonist without names. In most role-playing games, companions die for or beside the hero and are casually restored; the party is a unit of expendable lives. *Torment* makes this convention thematic. In the Fortress of Regrets the companions may fall, and it is the protagonist's reclaimed mortality that lets him restore them. The named dead of the party stand for the unnamed dead of the multiverse, and the hero's willingness to die is what brings them back.

The next part of this dissertation turns from the court to the crime: to the economy of borrowed death that the shadows embody, and to the medium in which every player who has ever reloaded a save re-enacts that economy.

CHAPTER



VI

ALLOTHANASIA

The Economy of Borrowed Death

6.1 The Diagnosis Stated

The fiction of *Planescape: Torment* rests on a mechanism that the game reveals slowly and that this dissertation places at its center.

A man committed a crime grave enough to damn him, so grave that no good he could do with the rest of his life would undo the sentence. Fearing an eternity in the Blood War, and hoping to buy the time that atonement seemed to need, he went to the night hag Ravel Puzzlewell, whose ritual separated his mortality from him. After that, his body could not stay dead. The ritual did not abolish death, however; it displaced it. Each time the Nameless One dies and rises, someone elsewhere in the multiverse dies in his place. The shades of these substitutes are drawn to him. They become the shadows that hunt him and crowd the Fortress of Regrets, where his separated mortality, the Transcendent One, keeps court. The motive matters for everything that follows. The bargain was a wager on atonement, and allothanasia is what the wager cost: each return it bought was paid for with a stranger's life, so the attempt to settle one debt kept opening others.

Allothanasia names this condition: a being whose death is suffered by another. The structure has four features:

- **Displacement.** Death is not cancelled but relocated. Each gain in one life is a loss in another.
- **Anonymity.** The substitutes are unchosen, unnamed, and unseen by the one they replace.
- **Non-consent.** None of them agreed to die for him, and none knew they were doing so.
- **Return.** The displaced dead come back as shadows. What was pushed outward seeks its origin.

These features separate the Nameless One's condition from the two models of deathlessness that dominate the literature before him.

The first is the *Makropulos model*. Čapek's Elina Makropulos has lived three hundred and thirty-seven years and finds that nothing matters any longer (Čapek 1922). Bernard Williams generalized her case into the argument that endless life would drain the categorical desires that give life its point (Williams 1973). This is a problem about the immortal's own good.

The second is the *Struldbrug model*. Swift's immortals of Luggnagg age without dying, and "as soon as they have completed the term of eighty years, they are looked on as dead in law" (*Gulliver's Travels* III.10, 1726). Their heirs inherit and their marriages dissolve. This is a problem about the immortal's legal and social standing.

The Nameless One belongs to neither model. His problem is not his own good or his standing but other people's lives. Allothanasia moves the problem of immortality out of the registers of welfare and status and into the register of justice.

Epicurus inverted. Epicurus consoled mortals with the argument that "death is nothing to us" (ὁ θάνατος οὐθὲν πρὸς ἡμᾶς). While we exist, death is absent, and when death is present, we no longer exist (*Letter to Menoeceus* 124–125). For the Nameless One this consolation is literally true: death is nothing to him, because he returns. Realized as fact, the Epicurean formula shows its monstrous underside. Death is nothing to him only because it is everything to someone else. Where his death is, he is not, and someone else is.

Statistical victims. Thomas Schelling distinguished identified lives, whose loss we see and mourn, from statistical lives, whose loss is real but diffuse and unseen (Schelling 1968). The shadows are statistical lives in the strictest sense. The harm they bear is real, its bearers are unknown, and its invisibility is not an accident of perception but a feature of the mechanism. Allothanasia is a harm that its structure hides from its beneficiary.

6.2 A Genealogy of Borrowed Death

Literature and religion have long imagined one death standing in for another. Three structures can be distinguished, and the Nameless One inverts each.

Substitution by decree, bargain, or rite.

- **Enkidu.** In Tablet VII of the Standard Babylonian *Epic of Gilgamesh*, the gods decide that one of the two companions who killed Humbaba and the Bull of Heaven must die. They choose Enkidu. Gilgamesh's search for immortality begins from the scandal of a death suffered in his place.
- **Admetus and Alcestis.** In Euripides' *Alcestis* (438 BCE), Apollo has won from the Fates a concession: Admetus may escape his appointed death if someone else dies for him. His aged parents refuse, and his wife Alcestis consents. The play's sharpest moment comes in the quarrel between Admetus and his father Pheres, who rejects the claim that parents owe their children their lives: χαίρεις ὁρῶν φῶς· πατέρα δ' ὃ χαίρειν δοκεῖς; "You rejoice to see the light; do you think your father does

not?" (691). Heracles then wrestles Thanatos at the tomb and brings Alcestis back veiled from the dead.

- **The scapegoat.** Leviticus prescribes that the high priest lay the people's sins on a goat, and "the goat shall bear upon him all their iniquities unto a land not inhabited" (16:22, KJV).
- **The pharmakos.** At the Thargelia festival the Athenians each year led out two people, chosen from the city's poorest and most despised, as purifications for the city, and drove them out. In the Ionian poet Hipponax (sixth century BCE) the chosen man is beaten with squills and fig branches; later and often aetiological sources tell of *pharmakoi* stoned, burned, or cast from cliffs. Most modern scholars (Bremmer 1983; Hughes 1991) doubt that classical Athens actually killed them, so this dissertation's use of the term for one who dies in another's place extends the rite rather than reports it. Derrida showed that the word, absent from Plato's text, haunts its logic of the *pharmakon* (§0.3).

Substitution as grace.

- **The Suffering Servant.** The fourth Servant Song gives the classic formula of vicarious suffering: "But he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed" (Isaiah 53:5, KJV).
- **Anselm.** In *Cur Deus Homo* (1098), Anselm gave the formula its juridical logic. The debt of sin is one that "facere non potest nisi deus, et facere non debet nisi homo": only God *can* pay it, and only a human being *ought* to. Hence it must be paid by the God-man (II.6).

Substitution as structural injustice.

- **William James.** In "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891), James imagines a world in which millions are "kept permanently happy on the one simple condition that a certain lost soul on the far-off edge of things should lead a life of lonely torture." He asks what, except a specific moral emotion, makes us feel "how hideous a thing would be its enjoyment when deliberately accepted as the fruit of such a bargain."
- **Ivan Karamazov.** Dostoevsky's Ivan refuses any cosmic harmony built on the tears of a single tortured child: "It's not God that I don't accept, Alyosha, only I most respectfully return Him the ticket" (*The Brothers Karamazov*, V.4, 1880; Garnett's translation).

- **Omelas.** Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), subtitled as variations on a theme by William James, makes the bargain a city. Omelas's joy depends on a child kept in misery in a basement. Most citizens accept the arrangement; a few walk away.
- **Jory.** Dick's *Ubik* (1969) supplies the predatory version. In the moratorium, the half-lifer Jory sustains his own dimming consciousness by consuming the residual life of the half-lifers around him (Chapter III).

The Nameless One's triple inversion. Against each structure, the Nameless One occupies the reversed position.

- **Against Admetus.** Admetus had Alcestis's consent, and her death is honored as sacrifice. The Nameless One's substitutes consented to nothing. Consent marks the difference between sacrifice and expropriation.
- **Against the Servant.** In the Servant Song and in Anselm, an innocent dies freely for the guilty. In the Nameless One's case, innocents die unknowingly for the guilty. The Servant's formula is reversed: *they* were wounded for *his* transgressions.
- **Against Omelas.** James's and Le Guin's bargains trade the suffering of one for the happiness of many. The Nameless One's bargain trades the deaths of many for the persistence of one. It is Omelas turned inside out and made worse. What the deaths purchase, moreover, is not pleasure but a penitent's time to atone. Omelas buys happiness with a hidden victim; the Nameless One's bargain buys the chance to be good that way. It is a moral Omelas.

The comparison with Jory marks a last distinction. Jory is a predator: he consumes others knowingly, by an act of will. The Nameless One, at the start of each life, is a beneficiary. His consumption runs through a mechanism he did not build and cannot see. The distance between predator and beneficiary is the space the game opens for moral action. A predator can only be stopped. A beneficiary can learn what his benefit costs and decide what to do about it.

6.3 Heidegger's Counterfactual

The most rigorous philosophical claim that *Torment* tests is Heidegger's. In §47 of *Sein und Zeit* (1927), Heidegger considers whether one might grasp death through the deaths of others, and concludes that one cannot, because dying cannot be delegated: "Keiner kann dem Anderen sein Sterben abnehmen." No one can take the other's dying away from him.

One may, Heidegger allows, go to one's death for another, sacrificing oneself "in some definite matter." But such a sacrifice never relieves the other of his own death in the slightest. Hence: "Das Sterben muß jedes Dasein jeweilig selbst auf sich nehmen. Der Tod ist, sofern er 'ist', wesensmäßig je der meine." Dying is something every Dasein must in each case take upon itself. Death, insofar as it "is," is essentially in each case mine.

In §50 Heidegger defines death as Dasein's "eigenste, unbezügliche, unüberholbare Möglichkeit": its ownmost, non-relational possibility, which cannot be outstripped.

The Nameless One is the counterfactual Heidegger declared impossible: a being whose dying has been taken from him by others. The game is not a refutation of Heidegger. It is a reductio of the counterfactual, and its conclusion vindicates him. A being whose death is borne by others does not gain a freer or richer existence. He loses exactly what Heidegger said death makes possible:

- **Wholeness.** Heidegger holds that Dasein can be a whole (*Ganzsein*) only as being-toward-death, in the anticipation (*Vorlaufen*) of its end. The Nameless One is the least whole being imaginable: a succession of fragments, each forgetting the last.
- **Mineness.** Having no death that is his, he has no life that is his in the full sense. His past is held by others (Chapter II) and his future is financed by them.
- **Authenticity.** For Heidegger, authentic existence is "freedom toward death" (*Freiheit zum Tode*, §53). It is the resolute self-understanding of a being that knows it is finite and takes over its own possibilities in that light. The Nameless One can do nothing resolutely, because he has nothing to lose.

The Fortress of Regrets stages Heidegger's thesis as action. It is the place where the protagonist can take the fragments of his former selves back into himself, and it is the place where he can reclaim his mortality. The game makes the two events converge. The recovery of wholeness and the recovery of death are one movement, and the ending turns on Heidegger's own phrase: to take one's dying upon oneself, *auf sich nehmen*. This is the literal content of the act this dissertation calls assumption.

Guilt as ground. In §58 Heidegger defines existential guilt (*Schuldigsein*) as "being the ground of a nullity" (*Grundsein einer Nichtigkeit*). Dasein never lays its own ground, since it is thrown, yet it must exist as that ground. The Nameless One's situation literalizes this structure twice over. He did not lay the ground of his condition: a former self did, and he inherits it as thrown. Yet he must answer for that ground as his own. His moral debts, the crimes of former selves and the deaths of the shadows, are the ontic content of an ontological structure that belongs to every finite existence.

Hegel: tarrying with the negative. Hegel had stated the principle before Heidegger, in the preface to the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807): "Aber nicht das Leben, das sich vor dem Tode scheut und von der Verwüstung rein bewahrt, sondern das ihn erträgt und in ihm sich erhält, ist das Leben des Geistes." Not the life that shrinks from death and keeps itself untouched by devastation, but the life that endures death and maintains itself in it, is the life of spirit.

Spirit, Hegel continues, wins its truth only by looking the negative in the face and tarrying with it (*Verweilen bei dem Negativen*). The Nameless One's life is precisely the life that shrinks from death, having outsourced it. By Hegel's standard it cannot become the life of spirit until it endures its own death.

The master–slave dialectic sharpens the point. For Hegel, self-consciousness achieves recognition only by risking its life in the struggle for recognition. A being that cannot risk his life cannot enter that struggle. The Nameless One stands outside the dialectic of recognition altogether, and his reclaimed mortality is also his entry into it.

Levinas's correction. Emmanuel Levinas objected to Heidegger on two counts:

- Death is not my ownmost possibility but the impossibility of all possibility: the absolutely other, which comes to me and cannot be assumed or mastered (*Le Temps et l'Autre*, 1947).
- The first death is not mine but the other's. My primary relation to death is responsibility for the death of the other person, a responsibility that precedes ontology (*Dieu, la mort et le temps*, 1975–1976).

In *Otherwise than Being* (1974), Levinas pushed this responsibility to the point of substitution: the self as hostage, the one-for-the-other.

The Nameless One's condition is the exact inversion of Levinasian substitution: it is the *other-for-the-one*. The game's resolution requires both philosophers. What awakens the Nameless One to his condition is the deaths of others, the shadows, whose existence he learns of before he understands his own. That is Levinas's priority of the other's death. What he does in response is take his own death upon himself. That is Heidegger's assumption. The ethical–ontological hinge of the game can be stated as a single proposition: *the death of the other summons me to my own*. Neither philosopher states it alone; the game states it by joining them.

6.4 Torment, Drive, and the Zone Between Two Deaths

Kierkegaard: the torment of the self that cannot die. Chapter I read the game's title through *The Sickness unto Death* (1849). For Kierkegaard, despair is the sickness of a self that relates to itself wrongly. Its torment is precisely that it cannot die: the despairing self wants to consume itself and cannot, and its self-consumption is impotent.

Kierkegaard's cure names the structure of the game's resolution. The self is freed from despair when, in relating to itself and willing to be itself, it rests transparently in the power that established it. For the Nameless One, the power that established his present form was a ritual of evasion, and he cannot rest in it. What he can rest in is the finitude the ritual stole. To will to be himself is to will to be mortal.

Freud: to die in one's own fashion. *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) proposes that "das Ziel alles Lebens ist der Tod": the aim of all life is death. The organism strives to return to the inorganic state from which it came. Freud adds that the organism resists premature and external death, because "der Organismus nur auf seine Weise sterben will", it wishes to die only in its own fashion. The instincts of self-preservation, he concludes, were originally "Trabanten des Todes", attendants of death, whose task was to secure each organism's own path to its end.

The Nameless One's condition is the blockade of that path. His drive toward his own death has been denied its object. What returns in place of the blocked death is repetition: the compulsive recurrence of the pilgrimage, which Chapter II read through Freud's paper on remembering and repeating. The game's plot is the death drive seeking its proper form. His quest is to die in his own fashion, as opposed to the fashion the ritual imposed on the multiverse.

Freud: the shadow of the object. Freud's earlier paper "Trauer und Melancholie" (1917) supplies the game's master image with uncanny exactness. In mourning, the libido gradually withdraws from a lost object through reality-testing. In melancholia, the ego identifies with the lost object, and its self-reproaches are really reproaches directed at the object. Freud's formula is: "Der Schatten des Objekts fiel so auf das Ich." Thus the shadow of the object fell upon the ego.

In *Torment* the shadows of the lost literally fall upon the protagonist. The Fortress of Regrets is the architecture of the melancholic ego: a place where the dead are not mourned but introjected, crowding a self that cannot let them go because it cannot acknowledge what they cost. The resolution is the work of mourning completed. Its reality-testing has two contents: the dead are dead, and I am mortal.

Lacan: between two deaths. In his seminar on the ethics of psychoanalysis (1959–1960), Lacan distinguished biological death from symbolic death. He read Antigone as a figure situated "between two deaths" (*entre deux morts*), condemned to a living entombment. Slavoj Žižek later extended the concept to explain why, in literature and film, the dead return: they come back because they were not properly buried, because a symbolic debt remains unpaid and the rite that would have inscribed their death in the order of meaning was never performed (Žižek 1989).

The Nameless One occupies the zone between two deaths in inverted form. He is biologically unable to die yet symbolically dead: nameless, without a place in any order of meaning, a man whose death has never been registered. The shadows occupy the same zone in its classical form. Their deaths were real, but they were never inscribed. They have no names, no rites, no record, and no acknowledgment that they died for someone. They return because a debt is owed.

Here the game's discarded working title regains its full weight. The project began as *Last Rites* (Chapter I). The last rites the narrative owes are not the protagonist's alone but those of the multitudes who died unnamed in his place. His final act performs them. Ending the mechanism and accepting judgment acknowledges their deaths as his debt, and so inscribes them. The game's first title named the symbolic obligation its ending discharges.

6.5 The Political Theology of the Deathless

The king never dies. Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed the medieval and early modern doctrine that the king has a mortal body natural and an immortal body politic, and that the dignity of kingship does not die. Blackstone stated the doctrine with classical economy: "The king never dies. Henry, Edward, or George may die; but the king survives them all" (*Commentaries* I.7, 1765).

Blackstone adds that the legal term for a king's death, *demise*, "signifies merely a transfer." In law, the demise of the crown means that, through the separation of the king's natural body from his body politic, the kingdom is "transferred or demised to his successor."

The Nameless One is the doctrine of the two bodies in pathological form. The formula fits him precisely: the Good, the Paranoid, and the Practical may die, but the Nameless One survives them all. His two bodies are inverted. His body natural never dies, while his mortality has become a separate body with its own will, its own domain in the

Fortress, and its own subjects in the shadows. And the legal double meaning of *demise* is the exact name of his condition. His demise is a demise: each death is a transfer. What is transferred is not a kingdom to an heir but death itself, to a stranger.

The sovereign exception. Chapter IV read the Lady of Pain through Carl Schmitt's definition of the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception (1922). The first incarnation's bargain with Ravel was such a decision within the domain of mortality: a decision to exempt one being from the law that binds all others. He made himself the exception to death, and he did so, by his own account, for the sake of the law he had broken: to have time to make amends. Schmitt's sovereign suspends the legal order in order to save it; the first incarnation suspended death in order to atone. In both cases the exception is justified by the norm it suspends, and paid for by those outside it.

Bare life. Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) recovered from Roman law an obscure figure defined by the grammarian Festus: "At homo sacer is est, quem populus iudicavit ob maleficium; neque fas est eum immolari, sed qui occidit, parricidi non damnatur." The sacred man is one whom the people have judged for a crime; it is not permitted to sacrifice him, but whoever kills him is not condemned for homicide.

Agamben reads *homo sacer* as the originary figure of "bare life": life that may be killed without the killing counting as either homicide or sacrifice, life included in the political order only through its exposure to death. He argues that the sovereign and *homo sacer* are symmetrical. The sovereign is the one before whom all are potentially *homines sacri*, and *homo sacer* is the one before whom all act as sovereigns. His modern paradigm is the Nazi concentration camp, where the SS reduced its prisoners to bare life and killed them without the killing counting, in the regime's own terms, as either crime or sacrifice. For that reason he rejects the word "holocaust," with its sense of a burnt offering, for the extermination of Europe's Jews. The comparison drawn here is structural; it implies no moral equivalence between a game's premise and the camps.

The shadows are bare life in the most exact sense fiction allows. Their deaths are not homicides, because no one kills them; they die by the operation of a mechanism. They are not sacrifices either, because no rite consecrates them and no community receives their deaths as offerings. They are killed without murder and without meaning. And the Nameless One stands in the sovereign's position: he is the one relative to whom every living being in the multiverse is a potential shadow. His persistence reproduces, inside a single biography, the structure Agamben found at the foundation of Western politics.

The scapegoat without a crowd. René Girard's theory of sacrifice (*La Violence et le sacré*, 1972) holds that archaic communities resolve crises of mimetic rivalry by uniting against a single victim, whose death restores peace and is then veiled by myth. In *Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde* (1978), Girard argued that the Gospels reveal the victim's innocence and so make the sacrificial mechanism untenable.

The Nameless One's case is a scapegoat mechanism privatized. It has one beneficiary instead of a community, countless victims instead of one, and no crisis resolved, only a persistence prolonged. The Girardian moment of revelation is the protagonist's discovery of what the shadows are. Once he knows that his continuance is paid for by innocents, the mechanism can no longer operate in good conscience. The ending is the end of sacrifice in Girard's sense: its beneficiary refuses it once he knows it for what it is.

The god made of death. Chapter I promised that the Transcendent One would invert Feuerbach's scheme, and the inversion can now be stated.

- For Feuerbach, God is the human species' infinite essence, projected and alienated, then worshipped as another.
- For Marx, the more a person puts into God, the less they keep for themselves.

In *Torment*, what is projected and alienated is not humanity's infinitude but a man's finitude. The Transcendent One is mortality made external, independent, and domineering. It is a finitude that believes itself infinite, a death that regards itself as a god. Marx's corollary holds precisely: the more of himself the Nameless One has alienated into his separated death, the less of a self he has retained. Transcendence, in *Torment*, is made of alienated death.

Nietzsche supplies the mechanism by which such a being grows. In the second essay of the *Genealogy of Morals* (§19), he argues that a community's sense of indebtedness to its founding ancestor grows with the community's power and duration. The debt accumulates until the ancestor, feared and propitiated across generations, is finally transfigured into a god. The Transcendent One is the Nameless One's ancestor in exactly this sense: the mortality of the first incarnation, the founder of his line of selves. It has grown into a quasi-divine power through millennia of accumulated, unpaid debt. The god of the game is a creditor.

6.6 The Ledger: Debt, Externality, and the Anti-Christian Stroke

Nietzsche's genealogy of debt. In the same essay, Nietzsche derives the moral concept of guilt (*Schuld*) from the material concept of debt (*Schulden*). The oldest relationship is between creditor and debtor, and it rests on an equivalence between injury and pain: the creditor who cannot be repaid is compensated by the right to make the debtor suffer (GM II §§4–8). Nietzsche calls it Christianity's stroke of genius (§21) that God resolved humanity's unpayable debt by paying it himself: "der Gläubiger sich für seinen Schuldner opfernd", the creditor sacrificing himself for his debtor.

The Nameless One performs the anti-Christian stroke. He is a debtor who has made others pay. His unpayable debt, the crime that damned his first incarnation, was not discharged but deferred, and the deferral is financed by strangers. He deferred it, as he understood it, in order to pay it: immortality was to be the time in which he would work it off. The deferral meant to make repayment possible became a new debt, owed to the people who financed it. The game's resolution reverses the stroke without restoring the Christian original. No creditor sacrifices himself for the debtor. The debtor pays his own debt. That is Anselm's logic stripped of its theology: satisfaction is made by the one who ought to make it.

The indebted subject. David Graeber's history of debt (2011) showed how deeply the language of morality is shaped by the language of obligation and repayment. Maurizio Lazzarato's *La fabrique de l'homme endetté* (2011) argued that debt is a technology for producing subjects: the indebted person is formed by the promise to repay, and his future is mortgaged to a past he did not choose. The Nameless One is the indebted man in extreme form, with one difference that defines him. His creditors have been paying.

Externality. Economics supplies the most precise modern name for this arrangement. A. C. Pigou defined an externality as a cost or benefit that an agent's activity imposes on others without compensation, so that private and social cost diverge (Pigou 1920). Ronald Coase stressed that such problems are reciprocal and that their resolution depends on how rights and liabilities are assigned (Coase 1960).

The Nameless One's persistence is the purest externality imaginable. His private benefit is continued life; its social cost is death borne by others; nothing compensates the difference. The Guvners' loophole (Chapter IV) is its legal form. Schrödinger's negentropy is its thermodynamic form. The Buddhist ledger error of Chapter II is its karmic form. And Sigil's necro-economy (Chapter I), in which the dead are collected, sold,

and put to work, is the civic landscape in which he, the city's most extreme beneficiary, walks unaware. On this reading, the ending internalizes the externality: the one who benefited now bears the cost.

6.7 From Makropulos to the Lorry Driver: Regret

Bernard Williams wrote two essays that bracket this chapter.

The first, "The Makropulos Case" (1973), argued that immortality would be unbearable for a being with a stable character. Over endless time, the categorical desires that give life its point would be exhausted, or the character would change so much that the survivor would no longer be the one whose desires were satisfied.

The second, "Moral Luck" (1976), introduced *agent-regret*. A lorry driver who, through no fault of his own, runs over a child feels something different from what a spectator feels, even a spectator who is sure the driver was not to blame. The driver's regret attaches to his agency even where his will was innocent. It is a first-person regret about what he did, not merely about what happened, and it may reasonably issue in a desire to make amends.

Torment moves from the first essay to the second. The Nameless One escapes Makropulos tedium, and he escapes it by forgetting. With each death his desires are renewed because his memory is erased. This yields a taxonomy of three immortalities:

- **Immortality with memory yields tedium.** This is the Makropulos case, Williams's argument, and Borges's City of the Immortals.
- **Immortality without memory yields repetition.** This is Freud's compulsion, the Nameless One's pilgrimage recurring without recollection.
- **Immortality financed by others yields guilt.** This is allothanasia, the Nameless One's actual condition once he learns what his returns cost.

The third is the condition of the lorry driver raised to cosmic scale. The Nameless One is the agent of harms his will did not choose: crimes committed by selves he does not remember, and deaths caused by a mechanism he did not build. Williams's point is that such harms still belong to the agent, and that regret, not mere sorrow, is the fitting response.

The Fortress of Regrets is the architecture of agent-regret. It is built, the fiction says, from the protagonist's regrets and anchored by them. It is where the shadows gather and where the former selves wait.

This explains why "regret" is the answer to Ravel's question most often associated with the game, and why it is necessary but not sufficient. Regret is the affective form of recognizing allothanasia: the emotion of a self that discovers others have paid for it. Regret alone, however, is melancholia (§6.4). It is the shadow of the object falling on the ego and staying there. It changes the nature of a man only when it becomes action, when agent-regret issues, as Williams said it might, in the desire to make amends, and then in the making of them. The first incarnation is the game's proof that even this is not enough. He is remorse in person, and his remorse did issue in a desire to make amends. But he sought amends by postponing his sentence rather than bearing it, and the postponement produced the shadows. Regret that tries to buy time instead of paying its debt does not escape allothanasia; it creates it. Regret is the gate. What passes through it is the subject of Chapter VIII.

6.8 Conclusion: The One Who Walks Toward

Le Guin's parable ends with the ones who walk away from Omelas. They cannot accept a happiness bought with a child's misery, so they leave the city, alone, toward a place the narrator cannot describe. Their refusal is admirable, and it has a limit that critics have long noted: the child stays in the basement. Walking away preserves the walker's innocence and leaves the arrangement intact. Ivan Karamazov's gesture has the same structure. He returns his ticket, but the harmony he refuses goes on without him.

The Nameless One's ending is the exact inversion of Omelas. He does not walk away from the arrangement; he dismantles it. He is not a citizen who discovers the child in the basement. He is the city: the one whose persistence is the arrangement's purpose and beneficiary. For him, walking away is impossible, since wherever he goes the mechanism goes with him. The only act that ends it is to take his death back, and the only direction open to him is toward the Blood War to which his first incarnation's crime condemned him. He is not the one who walks away but the one who walks toward. His first incarnation tried to atone by staying; the last atones by going.

The genealogy of §6.2 closes accordingly:

- **Admetus becomes Heracles.** By reclaiming his mortality, the Nameless One ceases to be the man who accepted another's death and becomes the one who wrestles Death and returns the dead. In the Fortress, the companions who have fallen may be restored.

- **The Servant's formula is set right.** Those wounded for his transgressions are released, and the transgressor bears his own stripes.
- **The last rites are performed.** The unnamed dead receive the only acknowledgment the game can give them: their deaths are recognized as a debt and paid.
- **Gilgamesh comes home.** At the close of the epic, having lost the plant of rejuvenation to a serpent, Gilgamesh returns to Uruk and shows the boatman its walls. He accepts his mortality and turns to what mortals build. The Nameless One cannot return to any city. His equivalent of the walls of Uruk is the battlefield of the Blood War, which he enters as the first place in the multiverse that is truly his own: the place his deeds have earned.

The structure analyzed in this chapter does not stop at the edge of the fiction. The medium in which *Torment* is played has its own economy of resurrection, and its own unseen donors.

CHAPTER



VII

LUDIC ALLOTHANASIA

The Player, the Save, and the Ethics of the Respawn

7.1 A Short History of Resurrection in Games

The video game inherited from its earliest commercial form an economy of lives. In the arcade, a "life" was a unit: countable, fungible, displayed in the corner of the screen as a row of icons. When the lives ran out, the screen offered a continue, with a countdown, and a new supply of lives could be bought with a coin. The arcade's continue screen was a *memento mori* with a price list. Resurrection was purchased, and its currency was the player's money.

Home consoles turned lives into collectibles. The "1-UP" became a reward scattered through the world, most famously the green mushroom of *Super Mario Bros.* (1985). By the later 1980s, passwords and battery-backed saves let players resume progress across sessions, and the personal-computer role-playing game made saving and loading nearly unrestricted. Over two decades the respawn became free. More exactly, its currency changed. What the player spends to return after death is no longer money but time: minutes of repetition, hours of play, portions of a finite life.

The formula this dissertation proposes for *Torment* can now be stated in the medium's own idiom. Every resurrection of the Nameless One is a 1-UP debited from someone else's account.

7.2 The Magic Circle and the Weightless Death

Game studies has theorized the weightlessness of in-game death through the concept of the magic circle.

- **Huizinga.** Johan Huizinga defined play as an activity separate from ordinary life, bounded in time and space, governed by rules, and pursued for its own sake (*Homo Ludens*, 1938).
- **Caillois.** Roger Caillois classified play into *agōn* (competition), *alea* (chance), *mimicry* (simulation), and *ilinx* (vertigo), and emphasized that play is separate, uncertain, unproductive, rule-governed, and make-believe (*Les jeux et les hommes*, 1958).
- **Salen and Zimmerman.** They made Huizinga's "magic circle" the standard term for the boundary within which a game's meanings hold (Salen and Zimmerman 2004).
- **Juul.** Jesper Juul analyzed video games as "half-real," composed of real rules and fictional worlds (Juul 2005). He later described the paradox of failure: we seek out

> activities that make us feel inadequate, because games offer a space where failure is instructive and safe (Juul 2013).

Within this framework, the respawn seals the magic circle. It guarantees that death inside the game carries no weight outside it. The avatar dies so that the player can learn without dying. Death becomes pedagogy, and the medium's most characteristic lesson, try again, depends on its being free. In most games this arrangement is ethically inert. No one pays for the avatar's return except the player, and the player pays only in time.

7.3 Torment's Diegetic Death and the Mimesis of Externality

Torment breaks this arrangement at the level of fiction while preserving it at the level of rules.

Diegetic death. For most of the game, the protagonist's death in combat returns him, within the fiction, to a resting place such as the Mortuary slab where the game began. Only a handful of narrative events end the game outright. The medium's most normalized mechanic is thereby explained by the story. The respawn is not a convention the fiction ignores but the premise it is built on. Clint Hocking coined "ludonarrative dissonance" for the conflict between what a game's rules reward and what its story asserts (Hocking 2007). *Torment* is the paradigm of the opposite: ludonarrative consonance, in which the rules enact the fiction's central fact.

The gap. The consonance, however, is incomplete in a way that turns out to matter. Within the fiction, every resurrection costs a life elsewhere. Within the rules, death carries little or no penalty. The rules also do not reimpose, at each gameplay death, the amnesia the backstory attaches to dying. The player therefore experiences the protagonist's deaths as cheap while knowing that the fiction declares them expensive.

One could call this gap a failure of integration. It is better read as mimesis. The gap reproduces, at the level of play, the exact phenomenology of an externality. The cost exists but is borne offscreen, by people the beneficiary never meets, and nothing in the beneficiary's own experience registers it. The player who lets the protagonist die carelessly and walks on from the Mortuary stands, in miniature, where the first incarnation stood: benefiting from resurrection whose price is invisible to the one who benefits.

Ian Bogost argued that games persuade through procedural rhetoric, through the arguments carried by their rules as well as their representations (Bogost 2007). *Torment*'s procedural argument is carried by the conjunction of a free procedure and a costly fic-

tion. Together they say: this is what an externality feels like from the inside, which is to say it feels like nothing at all.

7.4 The Player as Alcestis

The deeper substitution in *Torment* runs across the boundary of the fiction.

The Nameless One's continuity, across every session, every death, and every return, has an extradiegetic substrate: the player's time. Each hour spent in the game is an hour of a finite human life, given so that a fictional immortal may persist. Seneca warned that life is not short but made short by waste: "non accepimus brevem vitam sed fecimus, nec inopes eius sed prodigi sumus", we are not given a short life but make it short, and we are not poor in it but wasteful (*De Brevitate Vitae* 1.3). One need not share Seneca's severity to see the structure. The avatar's deathlessness is sustained by the player's mortality.

Chapter I cited Avellone's axiom that nearly everything in *Torment* was made to concern the player. Read in the light of allothanasia, the axiom has a second meaning. Everything in the game concerns the player, including its costs.

The player gives more than time. Coleridge described the reader's contribution to fiction as "that willing suspension of disbelief for the moment, which constitutes poetic faith" (*Biographia Literaria*, ch. XIV, 1817). In Planescape's own metaphysics, belief is a source of power: the Powers are sustained by worship. By that logic the game is a Power fed by the faith of its players. Its persistence beyond its commercial life shows it: fan patches, restorations, an *Enhanced Edition*, spiritual successors, and a scholarly afterlife of which this dissertation is part. The player donates both finitude and faith.

Yet the player differs from the shadows in one decisive respect. The player consents. The shadows are conscripted; the player volunteers, choosing to give part of a life to the protagonist's continuation. In the terms of §6.2, the player is not a shadow but Alcestis: the one who consents to die a little so that another may live. The ending then plays Heracles to the player. When the Nameless One reclaims his mortality, the game ends, and the time it had been consuming is returned. The protagonist's acceptance of death is also the player's release. Ludic finitude and existential finitude coincide: the session ends because its hero accepts his end.

7.5 The Player as Practical Incarnation

The player also occupies a second position, less innocent than the first.

The player can save, reload, and replay. Saving and reloading let the player carry knowledge from a failed branch into a successful one: to learn in one timeline what a character wants, then reload and exploit it in another. Replaying lets the player begin a new life of the protagonist while remembering the old. In both cases the player possesses exactly what the Nameless One lacks: memory across incarnations.

The player is thus the protagonist's allomnesic prosthesis in its purest form, the external memory on which his continuity depends. The player is the tattoo and the journal. And in using that memory strategically, the player becomes the Practical Incarnation: a former self who carries knowledge forward and deploys it to steer a present self and the people around him. Chapter II called the Practical's work prosthetic R, the engineered continuity of intention across a rupture. Every player who replays *Torment* engineers it too. There is one memory this prosthesis can never hold: on the path where the Nameless One recovers his true name, the game gives it to him and withholds it from the player (§2.7).

The reload has a further ontological dimension. Chapter II invoked Leibniz's Palace of the Fates and Borges's garden of forking paths to describe the game's modal structure. Each reload annihilates a possible world: the branch in which a conversation went badly, a companion died, or a choice was made and then regretted. The inhabitants of that branch are "forgotten" by the game as thoroughly as the Nameless One's former selves are forgotten by him, and their only memory survives in the player. *Torment*'s fiction, in which whole incarnations are erased and survive only in others' recollection, models the player's power over timelines with unsettling accuracy. The game does not thematize this power directly. Its fiction nonetheless holds up a mirror to it.

7.6 A Comparative Ludography

Later games have taken up the ethics of the respawn and the structures of allomnesia and allothanasia, some in *Torment*'s direct line, others by convergence. The following table sets out the most significant.

Work	Death and return	Who bears the cost	Relation to *Torment*
Blood Omen: Legacy of Kain **(1996)**	A vampire protagonist's final choice: die to restore a dying world, or refuse and rule	The world, if he refuses	Sacrifice offered and refused; *Torment*'s ending accepts it
Xenogears **(1998)**	Reincarnation across millennia; a dissociated second self; a beloved who recurs in each age	The lovers and selves who recur with him	Serial selves and a recurring beloved, without the debt
Legacy of Kain: Soul Reaver **(1999)**	Death shifts the protagonist to a spectral realm; he sustains himself by devouring souls	Consumed souls; a god later revealed as parasitic on the cycle of souls	Soul-consumption as mechanic, not yet as guilt
Star Wars: Knights of the Old Republic II **(2004)**	Darth Nihilus persists by consuming the life of worlds; the Exile is described by Kreia as a wound in the Force	Worlds; the soldiers killed at Malachor V on the Exile's order	Avellone's author-function returning to the allothanatic figure
Fallout: New Vegas – Dead Money **(2010)**	A story built around the refusal to let go	Those trapped by the Sierra Madre	Letting go as the moral of persistence
Undertale **(2015)**	Saving and resetting are diegetic powers ("determination"); the game remembers erased timelines	The inhabitants of erased timelines	The respawn's moral cost made explicit
NieR: Automata **(2017)**	Androids restored from memory backups; a final choice to delete one's own save to help strangers	The player, voluntarily	The player's persistence surrendered for anonymous others
Torment: Tides of Numenera **(2017)**	A god who persists by abandoning bodies that wake as "castoffs"	The castoffs	Allothanasia's structural sequel
Disco Elysium **(2019)**	An amnesiac detective; beliefs internalized in a "Thought Cabinet"; skills as inner voices	The detective's past self	Allomnesia, and doctrine as equipment
Outer Wilds **(2019)**	A time loop in which only the ship's log and the player's knowledge persist	No one; the universe itself ends	Finitude accepted rather than escaped
Hades **(2020)**	Death returns the divine protagonist home, to be welcomed and questioned	No one	Repetition without cost; repetition "forward"

Four cases deserve comment.

Undertale. Toby Fox's *Undertale* is the medium's most direct confrontation with the ethics of the respawn. Its fiction names the player's power to save "determination," and grants that power first to an antagonist who has used it to reset the world out of boredom. Its characters remember what the player erased: a sequence of killings undone by a reset is not forgotten, and a player who commits them leaves a permanent

mark on later endings. Where *Torment* shows the cost of resurrection within the fiction and leaves the player's reload untouched, *Undertale* extends the cost to the reload itself. It is the most rigorous heir to the problem *Torment* posed.

NieR: Automata. Yoko Taro's game performs the ludic counterpart of thanatic oikeiōsis. Its androids persist through memory backups, so death is a data-management problem, and its final ending offers the player a choice. The player may help an anonymous stranger through the last trial at the cost of permanently deleting their own save data. The accumulated record of their play, the player's persistence within the game, is surrendered for people they will never meet. It is the exchange of self and other (Chapter IV) enacted by the player. It also reverses the Nameless One's original bargain: persistence given up for anonymous others rather than taken from them.

Torment: Tides of Numenera. The spiritual successor, led by McComb, extends allothanasia into a new configuration. Its Changing God persists by moving his consciousness from body to body, and each abandoned body wakes with a mind of its own, a "castoff" orphaned by its maker's persistence. The Nameless One was one body with many serial minds. The Changing God is one mind leaving many orphaned bodies behind. The game's governing question, what one life matters, is Ravel's question translated into the arithmetic of substitution.

Outer Wilds. Mobius Digital's game offers the most philosophically serene resolution in the genre. Its protagonist is caught in a time loop that ends each cycle with the sun's explosion. Nothing persists across loops except the ship's log, an allomnesic record of discoveries, and the player's own knowledge. The loop cannot be broken by defeating death. The game resolves by accepting the end of the universe and witnessing a new one begin. It is the Doomguard's thesis redeemed: finitude accepted not as defeat but as the condition of what comes after.

A final observation concerns the author-function (§0.2). In *Knights of the Old Republic II* (2004), Avellone's next major work, the allothanatic figure returns twice. Darth Nihilus is a being of pure hunger who sustains himself by consuming the life of entire worlds. The protagonist, the Exile, was the Republic general who at the battle of Malachor V gave the order, with a nod to the engineer Bao-Dur, to fire a superweapon that destroyed the Mandalorian fleet and killed thousands of her own soldiers with it. The weight of those deaths cut her off from the Force, and her mentor Kreia describes her as a wound in the Force formed by them. The recurrence confirms that the structure this dissertation calls allothanasia is not an incidental premise but a signature of the practice the attribution "Avellone and McComb" names.

7.7 The Medium's Confession

Miguel Sicart argued that players are ethical agents, and that games are ethical objects whose designs invite, constrain, and shape moral reasoning (Sicart 2009). Janet Murray identified agency, immersion, and transformation as the aesthetic pleasures of digital narrative. She also observed that such narratives can explore multiple versions of a story, letting readers rehearse choices and their consequences (Murray 1997). Espen Aarseth defined ergodic literature as text whose traversal requires nontrivial effort from the reader (Aarseth 1997). Alexander Galloway insisted that games are actions before they are texts (Galloway 2006), and Mary Flanagan showed how games can serve as instruments of critical practice (Flanagan 2009).

Each framework captures part of what *Torment* achieves. None captures its specific contribution, which is best described as a confession. The medium's most normalized mechanic, the free return from death on which its whole pedagogy of failure depends, is shown to have a cost. The confession is not made in a manifesto or a mechanic. It is made in a fiction whose central premise is the respawn and whose central revelation is its price.

The game does not abolish the respawn; it could not, and remain what it is. It does something subtler. It gives the respawn a meaning, and that meaning sets the player in a double position. The player is Alcestis, freely giving part of a finite life to sustain an immortal, and is released when the immortal accepts death. The player is also the Practical Incarnation, carrying memory across erased lives and wielding it over the living. The ending addresses both. When the Nameless One takes his death upon himself, the game ends. Alcestis's time is returned, and the Practical's knowledge has nothing left to steer.

Conclusion to Chapter VII

The argument of the last two chapters can be condensed into three propositions:

1. **Within the fiction,** the Nameless One's deathlessness is allothanasia: an economy in which one persistence is financed by many anonymous and unconsenting deaths. The game reconstructs that economy through the full range of the Western and Buddhist traditions of substitution, and resolves it by reversing the substitution.
2. **At the level of play,** the gap between a free respawn and a costly fiction is not a flaw but a mimesis of externality. It gives the player the experience of benefiting from a cost that is borne elsewhere and felt by no one who benefits.

3. **Across the boundary of the fiction,** the player is the protagonist's donor twice over. The player gives time, as a finite being sustaining an immortal, and memory, as the external record of his lives. The player is Alcestis and the Practical Incarnation at once, and the ending releases one and disarms the other.

What remains is to construct from these materials the concept that answers them. Allomnesia names the self whose past is held by others. Allothanasia names the self whose death is borne by others. The question the final chapter must answer is what it means for such a self to take back what others have held and borne: not as a return to an origin that cannot be recovered, but as an act that changes, in Ravel's words, the nature of a man.

CHAPTER



VIII

THANATIC OIKEIŌSIS

Toward an Ethics of Reappropriated Finitude

8.1 The Problem Restated

The preceding chapters converge on a single structure. The Nameless One is a self expropriated twice over:

- **His past is held by others.** It survives in ink he cannot read, in companions who remember what he has forgotten, and in lovers and victims who carry him as devotion or grievance. This is allomnesia (Chapter II).
- **His death is borne by others.** Anonymous substitutes die in his place, and their shades return to hunt him. This is allothanasia (Chapter VI).

Over seven chapters, the game has ruled out every answer that philosophy and its own factions offer to such a self:

- **Memory** cannot restore him. Most of his past cannot be recovered, and the Lockean criterion would acquit him rather than transform him (Chapter II).
- **Belief** is not enough. It persists unchanged in Vhailor and hardens in the Transcendent One (Chapter III).
- **Doctrine** cannot contain him. Every faction finds in him its counterexample (Chapter IV).
- **No single virtue** answers the question. Each companion embodies only part of an answer (Chapter V).
- **Regret** is the gate, not the passage. Left to itself it is melancholia (Chapter VI).
- **Extinction**, the Dustmen's True Death, would end his torment and leave the ledger unpaid (Chapter IV).
- **Self-mutilation**, Oedipus's blinding, would punish without ending the harm (Chapter II).
- **Flight**, the path of those who walk away from Omelas, would leave the mechanism running (Chapter VI).

Whatever remains must meet four conditions:

1. It cannot depend on recovering presence. The game never specifies his original crime, and the name he can recover on one optional path changes nothing about what the ending requires of him.
2. It cannot depend on metaphysical identity, because the game grants Parfit's metaphysics.

3. It cannot be extinction, because a self must remain to bear what it takes back.
4. It must release those who bore the self's costs.

This chapter argues that one concept meets all four. It reconstructs that concept from Stoic sources, defends it against four objections, and offers it as the game's answer to Ravel's question.

8.2 The Stoic Doctrine of Oikeiōsis

The Greek *oikeiōsis* comes from *oikos*, "household," by way of *oikeios*: "belonging to the household," and so "one's own," "akin," "familiar." It names the process by which a living being comes to regard something as belonging to it. Cicero rendered it in Latin as *conciliatio* and *commendatio*, a being's being commended and reconciled to itself.

Reconstructed from Chrysippus as Diogenes Laertius reports him (VII.85–86) and from Cato's exposition in Cicero's *De Finibus* (III.16–22, 62–68), the Stoic doctrine has two stages.

First stage: self-appropriation. From birth, the Stoics held, nature makes each animal its own. It is attached to itself and to the preservation of its constitution, and its first impulse is toward self-preservation, not toward pleasure as the Epicureans claimed. Seneca adds that every animal has a sense of its own constitution before it knows anything else (*Epistulae* 121).

Second stage: the good and its extension. As reason develops, a human being discovers something that is not among the first objects of impulse: the good. The good consists in consistency (*homologia*, *convenientia*), in living in agreement with nature. Once discovered, it is valued above everything first sought (*De Finibus* III.20–21).

The same development reaches outward. Parental love is the natural seed of a concern that, when cultivated, embraces kin, then fellow citizens, then humankind. The world, Cato says, is a city shared by gods and men (*De Finibus* III.64). The Stoic Hierocles gave the doctrine its most memorable image. Each of us stands at the center of concentric circles: self, household, kin, fellow citizens, the human race. The task of ethics is to draw the outer circles toward the center, to treat the distant as near (Stobaeus 4.27.23). Marcus Aurelius compressed the social consequence into one line: "*Τὸ τῷ σμήνει μὴ συμφέρον οὐδὲ τῇ μελίσσῃ συμφέρει.*" What does not benefit the hive does not benefit the bee (*Meditations* VI.54).

The first incarnation's error. The doctrine also diagnoses the first incarnation, though not in the way one might expect. Oikeiōsis is meant to develop. The impulse toward self-preservation is natural and innocent, but it must be surpassed by the recognition of the good, and the good includes consistency with a nature that brings death. Marcus is explicit: death is a work of nature, and whoever fears a work of nature "is a child" (*παιδίον ἐστί*, *Meditations* II.12).

The first incarnation did not stop at the first stage. The game shows that he reached the second: he recognized the good and judged himself by it, finding his crime so grave that no lifetime of good deeds could undo it. The Good Incarnation, whose shade waits in the Fortress of Regrets, is that recognition in person. His error lay in what he did next. He pursued the good by the means of the first stage, making his own continuance the condition of his repentance, and asked Ravel for the time that atonement seemed to need.

The Stoics denied that the good needs time. On their view a virtuous life is complete at any moment, and a longer one is not thereby happier (Cicero, *De Finibus* III.45–48). Seneca put the point as a theatrical maxim: "Quomodo fabula, sic vita: non quam diu, sed quam bene acta sit, refert," as with a play, so with life: what matters is not how long it runs but how well it is acted (*Epistulae* 77.20). By that standard the bargain rests on a category mistake. It treats continued life, which the Stoics counted among the preferred indifferents, as though it were the good, and repentance as a quantity to be accumulated rather than a disposition to be achieved.

In making it, he reversed the doctrine's direction. Hierocles asks the center to draw the outer circles inward in care. The Nameless One's center draws the lives of the outer circles into itself as fuel, and it began to do so in the name of the good. Marcus's reproach is fulfilled with grim literalness: each incarnation begins as a child, a grown body waking without knowledge, name, or past. The man who feared nature's work stays, life after life, an infant.

A philological bridge. The German vocabulary Heidegger used for the relation between Dasein and its death restates the Stoic problem. *Eigen* means "own." *Eigentlichkeit*, conventionally translated "authenticity," means "ownness." Death is Dasein's *eigenste Möglichkeit*, its "ownmost" possibility. In Stoic terms, Heidegger's thesis is that death is the most *oikeion* of all things, the one that belongs to a being more properly than anything else. The Stoics and Heidegger meet exactly where the Nameless One fails. He has made everything his own except the one thing that is most properly his.

8.3 Thanatic Oikeiōsis Defined

Thanatic oikeiōsis is the act by which a self that has externalized its finitude makes that finitude its own again, and in doing so extends its concern to those who bore it.

The act has three moments, which is the Rule of Three applied to ethics:

1. **Acknowledgment.** The self recognizes as its own what it had placed in others: the deaths the shadows bore and the memories the companions hold. This is the work regret performs (Chapter VI), and the work of mourning completing itself in Freud's sense: the dead are dead, and I am mortal. In the Fortress of Regrets it takes dramatic form, as the protagonist confronts the shades of his former selves and takes them back into himself, among them the first incarnation, whose remorse began everything.
2. **Assumption.** The self takes on liability for what it acknowledges, without the warrant of memory or metaphysical identity. This is Heidegger's *auf sich nehmen*, taking one's dying upon oneself. It is also Hegel's punishment as the criminal's own right (Chapter V, §5.8), and, as §8.5 argues, Nietzsche's sovereign responsibility.
3. **Release.** The act ends the mechanism of substitution and frees those who bore its costs. No more shadows are produced. The companions who fell in the Fortress may be restored. Dak'kon's oath becomes dischargeable (§8.6). The player's time is returned (Chapter VII).

The household reassembled. The etymology of *oikeiōsis* supplies the central image. Chapter II read the incarnations as a Humean commonwealth whose members succeed one another in office. Here a better figure is a household, an *oikos*, whose members are scattered across time and whose head has forgotten them. The Fortress of Regrets is where the household is reassembled, and the act of reassembly makes the Nameless One its head. Its founder is among the reassembled: the first incarnation, the Good, consents readily to rejoin the self. The household's founder submits to its latest member, and the man who once bought time to atone yields to the one who will pay.

Roman law gives that headship a precise legal content. Under the noxal actions Gaius describes, the head of a household was liable for wrongs committed by dependents in his power. He had a choice: "aut litis aestimationem sufferre aut noxae dedere," either to pay the assessed damages or to hand over the wrongdoer (*Institutes* IV.75).

In reassembling his household, the Nameless One becomes its *paterfamilias* and answers for its members' wrongs. He cannot pay the damages, because the dead cannot be compensated. So he surrenders the wrongdoer, and the wrongdoer is himself. The

Blood War is a noxal surrender: the *noxae deditio* of the self.

What thanatic oikeiōsis is not. Four clarifications separate the concept from its nearest neighbors.

- **It is not recovery of presence.** The crime is never specified, and the name, where he recovers it, is never shown to the player and decides nothing. What he appropriates is a liability, not an essence.
- **It is not extinction.** The self does not dissolve into the True Death. It persists into the Blood War as the bearer of its consequences.
- **It is not self-mutilation.** Oedipus blinds himself, and the blinding is also a withdrawal: he punishes the organ of knowledge and turns away from a world he can no longer bear to see. The Nameless One does the harder thing that Chapter II promised. He recovers his sight, meaning his memory and his knowledge of what his persistence cost, and walks into the world with his eyes open. From the Oedipus of the *Tyrannus* he takes the acceptance of responsibility for deeds done in ignorance, which Bernard Williams defended as a richer idea of agency than the modern one (Williams 1993). He refuses the self-mutilation that comes with it.
- **It is not flight.** Those who walk away from Omelas keep their innocence and leave the child in the basement. The Nameless One walks toward.

Two models of responsibility joined. Chapter III promised that the final act would combine Iris Marion Young's two models of responsibility (Young 2011). The act looks backward in the sense of the liability model: it accepts answerability for a crime and for deaths already caused. It looks forward in the sense of the social connection model: it ends a process that would otherwise keep producing harm. Thanatic oikeiōsis is where liability for the past becomes responsibility for the future.

Levinas and Heidegger joined. Chapter VI proposed that the game turns on one proposition: *the death of the other summons me to my own*. Thanatic oikeiōsis is that proposition enacted. Levinas's priority of the other's death motivates the act, and Heidegger's appropriation of one's own death is its content.

Derrida's *The Gift of Death* (1992) supplies the link. Responsibility, Derrida argues, is rooted in irreplaceability, and it is death, the one thing no one can undergo in my place, that makes me irreplaceable. Until the end, the Nameless One has been the most replaceable of beings: others have died for him countless times. He becomes responsible in Derrida's sense only when he makes himself irreplaceable in his death, when no one can die it for him again.

8.4 Identity Without Metaphysics: Ricoeur, Korsgaard, Arendt, Jonas

Thanatic oikeiōsis needs an account of personal identity that does not rest on the metaphysical sameness the game denies. Four thinkers supply one.

Ricoeur: selfhood as constancy. In *Oneself as Another* (1990), Paul Ricoeur distinguished two senses of identity:

- *Idem*-identity is sameness: the persistence through time of a character, a body, a set of traits.
- *Ipse*-identity is selfhood: the constancy by which a person holds herself together through change. Its paradigm is keeping one's word. A promise is kept not because the promiser is unchanged but because she holds herself to it in spite of change.

The Nameless One has almost no *idem*-identity, since his character, memory, and intentions change with each incarnation. He can still achieve *ipse*-identity. He cannot do it by keeping his own promises, which he does not remember. He does it by keeping faith with the commitments others remember on his behalf.

Ricoeur called *attestation* the assurance of being oneself acting and suffering, a confidence that is neither proof nor certainty. The ending is an act of attestation. The Nameless One does not prove that he is the man who committed the crime. He attests that he will answer for it.

Ricoeur's last major work, *Memory, History, Forgetting* (2000), adds two ideas. The first is a duty of memory owed above all to victims. The second is "difficult forgiveness," which cannot be demanded and does not erase the fault. The shadows are owed memory, and the ending pays that debt by acknowledging them. Forgiveness, as Arendt will show, is not something the protagonist can give himself.

Korsgaard: the unity of agency. Christine Korsgaard's reply to Parfit (1989) is the most direct philosophical defense of the game's position. Even if there is no deep metaphysical fact of personal identity, she argues, we must regard ourselves as unified agents, because acting requires deliberating from a single standpoint. The unity of the person is not discovered but constituted, and agency constitutes it. Her later work generalized the claim. We constitute ourselves as unified agents by acting on principles we can endorse (*Self-Constitution*, 2009). Our practical identities are descriptions under which we value ourselves and find our actions worth doing (*The Sources of Normativity*, 1996).

The Nameless One's final act constitutes, in exactly this sense, the unity metaphysics cannot provide. By taking responsibility for the whole series of his selves, he makes the series one agent. The unity is the effect of the act, not its precondition.

Arendt: punishment, forgiveness, and promise. In *The Human Condition* (1958), Arendt identified two predicaments of action and two faculties that answer them:

- Irreversibility, the inability to undo what has been done, is answered by forgiveness.
- Unpredictability is answered by the promise.

Both faculties depend on plurality. No one can forgive himself, and no one is bound by a promise made only to himself. Arendt also observed that punishment is not the opposite of forgiveness but its alternative, since both put an end to something that would otherwise go on indefinitely.

These claims fit the ending precisely. The Nameless One's deeds are irreversible, and their consequence, the endless production of shadows, would continue forever if nothing interrupted it. He cannot forgive himself; Arendt's analysis forbids it, and the game never allows it. What he can choose is the other thing that also ends the endless: punishment. The Blood War is the Arendtian alternative to a forgiveness no one is in a position to give.

If forgiveness comes at all, it comes from others. This is the plural dimension the companions supply: Morte's fidelity, Annah's love, Grace's understanding, the promises Dak'kon kept.

Jonas: from the Gnostic to the responsible. A final figure closes a circle opened in Chapter I. That chapter drew on Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958; 2nd ed. 1963) to read the Nameless One's awakening as the exile of the Gnostic soul: forgetful, thrown into an alien world, addressed by a call from outside. Two decades later the same philosopher wrote *The Imperative of Responsibility* (1979). There he argued that the reach of modern action obliges us to act so that its effects stay compatible with the continuation of genuine human life, and that responsibility is owed above all to the vulnerable and the not yet born.

The Nameless One's path from Gnostic exile to responsible agent traces Jonas's own intellectual path, from the study of a soul estranged from the world to an ethics of answering for the world one's actions touch. The shadows are effects of action incompatible with genuine life, and the ending restores the compatibility.

8.5 Four Objections and Replies

The Buddhist objection. If there is no self (*anattā*), then reclaiming one's death reinforces the illusion of selfhood. The Dustmen's True Death, the dissolution of the one who clings, would be the more consistent response.

Reply. The objection can be answered from within Buddhism. The Buddha's first sermon names three forms of craving (*taṇhā*): craving for sensual pleasure, craving for existence (*bhava-taṇhā*), and craving for non-existence (*vibhava-taṇhā*) (*Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta*, SN 56.11).

- The first incarnation's bargain with Ravel is *bhava-taṇhā* in a refined and therefore instructive form: craving for continued existence, disguised as the wish to do good. The tradition would see through the disguise; craving that attaches itself to virtue is still craving.
- The Dustmen's True Death, sought as an escape from a debt one refuses to pay, risks *vibhava-taṇhā*: craving for annihilation.

The tradition rejects both. The path between them neither clings to existence nor flees into extinction; it accepts the ripening of one's deeds. Thanatic oikeiōsis returns the karmic fruit to the stream that produced it, correcting the ledger error identified in Chapter II. It is not the self clinging to itself but the end of the self's clinging to persistence.

Chapter IV also showed that the Mahāyāna tradition's own critique of private liberation, and its practice of exchanging self and other, anticipates the game's refusal of the True Death. Pressed to its conclusion, the Buddhist objection supports the ending.

The Parfitian objection. If identity is not what matters, the present Nameless One is at most weakly connected to the first incarnation. Accepting punishment for that incarnation's crime is then irrational, even unjust: one person punished for another's deed.

Reply. Four considerations answer it.

- **Korsgaard's argument.** Whatever the metaphysics, the unity of agency is constituted in practice, and the act of assumption constitutes it (§8.4).
- **The harm is ongoing.** The shadows are not only the first incarnation's victims. They are victims of a mechanism the present Nameless One sustains by continuing to live as he does. His responsibility for that continuing harm requires no identity with the original criminal. It is structural and forward-looking in Young's sense.

- **Agent-regret.** Williams's agent-regret shows that responsibility reaches beyond the voluntary, to what one's agency has caused even where one's will was innocent (Chapter VI).
- **Parfit's own liberation.** Most strikingly, the ending is Parfitian in spirit even as it rejects Parfit's discount on desert. Parfit reported that his reductionism changed his life. Life had seemed to him a glass tunnel through which he moved toward death. When he came to believe that identity is not what matters, the walls of the tunnel disappeared, and he found himself less concerned with the rest of his own life and more concerned with the lives of others (Parfit 1984, Part Three).

The Nameless One's ending enacts that liberation. He gives up the fetish of his own persistence, which his first incarnation had made the condition of his repentance, for the sake of others. What the objection calls irrational self-punishment is the practical form of the reductionist's release from the tyranny of self-continuation.

The Foucauldian objection. On this view the ending is an apology for the penal order. It shows a subject who internalizes guilt and submits to punishment, the soul becoming, in Foucault's phrase from *Discipline and Punish* (1975), the prison of the body. The Blood War is a cosmic penitentiary, and the game celebrates the confessing, self-sentencing subject that modern disciplinary power produces.

Reply. Three considerations answer it.

- **The Blood War is not a disciplinary institution.** It does not normalize, observe, or correct; it is a war. The Nameless One's entry into it is not submission to a normalizing gaze but a refusal to keep pushing his costs onto others.
- **Nietzsche distinguished two relations to responsibility.** Nietzsche is the objection's own ancestor. On one side is the bad conscience: cruelty turned inward, the sickness of an animal forced to discharge its instincts against itself (GM II §16). On the other is the "sovereign individual" (*das souveraine Individuum*), the being entitled to make promises, for whom responsibility is not guilt but "das stolze Wissen um das ausserordentliche Privilegium der Verantwortlichkeit," the proud knowledge of the extraordinary privilege of responsibility (GM II §2). The Nameless One's final act belongs to the second type. He takes on responsibility not as a sickness imposed on him but as a privilege he claims, the first act of a self that has earned the right to answer for itself.
- **Foucault himself answers it.** In his last lectures and books (*The Hermeneutics of the Subject*, 1981–1982; *The Care of the Self*, 1984), Foucault turned to Hellenistic and Stoic practices of self-formation: *askēsis* and the care of the self (*epimeleia heautou*),

an ethics distinct from obedience to law. Thanatic oikeiōsis is a Stoic concept and belongs to that ethics. The late Foucault answers the Foucauldian objection.

The Derridean objection. Reappropriation is impossible. There is no return to presence and no recovery of what is "proper" to a self, because the proper has always already been expropriated. Every dream of appropriation (*Aneignung*, *Ereignis*, *oikeiōsis*) belongs to a metaphysics of the proper that deconstruction exposes. In *Aporias* (1993), Derrida contested even Heidegger's claim that death is "mine," arguing that my death is the least proper of my possibilities.

Reply. The game accepts the objection's premise and draws a different conclusion. It recovers no presence. The crime is never disclosed, and even the name, which he can recover, does not return him to the self he once was: the ending is the same with it or without it. The proper name can return; the proper does not. Thanatic oikeiōsis is not the appropriation of the proper as presence. It is the assumption of liability: appropriation without property.

The Stoic term itself marks the distinction. *Oikeiōsis* is affiliation, not possession. It means coming to regard something as belonging with one, as kin belong to a household, not seizing it as property. Derrida's own account of responsibility supports the ending. As §8.3 noted, *The Gift of Death* locates responsibility in the irreplaceability that death confers, and the Nameless One becomes responsible exactly when he becomes irreplaceable, not before. The objection defeats a metaphysics of presence the game never held. It leaves standing an ethics of assumption that Derrida's later work helps to ground.

8.6 The Answer to Ravel's Question

What can change the nature of a man?

The game's answer, carried by its structure rather than any single speech, can now be stated. A man's nature is changed by thanatic oikeiōsis: by his taking back what others have borne for him.

This answer does not replace the partial answers the companions offered in Chapter V. It gathers each of them as one element:

- **Regret** is the gate through which acknowledgment passes (Chapter VI).
- **Belief** is disciplined into practice, as Dak'kon's knowing requires, so that assumption is an act and not a mood.

- **Love** becomes possible, because a mortal can love as Diotima's lovers love, knowing there is an end.
- **Fidelity**, Morte's virtue, is kept with the memories others hold.
- **Choice**, Grace's refusal of her nature, becomes the model for refusing the nature the first incarnation chose.
- **Justice**, Vhailor's demand, is satisfied without an executioner.

The game also refutes one answer that none of the companions gives, because the protagonist's own first self gave it: time. The first incarnation believed that enough time would let him change, and he bought it at others' cost. The incarnations that followed show what endless time produced: not a changed nature but repetition, forgetting, and a lengthening ledger. Time cannot change the nature of a man. It can only defer the change, and someone else pays for the deferral.

Why does this change the protagonist's *nature* and not merely his circumstances? In Planescape, nature is not fixed. Beings are shaped by their beliefs and deeds, and the cosmos records alignment according to what one does. Aristotle held that habit forms a second nature within limits nature sets. Hegel called ethical life, once it has become habitual, "eine zweite Natur" (*Philosophy of Right* §151). Grace showed that a nature can be refused.

Since the first incarnation's bargain, the Nameless One's nature has been allothanatic: he persists by displacing death onto others. Thanatic oikeiōsis changes that nature in the most literal sense available, from deathless to mortal, from a being that consumes other people's deaths to one that bears its own. Few fictions give so exact an answer to the question of what changes a nature. The answer is a change of nature.

The common answer to Dak'kon's question. Chapter V left a question open. Should Dak'kon be released from an oath that binds him until the protagonist's death, a death that never comes? The answer is the same as the answer to Ravel. The injustice of Dak'kon's oath lay in its term, which the incarnation that accepted it knew could never arrive. By reclaiming his mortality, the Nameless One makes the term reachable. The act that pays his own debts also makes it possible, for the first time, for Dak'kon's promise to be fulfilled rather than kept forever. The protagonist's mortality is the gift that finally lets a faithful man be free.

The three planar axioms resolved. The ending also resolves the three planar axioms with which Chapter I began.

- **The Center of All.** The cosmology says every point is the center; the genre says one point is. The Nameless One's persistence bent the world around him. In giving up

that persistence, he stops being *the* center and becomes one center among all the others, one point in a multiverse where every point is the center. The genre's egocentrism dissolves into the cosmology's pluralism.

- **The Unity of Rings.** The vicious circle of death and return, the wheel of a self that persists at others' expense, becomes the virtuous circle of Hierocles, in which the center draws the outer rings toward itself in care instead of consuming them. The Unbroken Circle of Zerthimon, the scripture of liberation from the mind's masters, is completed by a liberation from the self's mastery over others.
- **The Rule of Three.** The act that achieves all this has three moments: acknowledgment, assumption, and release.

EPILOGUE



CONCLUSION

The One Who Walks Toward

This dissertation set out to reconstruct the argument of *Planescape: Torment* rather than catalogue its themes. Its findings follow the order of its chapters.

Chapter I traced the genealogy of the game's cosmos. It followed the spatialization of alignment in *AD&D* to Planescape's doxastic plasticity and factional politics. It showed that the game's founding principle, that belief constitutes reality, descends from Milton, Swedenborg, Feuerbach, and James, and departs from all of them by extending collective intentionality to brute facts. It read Sigil as a city of thresholds, a site of interrupted rites of passage, and a necro-economy. And it placed the game against the Gnostic, classical, modernist, Borgesian, and fantastic strata it triangulates.

Chapter II defined *allomnesia*, the condition of a self whose past is held by others. It showed how the game tests the Lockean forensic self and refuses its exculpation. It showed how the game stages Reid's failures of transitivity, Parfit's Relation R, and Buddhist *anattā*. And it identified the game's *prosthetic R*, which turns psychological continuity into a form of self-manipulation.

Chapter III defined *doxastic realism* and drew from it an ethics of worldmaking. Its central figures were the lie as cosmogony (Adahn), conviction without a believer (Vhailor), and the tragedy of the doxastic commons (Curst).

Chapter IV read the fifteen factions as a disputation among philosophical schools, and the protagonist as their *reductio per exemplum*: each doctrine finds in him both its perfect case and its refutation.

Chapter V read the companions as a symposium on Ravel's question, each embodying a partial answer that the ending needs.

Chapter VI defined *allothanasia*, the condition of a self whose death is borne by others. It set that condition in a genealogy of substitution running from Enkidu and Alcestis to Omelas. It showed the game to be:

- a reductio of Heidegger's counterfactual;
- a staging of Freud's blocked death drive and Lacan's zone between two deaths;
- a private reenactment of the political theology of the deathless sovereign and his bare-life victims;
- a moral Omelas, in which even a penitent's wish to atone is financed by strangers' deaths.

Chapter VII extended the diagnosis to the medium, as *ludic allothanasia*. The game turns the respawn into a moral problem. The gap between free resurrection and a costly fiction works as a mimesis of externality. And the player occupies a double position: Alcestis, the consenting donor of a finite life, and the Practical Incarnation, carrying memory across erased lives.

Chapter VIII proposed *thanatic oikeiōsis* as the concept that answers these conditions. It reconstructed the concept from the Stoic doctrine of appropriation, defended it with Ricoeur, Korsgaard, Arendt, and Jonas, and tested it against Buddhist, Parfitian, Foucauldian, and Derridean objections.

Contributions. The dissertation contributes in four ways.

- **Conceptual.** It introduces a vocabulary whose value lies in naming structures that existing concepts misdescribe: allomnesia, allothanasia, thanatic oikeiōsis, doxastic realism, prosthetic R, the mimesis of externality, and ludic allothanasia.
- **Methodological.** It proposes a *modal hermeneutics* for branching works, which locates a game's arguments in what stays fixed across paths and its questions in what varies. It treats the role-playing game as an apparatus for running thought experiments that philosophy has so far only been able to narrate.
- **Comparative.** It places *Torment* in a field of philosophical fiction running from the *Hymn of the Pearl* and the *Alcestis* to Borges, Lem, Le Guin, Wolfe, and Dick, and in a ludography running from *Soul Reaver* to *Undertale* and *NieR: Automata*.
- **For game studies.** It identifies the ethics of the respawn as a problem the medium has largely left unexamined, and reads *Torment* as the medium's first sustained confession about what its most normalized mechanic costs.

Limitations. Any interpretation of a branching text is partial. A reading built on what stays fixed across paths may underweight the texture of particular playthroughs. No claim has been made about the designers' intentions beyond what their own testimony supports. The comparative frame draws substantially on Buddhist, Daoist, and other traditions but remains weighted toward the European philosophical canon. And the dissertation offers no empirical evidence about how players actually experience the moral structure it describes.

Future research. Several lines of inquiry follow:

- empirical study of how players experience death, reloading, and consequence in games that make them part of the fiction;

- a fuller comparative analysis of *Torment: Tides of Numenera* as the structural sequel to allothanasia;
- a general ethics of the save file across genres;
- the application of these concepts beyond fiction, to arrangements in which the costs of one party's continuation are displaced onto distant, anonymous, or future others. Such arrangements are studied, under other names, in the literatures on externalities, on global and intergenerational justice, and on responsibility toward statistical victims.

The scene of awakening, revisited. A body wakes on a slab. A skull speaks. Words written on a back the body cannot see tell it to seek a journal, find a man, and hide what it is. Everything the game will argue is present in that scene: the self held by others, the death displaced onto others, the instruction to conceal. Everything it will conclude is foreshadowed by that scene's reversal.

The game's closing image places the same man, mortal at last, in the war to which his first self's crime condemned him. He carries his memory and his debts, and he no longer hides what he is. He is not one of those who walk away from Omelas, keeping their innocence and leaving the child in the basement. He is the one who walks toward. In doing so he closes the basement, empties the Fortress, releases the shadows, and gives the player back the borrowed time.

What can change the nature of a man? Taking back his death from those who have been dying it for him.

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KEYWORDS

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Planescape: Torment · Chris Avellone · Colin McComb · Black Isle Studios · Planescape · *Dungeons & Dragons* · Great Wheel · Sigil · Lady of Pain · factions · Nameless One · Transcendent One · Ravel Puzzlewell · Fortress of Regrets · Blood War · allomnesia · allothanasia · thanatic oikeiōsis · oikeiōsis · Stoicism · Hierocles · doxastic realism · doxastic commons · ethics of belief · worldmaking · personal identity · Locke · Reid · Parfit · Relation R · prosthetic R · quasi-memory · *anattā* · *Milindapañha* · extended mind · distributed cognition · transactive memory · testimony · *pharmakon* · *pharmakos* · Derrida · Stiegler · tertiary retention · mnemotechnics · Mystic Writing-Pad · repetition compulsion · Kierkegaard · repetition · recollection · anamnesis · performativity · iterability · Adahn · Heidegger · being-toward-death · mineness · Levinas · substitution · Hegel · death drive · melancholia · between two deaths · political theology · Kantorowicz · king's two bodies · Schmitt · state of exception · Agamben · *homo sacer* · bare life · Lefort · empty place of power · Girard · scapegoat · Nietzsche · genealogy of debt · sovereign individual · externality · agent-regret · Bernard Williams · Makropulos case · Alcestis · Omelas · Le Guin · Borges · Lem · Philip K. Dick · Gnosticism · *Hymn of the Pearl* · Hans Jonas · Ricoeur · *ipse*-identity · attestation · Korsgaard · self-constitution · Arendt · forgiveness and promise · Foucault · care of the self · ludic allothanasia · respawn · save and reload · mimesis of externality · ludonarrative consonance · procedural rhetoric · magic circle · modal hermeneutics · conceptual personae · computer role-playing games · philosophy of video games · game studies · memory · forgetting · despair · Freud · Lacan · second death · immortality · sovereignty

social ontology | Buddhism | Gene Wolfe | Zelazny | Moorcock | philosophical fiction | comparative literature | save systems

What can change the nature of a man?

Taking back his death from those
who have been dying it for him.